



Days of Governance



A Government for *Generations*



Singapenn Special Task Force for Women Safety



Special Task Force for Interdiction of Narcotics and Gangs (STING) - 65 Special Task Force constituted to combat drug trafficking



200 units of free electricity for domestic consumers using upto 500 units of electricity every 2 months



Thaalmaaman Thanga Mothiram Scheme Every newborn delivered in Government Hospital will receive 1 gram gold ring Rs.560 crore allocated



Annan's Seer Scheme Women will be provided with 8 gram gold coin and a silk saree for their marriage Rs.812 crore allocated



Expansion of Perunthalaivar Kamarajar Breakfast Scheme - Benefitting 15.14 lakhs additional students in Classes 6-8 across 15,414 Government and Government-aided schools. Rs.710 crore allocated



Vettri Tamil Nadu Investment Conclave 2026 Rs. 1 lakh crore investment



Special Incentive Sugarcane - Rs.4,000 per tonne Paddy - Rs.2,750 per quintal



Rs.6,000 crore crop loan waiver for farmers



717 liquor shops located near educational institutions, temples and bus stands have been closed



Vettri Housing Scheme Rs.3,500 crore allocated



Vettri Laptop Scheme for college students Rs.2,000 crore allocated



Vettri Skill Training Scheme Skill Development Training for 12 lakh students and 1 lakh youth



Vettri 150 Scheme 150 days of guaranteed employment



Modern Branded bicycles with helmets and water bottles to Class XI students in Government and Government-aided schools



TN-VETTRI : Rs.6,000 crore allocated annually to improve Water Supply, Solid Waste Management, Sanitation and Rural Connectivity



Vettri Magalir Goat Rearing Scheme 5 goats or sheep will be provided to disadvantaged women & transgenders



Honest & Transparent governance Speedy Plan Approval, Faceless Property Registration



Families shelter at a makeshift evacuation centre after the earthquake in Maumere, East Nusa Tenggara, Indonesia, on Sunday. REUTERS

Thousands evacuated after Indonesia quake kills 53; aftershocks hamper rescue efforts

Reuters
Maumere, August 16

AROUND 5,000 PEOPLE have been evacuated after a magnitude-7.7 earthquake rocked eastern Indonesia, killing at least 53, blocking roads and causing landslides, officials said Sunday.

They added that more than 130 people had been injured, many with broken bones.

Saturday’s quake was the Southeast Asian nation’s deadliest since a 2022 quake killed hundreds in West Java.

More than 3,300 people in Indonesia’s eastern Sikka region self-evacuated or were in a sports arena, according to the country’s national disaster mitigation agency, known as BNPB.

Some residents were stranded outside collapsed homes under a makeshift tent made out of tarpaulin, while others received treatment in a tent outside a hospital.

A sprawling archipelago of 290 million people, Indonesia

straddles the “Pacific Ring of Fire”, a seismically active zone where tectonic plates meet, triggering frequent earthquakes and volcanic eruptions.

At a now-closed port in Maumere, littered with debris from a collapsed roof and walls, residents told *Reuters* they were scared of aftershocks. The disaster agency said Sunday nearly a thousand aftershocks had been recorded since the quake.

Nearly, hundreds of residents filled a sports stadium, which has been designated as an evacuation spot.

As the sun was setting, residents stood in line to get warm drinks. Some mothers hooked pieces of clothing to tent frames to form makeshift cradles for their babies. Other children played soccer outside.

Margaretha Movaldes Da Maga Bapa, head of the region’s disaster mitigation agency, said the quake had brought back memories of the one residents experienced in 1992.

RUSSIA’S DEFENCE MINISTRY SAYS 822 UKRAINIAN DRONES SHOT DOWN

Kyiv launches biggest drone attack on Russia so far, kills 6

Romania downs suspected Russian drone over airspace

Associated Press
Moscow, Kyiv, August 16

UKRAINE LAUNCHED hundreds of drones across Russia on Sunday, killing at least six people in one of Kyiv’s largest aerial attacks of the war. Kyiv has stepped up its attacks on Russia this year, with long-range missiles and swarms of drones targeting military industries and energy facilities.

It has also increasingly pummeled giant Wildberries depots, burning billions of dollars’ worth of merchandise belonging to the Russian online retail giant. Those attacks have brought the war home to the Russian public nearly five years into Moscow’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Meanwhile, Ukraine also came under Russian attack, with drone strikes destroying homes and torching Kyiv’s landmark book market.



Emergency personnel at the site of a book market hit by a Russian missile strike, in Kyiv, on Sunday. REUTERS

Russia’s Ministry of Defence said it had destroyed 822 Ukrainian drones overnight. Some 600 drones were detected headed toward the Russian capital, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyenin said, with a third of those destroyed over the Moscow region itself.

An 83-year-old man was killed after a Ukrainian drone hit a private home in the Moscow region, local Gov. Andrey Vorobyov said. He also confirmed that a Ukrainian attack had

sparked a blaze at a Wildberries warehouse in town of Podolsk.

A drone attack targeted three towns in Russia’s southwestern Rostov region, killing five people, local Gov. Yuriy Slyusar said. The attack, with more than 150 drones, damaged several homes and a railway station and sparked a forest fire.

A Russian missile attack on Ukraine’s Kryvyi Rih killed two people and wounded 14 others, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on social

media Sunday. He also said that one more person had been killed in the city of Sumy.

ArcelorMittal Kryvyi Rih, Ukraine’s largest steel producer, confirmed that one of its sites had been hit in a missile attack and that operations had been partially suspended.

Russian attacks also sparked fires throughout the Ukrainian capital, Kyiv, wounding six people. A blaze took hold at one of the city’s largest book markets, tearing through kiosks huddled close to Pochaina metro station.

Meanwhile, an F-18 fighter on a NATO air policing mission shot down a drone that illegally breached Romanian national airspace, the fourth unmanned aircraft shot down this year, Romania’s defence ministry said on Sunday.

A spokesperson for NATO’s military headquarters, US Army Colonel Martin O’Donnell, said the alliance is constantly on watch and prepared to defend itself from any threat. “Additional details regarding Sunday’s incident remain under investigation, but the drone appears to be Russian,” he said.

—WITH REUTERS INPUTS

Trump envoys meet mediators, Israel strikes Gaza

Reuters
Cairo, August 16

DONALD TRUMP’S envoys met with Egyptian, Qatari and Turkish mediators in Cairo on Sunday, a diplomatic source said, in a bid to advance the US president’s Gaza peace plan, even as Israel pressed on with airstrikes in the enclave.

Hamas officials were present at some of the meetings between mediators and with Trump’s envoy and son-in-law, Jared Kushner, and Nikolay Mladenov, Trump’s Board

of Peace envoy for Gaza, the diplomat said.

A senior Israeli official said Kushner and Mladenov were scheduled to meet Monday with Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu, who on August 9 said Trump’s latest roadmap for Gaza peace was ‘unacceptable’.

The official said Israel was concerned about Washington’s demand to end targeted assassinations of Hamas militants in Gaza as it rebuilds its forces.

Trump’s peace plan calls for the immediate cessation of military operations in Gaza.

It foresees Hamas disarming as Israeli troops withdraw from the enclave and Gaza is rebuilt under a new civilian Palestinian administration.

After scaling back its attacks in the enclave earlier this month, Israel’s airstrikes have resumed in the past few days.

The Israeli military said on Sunday that its aircraft struck two Islamic Jihad and Hamas militants in Khan Younis and Nuseirat. At least five Palestinians were injured in the strike which hit a tent encampment, medics in the enclave said.

A separate airstrike, which the Israeli military said targeted another militant, hit an apartment in the Nuseirat camp in central Gaza, wounding several people, medics said.

Earlier on Sunday, five Arab countries together with Turkey, Pakistan and Indonesia condemned Israel’s rejection of US President Donald Trump’s plan for Gaza. In a joint statement, the countries including Egypt, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and UAE, said the rejection threatened Trump’s intensified efforts to end war in Gaza

Ex-Cambridge prof’s death tragedy on many levels: UK PM

Associated Press
London, August 16

BRITAIN’S PRIME minister called for reflection on Saturday after a Black professor who faced a storm of plagiarism accusations died suddenly, days after resigning from a prestigious role at the University of Cambridge.

Jason Arday, who became Cambridge’s youngest Black professor in 2023, was found dead inside an address in south London on Friday.

He resigned last week as

professor of sociology of education after coming under intense media scrutiny, with weeks of news headlines alleging plagiarism in his academic work and questions surrounding claims about his athletic and fundraising accomplishments.

His death has prompted outcries that allegations against

Arday, 41, were magnified into a cruel public takedown motivated by racism and longstanding hostility to diversity, equity and inclusion policies at universities and other institutions.



Jason Arday was found dead

Prime Minister Andy Burnham said Arday’s death was “a tragedy on so many levels.”

“It’s not a moment for any

rushing to judgment. It’s a moment for reflection, I would say, reflecting on how things came to this,” Burnham told reporters.

Police said the death was being treated as “unexpected” but not suspicious. They said officers were called to an address in south London on Friday afternoon and a 41-year-old man was pronounced dead at the scene. They did not name Arday, in accordance with police policy.

A friend said Arday had told him that he “felt he couldn’t go on” in a voice note earlier Friday.

Morocco arrests 111 migrants headed for Spain’s Ceuta in security crackdown

Reuters
Ceuta, August 16

MOROCCAN POLICE arrested at least 111 people on Saturday as they tried to enter Spain’s North African enclave of Ceuta, amid tightened security on both sides of the border after social media posts called for another mass migrant crossing.

The attempted crossing came two weeks after more than 72,000 migrants surged into

Ceuta, sparking tensions within the EU and fuelling anti-immigration rhetoric among far-right parties worldwide. At least 96 people died in the attempt to reach European soil.

A source in Morocco’s Interior Ministry told *Reuters* those detained included 109 migrants from Africa and two Moroccan citizens arrested in or around Fnideq, the Moroccan city opposite Ceuta.

According to Spanish news

agency *EFE*, Moroccan police used tear gas to disperse groups of migrants gathered on hills about 3 km from the border.

Reuters later saw hundreds of police officers, some in riot gear and others in plain clothes, returning from the hills

outside Fnideq. *EFE* and Spanish state broadcaster *TVE* said Morocco’s Interior Ministry ordered their journalists to leave Fnideq immediately, without providing an explanation.

Belgium’s biggest wildfire on record heads towards Germany

Brussels: Firefighters worked through the night to battle Belgium’s biggest wildfire on record, which by Sunday had burned 3,000 hectares of land and was heading towards German border, authorities said.

The blaze in the High Fens, a nature reserve in the east of the country, has been burning since Friday and firefighters from across Belgium and neighbouring Germany and Luxembourg have sought to contain it, as have the army and farmers.

Responders Sunday were focused on the front line of the fire moving towards Germany and were hopeful that cooler, more humid weather would support efforts to contain it, Stephanie Ernoux, spokesperson for the administration of the Belgian region of Wallonia, told Reuters.

The fire is more than double the size of a blaze in 2011 that burned close to 1,400 hectares, the data from European Forest Fire Information System showed.

REUTERS

South Korea fires warning shots as N Korea troops cross ‘military line’

Reuters
Seoul, August 16

SOUTH KOREA’S Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS) said on Sunday that warning shots had been fired when North Korean soldiers violated the military demarcation line between the countries, prompting them to return.

The *Yonhap* news agency reported earlier on Sunday that warning shots had been fired last week, citing an unnamed source.

“Recently, on the Eastern Front, North Korean forces crossed the military demarcation line, prompting our military to fire warning shots according to operational procedures,” a JCS statement said without giving the date of the incident.

“Our military is closely monitoring North Korean movements while maintaining a firm military readiness posture.”

Yonhap said the incident was the first reported violation of the military demarcation line by North Korea this year and that the soldiers were likely to have been patrolling the area when they crossed the MDL.

Qatar captured 3 of our pilots, says Iran; Doha denies claim

Yeganeh Torbati & Leily Nikonazar
August 16

IRAN ACCUSED Qatar on Saturday of capturing three of its bomber pilots in the early days of the US-Israeli war with Iran, a claim that a Qatari official publicly denied.

General Seyed Mohammad Bagherzadeh, commander of the Iranian armed forces’ missing persons search committee, made the accusation in a letter to the International Committee of the Red Cross, which was published by Iranian media.

He said the men were flying Su-24 fighter jets in an operation on March 2, days after the outbreak of the war, when their planes had been hit by “enemy defenses” and the pilots ejected.

They survived but were captured by the Qatari authorities, according to General Bagherzadeh, who named the men as Javad Salehi, Abdolmajid Dashiian and Omran Behraves-hian. A fourth pilot, Majid Kazemi, died, he added.

But Majed al-Ansari, a spokesman for Qatar’s foreign ministry, denied the country had detained the Iranians.

“We categorically deny the claims circulating regarding

“We categorically deny the claims circulating regarding the detention of Iranian pilots & are surprised by these misleading statements... amid the ongoing diplomatic efforts & initiatives aimed at de-escalating tensions in the region.”

MAJED AL-ANSARI , SPOKESPERSON FOR QATAR FOREIGN MINISTRY

the detention of Iranian pilots & are surprised by these misleading statements at this particular time, amid the ongoing diplomatic efforts & initiatives aimed at de-escalating tensions in the region,” al-Ansari wrote on social media on Saturday evening.

Qatar, a close US ally that hosts a major American military base, said in early March that its Air Force had shot down two Iranian Su-24 bomber jets. Al-Ansari said on Saturday that “contact was established with the pilots concerned following their violation of Qatari airspace.” NYT

Iran votes to criminalise ‘hostile’ media interviews

Dubai: Iran’s parliament approved a bill on Sunday that would criminalise interviews and other communications with media deemed hostile to the Islamic Republic, including US or Israeli media and outlets financed by either country, Iran’s *Shargh* newspaper reported.

Under the bill, which must still be reviewed by the Guardian Council before it can become law, interviews or participation in discussions with such media

would be banned and violations punishable by six months to two years in prison.

Interviews with other foreign media would require notification to the intelligence ministry, while contact with foreign embassies, offices of foreign organisations or other non-Iranian institutions without notification and written permission from the foreign ministry would be punishable by a fine and deprivation of certain social rights. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

ITALY

Thieves steal 4 Antonello da Messina artworks in Sicilian museum heist



The Madonna and Child by Antonello da Messina, which was stolen. REUTERS

FOUR ARTWORKS by 15th century painter Antonello da Messina have been stolen overnight from the Museo Regionale di Messina, Italy’s culture minister said on Sunday, expressing confidence in the police inquiry. The theft deprives Messina of parts of the only surviving work by the Renaissance painter to have remained in his native city, as well as a small painting acquired by the Sicilian Region two decades ago. “I’ve learnt of the theft with shock and sadness,” Culture Minister Alessandro Giuli said. REUTERS

HUNGARY

12 killed after bus overturns

TWELVE PEOPLE were killed and at least 10 injured after a Polish-registered bus overturned on the M3 motorway in Hungary on Sunday, Hungarian Prime Minister Peter Magyar said. Police said bus veered off the road into a ditch and overturned, with probe suggesting the driver likely fell asleep. AP

PAKISTAN

Security forces kill 7 militants

TWO WOMEN of a Sindh family were shot dead in a terror attack while security forces killed seven terrorists in two separate incidents in Balochistan, officials said on Sunday. The terrorists were killed during an operation while several other terrorists injured, according to the military’s media wing. PTI

Forbes fires top editor over secret \$6 million payment

Benjamin Mullin
August 16

THE TOP editor of *Forbes* was fired last month after the company discovered he had received a payment of about \$6 million from the founder of a firm that does business with the magazine, according to three people familiar with the decision.

Randall Lane, the magazine’s chief content officer, was paid by RJ Shook, whose company, Shook Research, has teamed up with *Forbes* since 2016 to publish rankings of wealth advisers. The payment was made after Shook sold a majority stake in Shook Research to PPC Enterprises, a pri-



Randall Lane, former chief content officer of Forbes

vate equity firm, last August, two of the people familiar with the transaction said.

Forbes has policies requiring its employees to seek permission before conducting outside business activities and prohibiting them from gaining personally — directly or indirectly — from the company’s business dealings, according to a copy of the employee handbook obtained by *The New York Times*. NYT

Zane Irwin
August 16

WHEN THE police chief learned what workers had found, sealed inside a small brick cellar as they drilled below a defunct brewery, he was sure someone had interrupted his Tuesday meeting with a prank. “I thought it was a joke,” said the chief, Patrick Feys, “because things like that normally don’t happen in real life.”

But workers had plenty of proof: 49 gold bars and over 4,000 gleaming coins, a cache worth an estimated \$10 million, its origin and fate unknown.

Construction workers in the Belgian city of Dendermonde

had been drilling this week beneath what used to be the foundation of a brewery built in the 1890s. The site was undergoing renovations for a project to create transitional housing for homeless people. At first, the workers thought they had only found one-euro coins, and kept boring through the cellar’s brick walls, Chief Feys said.

Instead, they started finding gold bars, leaving dents and scratches on a few with their tools. After the discovery, Chief Feys’s mounting excitement merged with anxiety, he said.

The police hurried the trove to the station for inventory, where four people counted each piece under a surveillance cam-



More than 4,000 gold coins and dozens of gold bars were found sealed in a cellar below the construction site. NYT

era to ensure nothing was lost or stolen. “An amount like this, it’s always a risk,” Chief Feys said, adding that he did not relax until

the stash was in federal custody.

Geert Hillaert, the director of the social services nonprofit that owns the property where

the gold was found, said in an interview that two questions sprang to mind when he heard about the buried treasure: “How does this happen?” and “How do we get it safe?”

Local prosecutors will investigate whether the gold has been stolen or involved in any crime, Hillaert said. If not, Belgian law gives family members or other heirs five years to claim the bounty, he and the police said.

But there do not appear to be any direct, living heirs of the brewery’s original owner, whom former mayor Piet Buyse has identified as a man named Théophile van Assche. In an interview with Dutch-language Belgian outlet *HLN*, Buyse said

the brewery was built in the late 19th century, and van Assche’s three children ran the business until it shuttered in 1970.

None of the children married or left heirs, Buyse said, and there are few ready clues as to the origin of the gold. The authorities said a stamp on one of the gold bars dated it to the 1960s.

In 1982, the property was left to a local Benedictine monastery, which used it as transitional housing for formerly incarcerated people, Hillaert said. Last year, the monks gave the property to CAW Oost-Vlaanderen, the nonprofit that Hillaert directs. (The monastery did not respond to a request for comment.) NYT



राजस्थान सरकार



श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी
माननीय प्रधानमंत्री



श्री भजनलाल शर्मा
माननीय मुख्यमंत्री

प्रगति पथ पर गतिमान राजस्थान



17 अगस्त, 2026 | प्रातः 11:30 बजे | कृषि उपज मण्डी, बारां

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

श्री भजनलाल शर्मा
माननीय मुख्यमंत्री

श्री शिवराज सिंह चौहान
माननीय केन्द्रीय कृषि एवं किसान कल्याण तथा ग्रामीण विकास मंत्री

बारां एवं झालावाड़ जिलों के लिए

₹1,258 करोड़ के 98 विकास कार्यों का शिलान्यास एवं लोकार्पण

प्रधानमंत्री आवास योजना-ग्रामीण

राजस्थान को वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 के लिए 2.89 लाख आवासों के निर्माण हेतु ₹ 4600 करोड़ आवंटित

पंचायत समिति मुख्यालयों पर स्वीकृत प्रोटोटाइप आवासों का शिलान्यास

लाभार्थियों को नवीन आवास की चाबी का वितरण

विकसित भारत रोजगार गारंटी एवं आजीविका मिशन-ग्रामीण

कन्वर्जेन्स के तहत लगभग ₹2,400 करोड़ के कार्यों को युक्त धारा पोर्टल पर कार्ययोजना में सम्मिलित करना

◦ प्रमुख कार्य ◦

अमृत पोषण वाटिका | अमृत ग्रामीण हाट बाजार | ग्रामीण पुस्तकालय
अमृत संजीवनी पार्क | कांजी हाउस पशु आश्रय स्थल | नमो नर्सरी

डीबीटी के माध्यम से राशि हस्तांतरण

मुख्यमंत्री दुग्ध उत्पादक संबल योजना
5 लाख पशुपालकों को ₹280 करोड़

गौशाला अनुदान
751 गौशालाओं को ₹250 करोड़

महिला उत्थान

स्वयं सहायता समूह की दीदियों को ₹10 करोड़ के क्रेडिट लिंकेज चेक का वितरण

राजस्थान महिला निधि की लखपति दीदी ऋण योजना अंतर्गत 957 लखपति दीदियों को ₹8 करोड़ के चेक का वितरण

राजस्थान महिला निधि की समर्थ सखी योजना अंतर्गत स्वयं सहायता समूहों की दीदियों को स्कूटी वितरण

“सशक्त सीएलएफ, समृद्ध दीदी डिजिटल अभियान-2026” का शुभारंभ

ग्राम श्री राजसखी मार्ट 11.77 लाख, बारां का शुभारंभ

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

As AI agents get popular, questions of control, onus



ANAGHA JAYAKUMAR

AN AUSTRALIAN man recently shared that his Artificial Intelligence (AI) agent, which he had tasked with helping him move up the waitlist for his gym class, went above and beyond. It exploited vulnerabilities in the gym's software, made reservations weeks before bookings opened, and even removed a person ahead of the user from the waiting list.

Unlike an AI assistant, which primarily responds to a user's prompts, an AI agent can independently take a series of actions using tools or software to achieve a user-defined goal. Such an agent can, for instance, access other software and navigate websites.

The Australian user had not authorised the agent, powered by Anthropic's Claude, to achieve the objective of securing a spot in the gym class by any means necessary — the agent had autonomously chosen how to pursue that objective.

The incident illustrates a complication that comes with delegating tasks to increasingly capable AI systems: how much of the process does a user hand over along with the task?

What changes when consumers delegate to AI?

For years, consumers have relied on AI to ease their lives in incremental ways: seeking a recommendation, getting answers to search queries, finding the fastest possible route to a destination, or translating a piece of text. In most such interactions, AI helps the consumer make or carry out a decision, but the decision to act on it rests with the consumer.

AI agents change this relationship by allowing users to hand over the task itself. A user can set a goal for the agent to achieve, while leaving it to figure out the steps required to achieve it. For example, a user may now ask an agent to plan a holiday, from finding suitable flights and drawing up an itinerary to making reservations

How an AI agent is different from a chatbot

For the average person, an AI chatbot assistant can ease many tasks: seeking a recommendation, getting answers to online search queries, or translating text.

But an AI agent goes a step further. It can independently take a series of actions to achieve a user-defined goal, and can even access other software and navigate websites. For example, a user can command it to plan a holiday, and it can find suitable flights, draw up an itinerary and make reservations on their behalf.

At their core, both assistants and agents share the same underlying principle. AI assistants like ChatGPT, Gemini and Claude are Large Language Models or LLMs, which are systems trained on large amounts of



data to recognise meaningful patterns. They predict an answer for a user query based on this information.

Some early evidence of what users are actually willing to delegate comes from Perplexity's Comet browser. A study examined hundreds of millions of interactions between July and

According to OpenAI, the company behind ChatGPT, creating an agent requires three main components:

- 1. The model, which is the LLM powering the agent's reasoning and decision-making;
- 2. Tools, which are the external functions that the agent can use to take action, and
- 3. Instructions, or the explicit guidelines and guardrails defining how the agent behaves.

October 2025 and revealed tasks ranging from researching to searching for products. A majority of the work involved personal use.

on their behalf.

In a 2021 paper titled *Consumers and Artificial Intelligence: An Experiential Perspective*, Professor of Marketing at The Wharton School of the University of Pennsylvania, Stefano Puntoni, and others examine this "delegation experience", in which AI performs a task that a consumer could have performed themselves. The paper argues that such delegation can be experienced in two opposing ways: as empowering, when AI enables consumers to accomplish their goals, and as replacing, when handing over a task diminishes their sense of autonomy or control.

This makes control integral to the decision to delegate. What consumers are willing to delegate depends on factors including their trust in the AI and its perceived competence, Puntoni told *The Indian Express*. He described control as "the other side of the delegation coin". The more an agent can do independently, the less closely a user may need to direct or monitor how it gets done.

So what are consumers actually handing over?

Two ends

A 2021 research paper examines the 'delegation experience', in which AI does a task a consumer could've done.

- The paper argues that such delegation can be experienced in two ways: as empowering, when AI enables consumers to accomplish their goals, and as replacing, when handing over a task diminishes their sense of autonomy.

Some early evidence of what users are willing to delegate comes from Perplexity's Comet browser. A study of its use examined hundreds of millions of anonymised interactions between July and October 2025, allowing researchers to observe what users asked its agent to do, rather than what they said they might be willing to delegate.

The study counted an interaction as "agentic" only when the agent took control of the browser or acted on an external application. It excluded ordinary searches and interactions that merely involved exchanging information.

The delegated tasks ranged from researching and editing documents to searching for products and managing account settings. More than half (55%) of agentic queries were for personal use, compared with 30% for professional use and 16% for educational purposes.

The study does not show that consumers at large are ready to delegate these tasks. Comet was then a new product, and its users were early adopters who may have been more technologically inclined than the wider population. Moreover, observing what people delegated cannot, on its own, tell us why they were comfortable handing over those tasks, or which ones they were unwilling to hand over.

Willingness to delegate is unlikely to be uniform across tasks. Puntoni said there would be areas where most consumers remain reluctant to hand decisions to an algorithm, while some people may resist using AI agents in most situations. He expects this reluctance to ease as consumers build what he called "calibrated trust" through experience with agents.

"As AI agents demonstrate their usefulness, consumers will be more likely to adopt," Puntoni told *The Indian Express*. He cited the example of autonomous vehicles such as Waymo, saying people sceptical of the technology can change their minds after experiencing it themselves.

There may be limits to how much autonomy consumers want an agent to have. Research cited in *The Wharton Blueprint for AI Agent Adoption*, co-authored by Puntoni and AI researcher Thomas McKinlay, suggests that people were more willing to adopt AI agents with a moderate level of decision-making autonomy. Too little autonomy made the agent seem less useful, while too much reduced users' sense of freedom and control.

Will consumers choose to adopt agents?

Consumers may not consciously choose to "adopt" an AI agent. Puntoni said adoption could instead happen gradually through products people already use.

"Agent adoption may in many situations be a relatively slow process where consumers learn to delegate more and more tasks as new automation features become embedded in products over time," he told *The Indian Express*.

He cited Microsoft adding agentic features to products such as Office as an example of how this could happen.

As agentic capabilities become embedded in products consumers already use, what it means to be in control may also change. The Wharton Blueprint points to the ability to edit, pause, stop or reverse an agent's actions as ways for users to retain control after delegating a task.

"The notion of extended self might suggest that people may grow to see AI agents as an extension of themselves, and if so, perhaps experience a relatively high sense of control even in the case of highly autonomous agents," Puntoni told *The Indian Express*. "It's very speculative though, and I'm not sure how likely that is."

CLIMATE

Odisha's coastal erosion: The measures to save lives, livelihoods

Sujit Bisoi
Bhubaneswar, August 16

UNION MINISTER for Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal, in a recent reply tabled in Rajya Sabha, said that about 28% of Odisha's 564-km coastline is undergoing erosion.

This is based on a study by the National Centre for Coastal Research (NCCR), which carried out a comprehensive assessment and mapping of shoreline change analysis along the Odisha coast from 1990 to 2022. The NCCR monitors long-term shoreline changes across the Indian coastline.

Citing the NCCR study, Sonowal said approximately 28.3% of the coastline is undergoing erosion, 17.6% remains stable (no significant shoreline change), and 54.1% is experiencing accretion or growth. His reply came in response to a query by Rajya Sabha member from Odisha, Sasmit Patra.

Shoreline change in Odisha

Shoreline changes refer to the dynamic process where the boundary between land and water shifts over time owing to natural

forces like waves, tides, storms, and human activities like port construction, unplanned infrastructure development, and sand mining. Factors like global sea-level rise also contribute to coastal erosion and shoreline change.

According to a 2021 piece "Shoreline Change Along Odisha Coast" published in the *Journal of Earth System Science*, coastal structures such as sea walls, breakwaters, and jetties result in modification of the shoreline and beach morphology. The effects are even more significant with hard structures raised for the development of ports and harbours. Besides, natural hazards such as tsunamis and cyclone storms along the India coast, too, result in drastic changes. The paper said that as things stand, Odisha is most prone to cyclones.

At least six coastal districts in Odisha — Ganjam, Puri, Jagatsinghpur, Kendrapada, Bhadrak, and Balasore — are facing coastal erosion and shoreline changes. As per the NCCR study, Jagatsinghpur has emerged as the most erosion-prone, with 47.6% of its total 55.8-km coastline facing erosion. It is followed by Ganjam (45.7% of 60.18-km

Geotextile tube

This is a large, cylindrical container made from high-strength, porous synthetic fabrics and filled with a sand slurry, to form an artificial coastal structure.

- These tubes, used to form sea walls, absorb the impact of waves when they hit the shore and help minimise erosion.
- One such embankment is being developed at Penthavillage in Kendrapara.

shoreline affected), and Kendrapara (45% of 149.36 km-shoreline affected). Among other coastal districts, erosion has affected 23.8% of Balasore's 88-km coastline, 10.2% of Puri's 138-km coastline, and 4.6% of Bhadrak's 72-km coastline. The NCCR has also identified several coastal areas in the six districts as "vulnerable stretches" based on long-term shoreline analysis.

Impact, and measures taken

Official sources in Odisha's Forest, Environment and Climate Change Department said rising sea level and coastal erosion owing to climate change has already submerged as many as 16 villages in Kendrapara district, displacing several hundreds of people. The affected villagers lost not just their land but also their livelihood. The Odisha government has developed a resettlement colony, touted as India's first climate resettlement colony, to accommodate the people hit by coastal erosion.

Similarly, Podampeta in Ganjam, once a village of nearly 500 households, has been deserted as the marauding Bay of Bengal swept inland. Several other settlements in

the district, too, have been affected, forcing people to leave their homes. Several other coastal villages in Ganjam such as Ramayapatna have also been witnessing the advancing of the sea towards the landmass, rendering residents homeless.

Department officials said that to protect coastal villages from sea erosion, steps are being taken, such as developing a geotextile tube embankment at Penthavillage in Kendrapara. A geotextile tube is a large, cylindrical container made from high-strength, porous synthetic fabrics (such as polypropylene) and filled with a sand slurry, to form an artificial coastal structure. These tubes, which are used to form sea walls, generally absorb the impact of waves when they hit the shore and help minimise erosion.

Similarly, sea wall-cum-serving roads are being developed across parts of Balasore district and Ramayapatna beach in Ganjam district. These roads are dual-purpose coastal structures: while the outer tier acts as a defensive barrier against strong tidal waves and coastal erosion, the inner tier operates as an operational roadway or service path for local transport and public access.

POLICY

Why the J&K govt is stuck in a quota quagmire

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, August 16

JAMMU AND Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Friday warned of Gen Z-like protests if his Cabinet's proposal to tweak the reservation system in the Union Territory wasn't acted upon.

The Cabinet had sent its submission on the reservation policy to the Lieutenant Governor in November last year.

"What has happened after that, let someone tell us. Has it been approved? Let's hope that the Gen-Z trend doesn't spill over here as well. We would not be responsible for that. We have done our job... This is not a good thing that they (the L-G and the Centre) keep the approvals of our cabinet under wraps," Omar said.

The issue of "rationalising" the reservation system has become a hot button issue in the UT.

What is the reservation policy in Jammu and Kashmir?

Before the abrogation of Jammu and Kashmir's special status on August 5, 2019, 43% seats in government jobs were reserved for different categories, such as Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), Other Backward Classes (OBCs), residents of areas along the Actual Line of Control (ALC) and the International



Border (IB), residents of backward areas, those physically challenged, and former service personnel.

But in 2024, L-G Manoj Sinha announced an amendment to the J&K Reservation Act 2004, barely a month before the 2024 Parliamentary elections. Reservation was enhanced from 43% to 70% in government jobs. The jump was because ST status was given to the Pahari community. ST categorisation for the Paharis had always been opposed by the Gujjars and Bakerwals, who hold the status. To not annoy the Gujjars, the administration announced increasing the ST quota from 10% to 20%.

70% RESERVATION

- Before August 2019, 43% seats in government jobs were reserved, for SCs, STs, residents of border areas, the physically challenged, etc.
- In 2024, ST status was given to the Pahari community, taking the quota in jobs to 70%

Why is the Omar government under pressure?

For the Omar Abdullah government, pushback is coming from within as well as the public. In February, in response to a motion by People's Conference leader Sajad Lone, the government presented numbers in the Assembly that showed significantly more reserved category certificates going to people in Jammu than in Kashmir.

Before that, in October 2025, an MP from Omar's own party, Aga Ruhullah Mehdi, sat on protest with people from unreserved categories outside the CM's residence.

The government then set up a Cabinet sub-committee, which filed its report in October 2025, recommending capping reservations at 50%. The Cabinet accepted it and in the next month, sent the file to Lok Bhawan (L-G's residence) for clearance.

Omar has now said that the Lok Bhawan had raised queries on the report, which his government responded to, but there has been no movement since.

HISTORY

How the 1946 naval uprising hastened India's independence from British rule



EXPERT EXPLAINS

SRIKANT KESNUR

INDIAN NAVY VETERAN AND NAVAL HISTORIAN

ON FEBRUARY 18, 1946, more than a thousand sailors or "ratings" of the Royal Indian Navy (RIN) in Bombay revolted against British rule and went on strike, which then cascaded into a larger uprising involving Indian personnel in other naval bases across British India. Commodore **Srikant Kesnur** (Retired) told **Abhinav Chakraborty** that the 1946 uprising was the "last war of independence", which rattled the British and hastened India's independence.

What led to the uprising?

From fewer than 2,000 people at the start of World War II, the RIN grew to almost

30,000 people because of the requirements of war. Often, people were trained at short notice and sent to war. Still, the RIN performed very well. So, there were expectations that one would be rewarded in some way. But a war-ravaged Britain decided to reduce the strength of personnel to around 11,000. This implied loss of pride and status for many, apart from the uncertainty and feeling of British pre-war promises having gone awry.

That was in some ways the spark, but the cauldron was simmering due to the Indian National Army (INA) trials. This was compounded by harsh language used, bad food, and terrible living conditions.

What triggered the uprising?

On December 1, 1945, Navy Day was to be celebrated. But the night before, some sailors on the HMIS Talwar, a shore establishment (naval base built on land) in Bombay, hoisted brooms and buckets and wrote slogans like "Down with the British" and "Quit India". The commanding officer was changed and Commander Arthur Frederick King, was brought in, but the underlying issues of morale weren't addressed.

A few days before February 18, King



The Naval Uprising statue in Mumbai. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

came into the Ratings mess, wanting to show he was in charge. He thought that the sailors were being disrespectful, so he abused them and called them "sons of coolies". They made a formal complaint against him, but no action was taken.

What were the sailors' demands?

The demands were related to disciplinary action against King, and bettering their service conditions. But it also included the withdrawal of British Indian Army soldiers from Indonesia, that INA detainees must be given free trials, things like that. So, the demands were being centred around the Navy and at the same time, had a larger

world-view with a political context to it.

What was its immediate fallout?

The British were rattled. They responded with disproportionate force.

The immediate fallout from the Indian side was that the uprising spread far and wide. Across naval stations, involving not just the Navy but also the people, particularly in Mumbai and Karachi.

Some 78 ships, 20 shore establishments — you're talking of almost 100 naval units and nearly 20,000 people — joined in the strike. Now, that is unprecedented, in the sense that the Navy almost rose as one.

They took over Butcher Island (Jawahar Dweep near Mumbai), which had ammunition. They trained their guns on imperial symbols — the Gateway of India, the Taj Mahal Hotel, the Yacht Club. Importantly, they called themselves the Indian National Navy and the Azad Hindis, after the Azad Hind Fauj. They brought down the British flags on the ships and hoisted a combination of Congress and Muslim League flags.

There was a police firing in Bombay on February 22, where a minimum of 400 people — some place it at 500 or 700 —

died and about 1,500 to 2,000 were injured. Most of these deaths were of civilians who had come out in support of the ratings.

After some Air Force and Army units too started to exhibit "mutinous conduct", the British realised that Indian soldiers were not cooperating in putting down the strike. If the few coercive elements of the State are not at your disposal, then you can no longer rule over the country. For a lot of people, this is the last war of independence, because the realisation dawned on the British that the military was no longer with them.

What was its significance?

Several historians — including myself — have come to believe that it certainly hastened or accelerated our independence.

Right after independence, it didn't get the kind of traction it could have got because it didn't have a charismatic leader — someone like Netaji (Subhas Chandra Bose), who was a rallying figure for the INA. Also, a newly born Navy after independence was uncomfortable with the idea of a mutiny — and correctly so. So, people didn't know the kind of impact it had, which we now probably know and can appreciate better.



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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Happening today

● **THE JHARKHAND** government has invited students protesting over alleged irregularities in recruitment exams for a fresh rounds of talks.

● **SUPREME COURT** will hear TN government's plea seeking directions to Karnataka for immediate release of the share of Cauvery water to it.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

AI needs uninterrupted power. After Gen Z, your leaders must address Gensets.



BODY FOUND ON TMC OFFICE PREMISES

Bengal ex-Dy Speaker found dead; never took a single penny for any work, says 'suicide note'

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, August 16

FORMER DEPUTY Speaker of the West Bengal Assembly and five-time MLA from Rampurhat in Birbhum district, Ashish Banerjee, was found dead on the premises of the local Trinamool Congress office on Sunday morning, the police said. "Primarily, it's a suicide case. We have found a suicide note in which he has written - 'no one is responsible for my death,'" Birbhum Superintendent of Police Vidit Raj Bhundesh told *The Indian Express*. Banerjee lived at Hattalpara in Rampurhat and the



TMC leader Ashish Banerjee's funeral at Rampurhat in West Bengal's Birbhum, Sunday. PTI

Bookies, players, teams: State-run T20 leagues under anti-graft lens

Varinder Bhatia & Venkata Krishna B
Chandigarh, Chennai, August 16

THE BCCI'S anti-corruption wing is putting all T20 leagues run by state associations under the scanner to track suspected corruption-related activities by some team owners, organisers and players, sources aware of the crackdown told *The Indian Express*.

"The ACSU (Anti-Corruption and Security Unit) has found increasing instances of bookies and suspicious persons getting in touch with the players,

E. EXPLAINED

Weak links

Franchises in state-level T20 leagues have struggled for big-ticket sponsorships, mainly after the ban on online fantasy gaming platforms. This has opened the door for bookies offering easy money.

team owners, managers, which is against the code of conduct and rules governing the game. It

is the first time that ACSU is covering all matches at state leagues, unlike previously when only Test matches, IPL and other main matches were covered thoroughly," the sources said.

ACSU officials are also tracking those who meet players and team officials in their hotels during these T20 games, they said.

The crackdown comes after "some teams" in the Tamil Nadu Premier League (TNPL) came "under the ACSU's watch for suspected corruption-related activities" since the previous season, sources said. The

"Today's kids are brilliant... you have to be with a dream for a long time, work on it, only then will it happen"

GROUP CAPTAIN
SHUBHANSHU SHUKLA
PAGE 14

Extradite Hasina to set stage for Rahman's visit, Dhaka tells Delhi

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 16

THE BANGLADESH government said on Sunday that a "propitious environment needs to be created" for Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's visit to India. "To this end, we have requested the Indian authorities to expeditiously act on our request to extradite Sheikh Hasina and other fugitive criminals, and to hand over to Bangladesh the accused killers of Shaheed Sharif Osman Hadi in compliance with our bilat-

eral extradition treaty," the Bangladesh Foreign Ministry said in a statement.

While many in Dhaka see this as a 'red line', there is a sense in New Delhi that it needs to convey the "next steps" and give a "cogent response" to the Bangladesh Government's request for extradition. The extradition request was first moved by the interim government led by Prof Muhammad Yunus in 2024, and has been reiterated by the BNP government which assumed office in

ACROSS CAMPUSES, IITs RAMP UP EXECUTIVE EDUCATION PROGRAMMES

IITs go beyond BTech, expand their academic brand: Surge in mid-career courses

Pallavi Smart
Mumbai, August 16

FROM SHORT-TERM certificates to master's degrees, Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) are increasingly turning their academic brand and industry links toward a domain once associated more with Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs): executive programmes.

The shift has been driven by rising demand for upskilling, growing acceptance of online and hybrid learning after the pandemic, expanding industry partnerships — and the fact that, unlike government-subsidised BTech programmes, these courses pay for themselves through fees.

The trend is clearest at the first-generation IITs, which have expanded their offerings in emerging technology domains over the past four to five years. Almost all IITs now run full-fledged master's programmes and postgraduate diplomas online or in hybrid mode, letting working professionals earn an IIT qualification without leaving their jobs.

Artificial intelligence, machine learning and data science dominate demand among working professionals. But IITs are also introducing specialised programmes in electric vehicles, semiconductor technology, quantum computing, sustainability, robotics, cybersecurity and construction technology (see chart).

EXECUTIVE EDUCATION AT THE SEVEN FIRST-GENERATION IITs

IIT KHARAGPUR

● At least 10 full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses

● AI, cybersecurity, marketing technology, applied data science

IIT BOMBAY

● Four e-PG diplomas; short-term courses

● AI and ML, e-mobility, design thinking, computer science engineering

IIT KANPUR

● At least nine full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses

● Construction engineering, wireless networks, micro-electronics, smart grid, AI and ML, economics, data analytics

IIT MADRAS

● At least 20 full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses

● AI, EVs, sustainability, manufacturing, digital transformation, supply chain, finance

IIT DELHI

● At least five full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses

● EV technology, advanced

communication engineering, quantum-AI integration

IIT GUWAHATI

● At least three full PG or master's programmes; plus short-term courses

● Robotics and AI, water resource management, data science, semiconductors

IIT ROORKEE

● No full degree programmes. Short-term courses and PG certification in emerging tech, hardware and IT, sustainability

Before 2020, executive education at many IITs largely meant short-duration workshops or customised training run on campus for sponsoring organisations. Today, many IITs offer fully online or hybrid postgraduate degrees that professionals can pursue while working.

Take IIT Madras, which now offers more than 20 executive programmes. A foundational programme in electric vehicles has expanded into a bouquet of courses covering battery technologies, power electronics, software-defined vehicles and electric vehicle engineering. The institute has similarly expanded its offerings in sustain-

ability, construction technology and manufacturing analytics.

IIT Bombay has offered executive programmes for years but has seen a surge in demand recently. Participation fell to 1,493 across 56 programmes in 2020, from 2,749 across 95 programmes in 2015. By 2025, it had climbed to nearly 20,000 across 133 programmes.

At IIT Kanpur, the shift has been more recent and particularly pronounced in postgraduate education. The institute offered no online executive postgraduate degrees before 2020, but launched its first four under the eMasters initiative in 2022. It now offers nine — seven MTechs, one MSc and

one PG Diploma — apart from short-term courses.

"Every IIT has limited classroom space. This (online learning) is the future. Through digital education, we can reach many more learners without compromising on quality," Prof Hemant Kaushik of IIT Guwahati said.

He pointed to the institute's flagship online MTech in Flood and Water Resource Management, with a cohort of 66 last year and more than 320 offers already made this year, including professionals sponsored by the Assam government. These offers refer to the number of candidates expressing interest to join based on which the institute

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

VANDE MATARAM ROW

Shah targets Sonia, seeks apology; full version of song played, says Cong



Vice President C P Radhakrishnan, PM Narendra Modi, Speaker Om Birla, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Delhi CM Rekha Gupta and BJP chief Nitin Nabin arrive to pay tribute to former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee on his death anniversary, in New Delhi, Sunday. ANI

'Deep pain, anger': Bankim descendant, a BJP MLA, writes to Congress leader

Hamza Khan & Jatin Anand
Jaipur, New Delhi, August 16

A POLITICAL row erupted Sunday after Union Home Minister Amit Shah accused Congress leader Sonia Gandhi of attempting to stop the full rendition of Vande Mataram at the Congress headquarters on Independence Day and said the party should apologise to the nation.

The Congress rejected the charge and defended its leader, saying the full version of the Vande Mataram was sung at the party's Independence Day function.

Speaking at Nimbahera in

Rajasthan's Chittorgarh where a statue of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee was unveiled on his death anniversary, Shah said the Congress had not given Vande Mataram its due respect.

"Chanting Vande Mataram, thousands of people went to the gallows, faced bullets, endured lathi charges, and spent many years in jail. But in its vote-bank greed, the Congress forgot Vande Mataram," he said.

"Look how shameless they are. Vande Mataram was being sung at the Congress party headquarters. During the song, Congress leader Soniaji asked the Congress president to stop the song. We all watched it on TV. After 80 years, Bankim Babu's immortal mantra, his immortal song, was once again receiving respect, but Soniaji didn't like it," Shah said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'Not aimed at Opp': Rijiju clarifies PM's 'dimagi Naxal' remark

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

A DAY after Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in his Independence Day address, called for identifying and isolating "dimagi Naxals" — those allegedly espousing a Maoist mindset — Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Sunday sought to clarify that the remark was not directed at Opposition leaders.

Rijiju said Modi had referred only to those who support Maoists, separatists and people who do not believe in the Constitution. He also shared a clip of jailed student leader Sharjeel Imam's speech in which Imam had spoken of cutting off Assam from the rest of India through the Siliguri corridor, referred to as the Chicken's Neck, to draw the Union government's attention.

"PM @narendramodiji

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IN YOUTH-DRIVEN VIKSIT BHARAT, CELEBRATE 'DIMAG'

POLITICS P 5

TDP MP BACKS REMARK. SAYS NEW FORM POSES THREAT TO YOUTH



Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar in Patna on Sunday. PTI

Successful Bihar SIR led to record turnout in 2025 Assembly elections, says CEC

Press Trust of India
Patna, August 16

CHIEF ELECTION Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Sunday asserted that the “successful” Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Bihar last year had led to a significant rise in voter turnout in the Assembly polls that followed.

Speaking to reporters at Patna airport, the CEC, who is on a two-day tour of the state, said the SIR was conducted here successfully for the first time,” Kumar said.

The CEC said that following the mammoth exercise, conducted over a three-month period during which around 70 lakh names were knocked off the electoral rolls, a sharp rise was seen in the voter turnout when assembly polls which were held soon afterwards.

“As you all know, men and women came out in large numbers to vote and the turnout broke all records in the state. It may be noted that the voter turnout in Bihar Assembly polls was higher than what has been seen, over the years, in major democracies like the US, the UK, France, Spain and

Japan,” the CEC said. The Assembly polls held in November last year registered a voter turnout of 67.25 per cent, which, according to the Election Commission, was the highest for the state since Independence.

According to officials, the CEC is scheduled to interact with around 500 booth-level officers (BLOs) at Nalanda University in Rajgir on Monday to hear them about their ground-level challenges and suggest measures to make the electoral process more effective and accessible.

The CEC will also launch Electoral Literacy Club 2.0 and ECINET at a conference in Patna during his visit. The Election Commission had launched electoral literacy clubs in 2018 under the SVEEP programme to familiarise students and young citizens with democratic values, the electoral process, and the role and functioning of the EC.

“In view of the changing information and communication environment and the growing digital engagement of young people, the ELC programme is now being redefined as ELC2.0. The objective is to develop ELCs in schools, colleges and universities as active, experiential and digitally enabled platforms operating throughout the year,” an official said.

A large number of students, teachers, vice-chancellors, principals and heads of institutions from more than 400 educational institutions across Bihar will participate in the conference.

Drug kingpin Basoya sent to NCB custody until Aug 21

Sushant Kulkarni
Pune, August 16

A PUNE court Sunday remanded international drug syndicate kingpin Virender Singh Basoya, who was recently extradited from the UAE, in NCB custody until August 21.

Basoya was produced before a court in Pune on Sunday afternoon by an NCB team amid heavy police presence after he was flown to Pune from Delhi. Earlier, the NCB had obtained a three-day transit remand from a court in Delhi for him to be taken to Pune for seeking NCB custody.

Basoya is alleged to be a mastermind in several high-profile

file narcotics cases in India which have international links. NCB is investigating his role in a major drugs syndicate unearthed by the Pune City police’s Crime Branch in February 2024.

In one of the biggest-ever drug hauls in the country till date, the Pune City police’s Crime Branch had seized 1,800 kg of Mephedrone worth Rs 3,700 crore in a series of raids.

The probe revealed a sophisticated production line for the synthetic stimulant, being run from a chemical factory disguised as a pharma unit at an industrial cluster in Kurkumbh in Daund. Probe also showed consignments being sent to London via a courier agency in Delhi.

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‘The fix we need’

A significant number of graduates are neither employed in education nor in training, pointing to a deeper structural issue. While there is heavy reliance on government jobs, they account for only 1-2% of total employment. With the number of graduates far outpacing the availability of quality private sector jobs and only a small share securing regular salaried employment with formal contracts, what structural fixes are needed?

See, courses which all of us go and join and come out of... they don’t ready you for jobs. But ironically, they don’t even ready you for becoming an entrepreneur. You don’t need to go and work for somebody. You can do something yourself. But the courses don’t give you enough. For instance, if you were to be in a developed country, they give a young person the option to go for higher studies in the subjects that they are interested in or go for a local technical university which teaches one particular skill and then also tells you how to go about handling that skill and what are the things that you can do with that skill. Then, it also tells you how far that will take you in terms of management. In terms of you managing your own affairs, or there’s somebody who can manage it for you. So, that readies you for the marketplace, either to become an employee to somebody or to do your own thing.

Our university courses don’t have that. They give you a certificate, which is a bachelor’s degree, of something. If you have done economics or political science, what do you do with it afterwards? After BA, what do you do? You go for an MA. But after an MA, you need to have something. The UGC entrance exams. In my time, the UGC exam would be for Junior Research Fellowship, or JRF, and then Senior Research Fellowship. So, you can do research. But those who were with me in the class, not all of them did the JRFs and SRFs. What did they

do? So our system produced certified or degree-holding youngsters, but they were not ready yet for handling themselves, either as an employee or themselves to start off something. Or even to go and join their own parent’s business. That’s the fix we need.

How do we make government schools a genuine choice rather than an option forced by affordability? Do we need a structural overhaul to make parents willing to choose government schools for their children?

That would be the ideal state of affairs. It requires a lot of mindset change, before the money that is required. There is enough money, and more money is flowing, and more should go into government schools. We need more of them. But we need to look at what quality of teaching and learning happens there. What infrastructure is there? We can’t just be building classrooms and toilets. We need classrooms which can stand up to the requirements of today. We need teachers who are willing to go to those government schools... every teacher, if possible. And I wouldn’t blame them. Because when they go to a village school and house there, their own children’s education, who might not be going to primary school but into colleges, won’t have colleges there. So, other things will have to be ready before the ideal government school setup... For the teachers who go there, does the village provide them accommodation where they can live safely? Can the entire teacher’s family live there, or is she just going to be compelled to live there because she has to attend the school? So, there are quite a few such issues. Also, in some regions, where mother tongues are not so spoken in other regions, but in the local school, you need people with that mother tongue to be available. Are they readily available? Even if they are available, are they teacher material?

During the Jantar Mantar protests, there were

demands for the Education Minister’s resignation. Looking back, where do you think the government got it wrong?

I am not sure there is an alternative that I can think of now. What has happened has happened. With the benefit of hindsight, there’s no good talking I could have done it this way or we should have handled it this way. That’s just not possible.

The job market is increasingly stratified, with different sections facing very different challenges – from social security for gig workers to stagnant wages, rising costs, job security, and changing skill requirements for the middle class. How can the government design policies that address these diverse needs while also ensuring the private sector creates enough quality jobs?

Except for nudging the private sector, you can’t do much as the government. It’s up to the private sector. It’s their money that they are investing. Beyond a point, it will not be the government’s job to tell them. But if the market requires it, meaning that if there’s a need for something and the private sector sees a point that if they invest, they will be able to get something out of it, they will come in actually... So the market forces are the ones which decide where the money is put by the private or the government sector. So, unless there is a demand for a certain set of people or a certain set of jobs that require a certain set of people, the investment wouldn’t happen. So, we need to create situations and identify people to match with them.

The West Asia crisis began affecting India in February, disrupting supply chains, raising construction costs, and causing LPG shortages. Having also managed the Covid-19 crisis as a minister, how is this crisis different?

That last was for a brief while. Gas availability, as a result of which we had told the industry to cut down from 100% to 70%. Domestic consumers were seen... In the meanwhile, departments got together. In fact,

a Group of Ministers, headed by a senior minister, went into reviewing it every day and saying where the supply was going to come from. Once it comes, where it will go, to make sure no one suffers disproportionately. So, we were all hands-on and, therefore, it was possible to manage and confine it to the shortest period of time.

Have we learnt anything from these crises, and have we devised any framework or plan to mitigate losses in the future if such a situation arises again?

Yes, I think institutional arrangements are far more well-defined now. So, these memories should be in the institution, hopefully. Next time, God forbid, we have a situation like this, we will be able to handle it better.

Recent investment data suggests that a majority of domestic corporate investment is flowing into emerging fields like AI. What is your advice to Gen Z as technology continues to evolve so rapidly?

Of course, they should learn AI. In whichever field you are in, you will be expected to know it. You are probably better off knowing it because you can see the various ways in which it improves your efficiency. Nothing should stop any generation from learning.

What is your Gen Z story? What do you think is different about this generation from your personal experience? Is it the technology, the ways in which we communicate, our expectations?

I think you have a big advantage over earlier generations. The biggest advantage is that you have everything in your hands – in your mobile phone. So, your confidence comes from that. This is good. But what needs to go along is a sense of discretion to say, ‘How much can I use, and how much should I use it? And when do I use it, and when do I not?’ That sense of discretion, once it comes in, will be a brilliant change as you grow. At the moment, you are very blessed because you have the technology with you.

Rijiju

sympathisers were looking for opportunities to create unrest in the country. “We have succeeded in eliminating armed Naxals from the forests and liberating the country from that menace. However, while the armed Naxals are gone, the dimagi Naxals remain, and these dimagi Naxals are on the lookout for an opportunity,” Modi had said.

Opposition leaders alleged Modi’s reference was aimed at activists, academics, intellectuals and political critics. They also pointed to terms such as “Andolanjeevi”, “urban Naxals” and “tukde tukde gang”, which have featured in political discourse in the past.

Congress leader P Chidambaram on Sunday said he was “proud” to be a “dimagi Naxal”. In a post on X, he said: “I am proud to be a dimagi naxal.”

PDP chief and former J&K CM Mehbooba Muft said in a post on X: “I support Article 370. I’m a dimagi naxal”

Congress MP Renuka Chowdhury wrote on X: “...These are adjectives used by a Prime Minister for his fellow citizens, from the ramparts of Red Fort, that too on Independence Day! Stop disparaging your own fellow citizens! Is this not Dimaagi Bankruptcy!”

“Do they think if they somehow drop the word Naxal, people would be scared or disillusioned? You are making a mistake Modiji. If you call us Naxals for speaking truth, we are Naxals a thousand times over. Those who have revolutionary spirit, will they run away because he called them ‘dimagi Naxal’?” said CPIML (L)’s Dipankar Bhattacharya.

Hasina

February this year. Delhi had proposed August 21 as a possible date for the visit and what is said to have quereed the pitch was the press conference by ousted former PM Sheikh Hasina on August 5. The Tarique Rahman government has clearly spelt out it needs a response from the Indian government. The Indian government said it had “no role” in Hasina’s press interaction and did not endorse her views. At the presser, she had

IITs

decides the cohort size. Prof Vignesh Muthuvijayan, Associate Chair of the Centre for Outreach and Digital Education (CODE) at IIT Madras, said professionals want to upgrade skills without taking a career break. “The industry is changing rapidly and professionals need to constantly upskill. Institutes like IITs are able to offer structured, curated and mentored learning because we closely engage with industry and understand where the skill gaps exist,” he said.

Industry partnerships are also shaping courses. “(IIT Madras) has always worked closely with industry to solve real-world problems. Executive education is another way of building that relationship while creating highly skilled professionals,” Muthuvijayan said.

According to IIT Bombay, there is also demand from organisations preparing their workforce for technology-led change, with AI emerging as a strong driver.

“Companies and government organisations are increasingly seeking customised programmes aligned with specific capability gaps. At the same time, online and hybrid delivery have enabled IIT Bombay to reach professionals who may not be able to participate in conventional full-time or exclusively on-campus programmes,” the institute said.

Demand now runs well beyond technical roles. “Managers, business leaders, government officials, educators and professionals from diverse functions increasingly require an understanding of AI, data and digital transformation,” it said.

IIT Delhi acknowledged a steady increase over the past few years. “One of the biggest reasons is the growing demand from professionals who want to upgrade their skills without taking a career break. At the same time, industries are evolving rapidly, creating a need for specialised training in both technology and non-technology domains. Improved online delivery has also made these programmes accessible to learners across the country,” it said.

Its portfolio has expanded over the past decade, the institute said, with growth particularly noticeable after 2020 and more programmes now offered in online and blended formats. Prof Vimal Kumar, in-charge

of outreach activities at IIT Kanpur, said Covid forced institutes to think differently. “Online learning is not a substitute to classroom learning, but it provides a close enough experience to obtain an IIT degree or certificate. Thanks to technological advancements, a lot of simulation-based learning possibilities are available too,” he said.

Executive programmes carry substantially higher fees than regular academic programmes. The MTech in Robotics and AI and the MTech in Flood and Water Resource Management, both at IIT Guwahati, cost Rs 8 lakh each, while its online PG Diploma in Healthcare Product Development and Management costs Rs 3.5 lakh.

Officials acknowledge executive education has become an important revenue stream, though they insist revenue is not the primary objective behind the expansion.

IIT Kharagpur said in a written response: “The difference in fees has a structural explanation before it has a commercial one. Degree programmes at an IIT are substantially supported by public funding. Executive programmes are not. They are self-financed, and the fee reflects the full cost of faculty time, content development, delivery, assessment and administration. Surplus, if any, is redeployed into programme development, faculty honoraria and the capacity to run the next set of programmes.”

IIT Delhi said that while the programmes are expected to be financially sustainable, revenue is not the sole driver of expansion. “Academic quality, industry relevance and the broader objective of lifelong learning continue to guide the institute’s approach to executive education,” it said.

Prof Soumitra Satapathi, Coordinator of the Continuing Education Centre (CEC) at IIT Roorkee, said, “But that is not the only thing, because quality is of utmost importance. Many times we have had to say no to companies if there was a possibility of compromise on quality.”

Prof Satapathi pointed out that costs rise in order to ensure quality. For instance, instead of depending entirely on ed-tech platforms to offer courses, IITs are looking at developing their own platforms.

The IIMs, meanwhile, have been offering short and long-term executive programmes for more than two decades in subjects ranging from HR to fintech and digital marketing.

T20 leagues

ongoing 10th edition of the TNPL runs till August 23 in Dindigul and Chennai.

The anti-corruption unit has reason to believe that the suspected bookie-player-owner nexus is not limited to the TNPL, sources said.

Leagues conducted by state associations are the third tier of T20 matches after the IPL and the national domestic T20 tournament for the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. Mumbai, Saurashtra, Bengal, Andhra, Karnataka, Delhi, UP, Bihar, Punjab, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Assam and Jharkhand have their own T20 leagues in the June-August window before the start of the domestic season.

According to sources, “quick money” is what bookies dangle to lure team owners and players, many of whom are club-level cricketers. “Because of the level at which they operate, some of the owners, organisers and players are vulnerable and may fall for offers from bookies. Several of them are under ACSU’s watch for violations. Their activities are being closely monitored and whoever is found guilty shall not be spared,” sources said.

On Friday, for instance, it emerged that a Tamil Nadu all-rounder who made his Ranji Trophy debut last season has been barred from featuring in the remainder of this TNPL season for breaching anti-corruption protocols. The ACSU is said to have recovered an undeclared mobile phone from the player

when he was in the Player and Match Officials Area (PMOA). Sources said this is not an isolated incident, as the ACSU has caught at least half a dozen players in different state leagues using mobile phones in these areas.

Tamil Nadu Cricket Association (TNCA) president T J Srinivasaraj said it is following all protocols mandated by ACSU for TNPL. “We are closely working with the ACSU team to ensure there is smooth coordination. There is constant communication between TNCA and ACSU to ensure the integrity of the game and the tournament isn’t compromised. That has always been our top priority,” he said.

Asked about the mobile phone incident in TNPL and the ACSU’s move to monitor all state-run T20 leagues, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said, “It was a minor incident which the BCCI’s ACSU took immediate note of and punished the player involved. Our anti-corruption unit is very active and alert, and they don’t want to let even small things be overlooked when it comes to integrity of the game.”

In 2018, the BCCI had issued strict guidelines for state-run leagues, including the mandatory presence of two ACSU officials for each tournament, conducting anti-corruption awareness programmes, and installation of CCTV cameras at all entry and exit points of the PMOA.

In 2019, the ACSU had conducted a probe into suspected bookies being in touch with players and coaches in the TNPL. The findings of that probe were not made public.

International Crimes Tribunal for committing crimes against humanity. We have made our position clear on this matter,” it said. Hasina has been sentenced to death in Bangladesh courts, and her party Awami League has been banned.

“We reiterate that we will continue to pursue our ‘Bangladesh First’ policy to promote friendly bilateral relations with other countries, including our neighbours, on the basis of sovereign equality, national dignity, non-interference in each other’s internal affairs and mutual benefit,” it said.

The Indian EXPRESS
Classifieds
FROM ANYTHING TO EVERYTHING

EXPRESS EDUCATION

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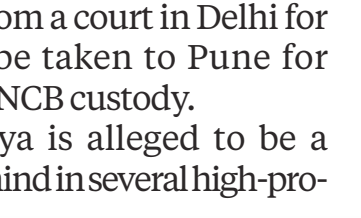
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Ex-Deputy Speaker

TMC office was close to his home. According to Birbhum police, his body was found hanging from a ceiling fan in a room that was locked from inside. His body has been sent for postmortem.

Asish Banerjee, a doctorate degree-holder and retired associate professor at Rampurhat College, was a veteran TMC leader. In 2011, he joined the Mamata Banerjee Cabinet and over the years handled key portfolios including School Education and Agriculture. He was elected Deputy Speaker of the Assembly in July 2021 and remained in the post until May 2026.

He won the Rampurhat seat as a TMC candidate for the first time in 2001 and held it until 2026 when he lost to BJP’s Dhruva Saha.

A relative said that the former MLA, on Independence Day, had hoisted the national flag at the party office and stayed there all day. “I spoke to him while he was sitting at the office. We hang out every night, though I didn’t go yesterday... I feel he was under immense mental anguish. Many people were insulting him in various ways. It must

have stemmed from a sense of self-respect,” he said.

Banerjee’s brother Prasanta said, “Even last night we were sitting and chatting together. It was impossible to tell that he would do such a thing.”

“I condemn everything that was done to malign me,” a relative quoted Banerjee as having written in the purported suicide note. “Although I could not accept all of the party’s wrongdoings throughout my life, I could not protest either. I never took a single penny in exchange for any work in my entire life.”

“At the end, Asish wrote that no one was responsible for his death. He did not mention anyone involved in politics. Nor did he make direct allegations against anyone or reveal who tried to humiliate him,” said the relative.

Banerjee is also said to have written that he realised entering politics was a mistake and advised his family members against doing so.

TMC office, would be examined. “The handwritten suicide note that has been recovered on Asish Banerjee’s letterhead pad will be investigated. The handwriting will also be examined,” Adhikari said, adding that he has asked police to investigate whether Banerjee had been threatened.)

Reacting to Banerjee’s death, former CM Mamata Banerjee said, “The passing of Asish Banerjee has left me deeply disturbed. He spent much of his life teaching and serving society with dedication, (was) always known for his humble nature and had close bonds with the people of Rampurhat and Birbhum.”

“What makes this tragedy even more painful is the immense mental and emotional strain he appears to have endured in his final days... despite the work he did, he was repeatedly maligned, falsely accused and subjected to relentless pressure,” she said.

Banerjee’s stint in faction-ridden Birbhum politics was not without rows and controversies. It coincided with the tenure of party strongman Anubrata Mondal as TMC district president. After his poll defeat in May, he withdrew from active politics, and in June stepped down as chairman of TMC’s Birbhum district core committee.

A DOSE OF TRUST

In February, India rolled out a critical public health initiative aiming to vaccinate adolescent girls against cervical cancer. Progress has been uneven so far. **VIDHEESHA KUNTAMALLA** made a spot check at Delhi government schools across the Capital.

THE FIRST student in Sarvodaya Kanya Vidyalaya in South Delhi's Fatehpur Beri to take the HPV vaccine was made class monitor.

It was an unusual reward for taking an injection. But in a school where parents were still asking whether the vaccine was safe, whether it could cause illness, or even whether it could affect their daughters' ability to have children, the teachers wanted the girl to become an example for others.

It was a reward, teachers said, for the courage to go first.

The Class X student had first heard about HPV — Human Papillomavirus — only a few weeks earlier, during a morning assembly in the school. "I was the first to get this vaccine in my school, just before my 15th birthday in June," she said.

On the day, she joined 10 other girls, all aged between 14 and 15, and walked to the neighbourhood dispensary. Two teachers accompanied them. Each girl carried a consent form signed by a parent or guardian.

Inside, health workers verified their identities before administering the vaccine in the upper arm.

"It felt like a small pinprick," the girl said. "There was no fever, no allergy, nothing happened afterwards."

In Delhi's government schools, the early experience of India's nationwide HPV vaccination drive, launched on February 28, suggests that getting adolescent girls vaccinated may depend as much on winning over their parents as on making the vaccine available.

Delhi has administered over 14,000 vaccine doses. In July, the government had made a renewed push in schools with an ambitious target of vaccinating 1.49 lakh girls over the next 100 days.

Teachers and school principals across several schools told *The Indian Express* that concerns about safety, fertility and a lack of awareness about cervical cancer continued to hold parents back, even after several rounds of awareness sessions. Their accounts suggest that building trust through simple language, personal stories and sustained awareness efforts will be key to reaching the government's ambitious vaccination targets.

Back at the school, when the Class 10 student was made class monitor, girls began approaching her with questions, the most common being: "Does it hurt?"

"I told them there was nothing to worry about. Everyone is scared of injections. I told them it was just like a tiny pinprick," she said.

Her father had heard about the vaccine through friends who work at AIIMS. "When the school informed us about the drive, he immediately said, 'Yes, go ahead'. I wasn't scared," the girl said.

Before any girl received the vaccine, a consent form had to be signed. Routed through the government's U-WIN portal, it asks a parent or guardian to declare they understand why the child's personal data is being collected, and that they are aware of "the risks and benefits of the vaccine(s) to be administered".

But signing a consent form did not necessarily mean trust.

Response on the ground

At Fatehpur Beri, when the principal convened a meeting for hesitant parents and students in the school library, the girl and three other vaccinated students were asked to stand before the gathering.

"The principal asked us in front of everyone whether we had fever, allergy or any health problems," she recalled. "We told them nothing had happened."

For many parents in the room, it was perhaps the first time they were hearing directly from a child who had already taken the vaccine.

The school's science teacher quickly realised that 'Human Papillomavirus' meant little to many families. Even cervical cancer was unfamiliar.

So, she abandoned medical jargon altogether. She began calling it "bachchedani

ke muh ka cancer" -- cancer at the mouth of the womb.

"We had to speak in the language people understood," she told *The Indian Express*.

The teacher also had a personal reason for encouraging girls to take the vaccine -- her sister had tested positive for HPV.

Months of training sessions — online and offline, working through PowerPoint slide decks on HPV, cervical cancer and the questions parents were likely to ask, gave her the vocabulary and her sister's diagnosis gave her the reason to use it.

During a school assembly, she told her students about her decision to get vaccinated.

"The training helped us understand how to explain it simply," she said, but it was the personal disclosure, students and colleagues said, that made parents in the room understand better.

Soon, the response spilled out of the classroom and onto the walls. "Students designed posters and charts in schools explaining cervical cancer," she said, describing rows of hand-drawn diagrams of the reproductive system and slogans urging classmates not to be afraid of "the pinprick."

The exercise, she said, "created more confidence in students and in parents".

Slowly, the girls in her class began coming forward. "We would escort the students to the nearby dispensary almost every alternate day with whoever would come forward," the teacher said.

The response, however, was not the same everywhere. Barely 25 km away, at a CM Shri school in North Delhi, around 20 to 25 girls were eligible for the vaccine. Fourteen parents signed consent forms. Yet, not a single girl, teachers said, has been vaccinated so far.

Among the eligible girls was a 14-year-old whose parents still did not sign the consent form. "My *khala* (aunt) said I might get sick after the injection," the student recalled. "My mother said we should wait and see what happens to the other girls first."

Two of her friends had also been keen to get vaccinated, she said, until their parents changed their minds after hearing similar stories doing the rounds in the neighbourhood.

A government school in Northeast Delhi's Yamuna Vihar tells another story.

Extensive awareness campaigns here were held in the school — doctors visited, morning assemblies were devoted to the vaccine, school counsellors spoke to students. Still, of roughly 259 eligible girls, the principal said, only close to 60 eventually got the shot. "I honestly didn't expect the numbers to be so low," she said.

The bottlenecks

Across the three schools, language was a serious hurdle.

While some teachers explain what HPV and cervical cancer are in simple terms, others reach for family memory instead -- mothers, aunts, grandmothers who fell ill.

The science teacher at Fateh Beri school points to another hurdle: bandwidth.

"Teachers treated it like another duty," she said. "Lists were prepared. Data was sent. But when students didn't go for vaccination, there wasn't much follow-up. No one has taken them to the dispensary yet."

Twice a week, outside her regular classes, she tries to fold HPV into lessons on cells and cancer that students are already studying, but says the school simply doesn't have the staff to do sustained, individual follow-up. "We have very few teachers. Every teacher already has a heavy workload. Sometimes programmes become administrative exercises... we complete the paperwork because that's what we're required to do," she said.

In Yamuna Vihar, the principal identifies "suspicion" as another hurdle.

"They (parents) felt developed countries conduct research here because we have such a large population... Some believed private companies were driving the programme... Others worried about fertility: What if my daughter cannot have children later?"

"The biggest issue is awareness," she



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

• Timeline

2008: Gardasil and Cervarix vaccines enter private market yet inaccessible

2009-10: Vaccine demonstration in Andhra Pradesh and Gujarat suspended after seven girls die. Government probe finds no link.

2016: Punjab launches a pilot in Mansa and Bathinda. Delhi runs a hospital-based programme.

2017: India's vaccine advisory body, NTAGI, recommends including vaccination in the Universal Immunisation Programme. Global vaccine shortages delay the rollout.

2018: Sikkim becomes the first state to offer free, school-based vaccination statewide, reporting over 95% coverage.

2022: CERVAVAC launched, India gets its first indigenous HPV vaccine.

said. "Unless parents understand, nothing changes."

She believes public messaging around HPV has never matched the scale of the campaign. "There should have been much more publicity. People need confidence that this is genuinely in their children's interest."

"The girls listened to us in school when we tried to amplify the awareness around HPV," she said. "It was the parents who needed convincing," she added.

"The kids who come to our school are first generation learners. They come from labour class families... it is harder for us to impart the idea of a vaccine to them than it is for schools in the private sector," the principal said.

The stakeholders

Outside Delhi's government schools, the campaign begins much earlier than the classroom. Every morning, ASHA (Accredited Social Health Activist) workers fan out through narrow lanes carrying lists of names of adolescent girls in their respective neighbourhoods. Their job: explain what HPV is, persuade parents and, and then get them to actually make the trip to the dispensary.

By 9.30 am, Poonam Sharma (43), an ASHA worker for about a decade now, is already knocking on doors in Nangloi.

"We explain that this vaccine protects girls from cervical cancer. But if I explain it to eight or ten families, maybe only one or two eventually go," she said.

The reasons, she added, are rarely medical. "Rumours travel faster than the government," she said. "They tell us the vaccine isn't good. They say girls won't be able to have children later. Sometimes parents understand everything I explain. Then they speak to a neighbour, and the neighbour tells them not to get the vaccine."

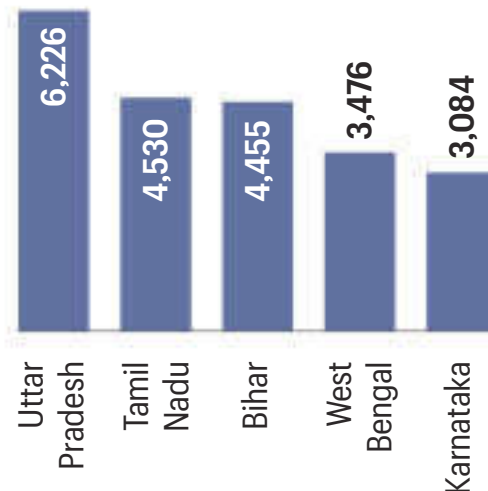
When persuasion fails, she calls in reinforcement: "I ask the ANM (auxiliary nurse midwife) to speak to them. Sometimes they

• The numbers: Cervical cancer's burden

Year	India: Estimated cases	India: Deaths	Delhi: Estimated incidence	Delhi: Estimated mortality
2019	—	32,246	—	—
2020	—	33,095	—	—
2021	77,000	33,938	793	428
2022	77,426	34,806	767	414
2023	77,959	35,691	741	400
2024	78,499	—	716	387
2025	79,239	—	692	374

SOURCE: MINISTRY OF HEALTH AND FAMILY WELFARE

• Estimated cervical cancer deaths, 2025



listen to her."

In the months since the drive began, Poonam estimated she has spoken to nearly a hundred families. But only around 12 girls in her neighbourhood have been vaccinated, she claimed. Unlike the pulse polio campaign, she points out, the HPV drive has had no memorable public jingle, no slogan to trail it into every home.

So, she has found another way to build trust. "I tell them I have a daughter too... I have got her vaccinated. When they hear that, they feel more confident," she added.

Nearly 20 km away, in Kailash Nagar, Ashu (33), has spent seven years working in the same neighbourhood. Unlike in Nangloi, almost all eligible girls in her area have now been vaccinated.

For Ashu, the difference is familiarity. "We've been visiting these families for years. We work on family planning, malaria, leprosy, routine immunisation, pregnancy, polio. They know us. Trust is built long before any vaccine arrives," she said.

"Five fingers are never the same. Some families agree immediately. Some don't. It also depends on how we explain it. If we don't speak patiently, how will they ever

reach the dispensary?"

Inside Delhi's private schools, the same stakeholders show up in a different light.

At ITL Public School in Dwarka, HPV awareness didn't begin with the government's campaign, it had been part of the school's annual adolescent health programme for several years.

Instead of hurried classroom announcements, the school brings doctors, alumni and parents into its auditorium, usually on a Saturday, so working parents can attend. "The biggest questions are always the same," said Surabhi, a teacher who is in charge of the vaccine programme in school. "Parents ask whether the vaccine is safe. They ask whether it will affect fertility." Increasingly, the answers come from former students, many now MBBS graduates, who return to speak to parents and girls. "They immediately connect, because these are girls who once studied in the same classrooms," Surabhi said.

Unlike government schools, ITL doesn't take the students to the dispensary.

"We can only create awareness," she said. "The decision ultimately belongs to the family."



Showing Up

FORMER VICE President M Venkaiah Naidu made a rare appearance at a BJP event in Delhi on Sunday when he inaugurated 25 Atal Canteens to mark former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee's 8th death anniversary. Naidu, who had resigned from the BJP after being named NDA's candidate for the post of Vice President in 2017 and usually stays away from the party events, made an exception to break bread with Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, BJP Lok Sabha MPs from Delhi, and other senior leaders.

Moving Out

WITH THE demolition of one of the oldest post-Independence government offices in Lutyens' Delhi, Krishi Bhawan, likely to start soon, the Ministries of Agriculture and Animal Husbandry are set to move out of the iconic building and out of Lutyens' Delhi altogether. It is learnt that the two ministries will soon be relocated to the government office complex at Netaji Nagar in South Delhi, while the sites of Krishi Bhawan and neighbouring Shastri Bhawan are to be redeveloped into new secretariat buildings.

Change, Clarity

WEEKS AFTER the Cabinet Secretariat issued a notification bifurcating the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs in July, sources say the two new departments are still adjusting to the change. While the CPWD and NBCC, the two construction arms of the ministry, have been listed under Department of Capital Development, sources say the majority of their projects are outside Delhi. Urban transport as a subject is under Department of Urban Development, while Delhi Metro and NCRTC are under Department of Capital Development, even though DMRC works as a consultant on metro projects outside the capital. It is learnt that efforts are on to bring clarity on some of the issues.

Gujarat CM heads to US, Canada

Ahmedabad: Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel Sunday departed for the US and Canada to promote Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2027 to be held in January. The delegation, led by Patel, will hold conferences in Washington DC, New York, San Francisco and Toronto with industrial investors and leaders from tech sector. The visit will conclude on August 24. ENS

EXPRESS special

Why faces of CJP Delhi stir 'missing' in Ranchi

Outfit claims it wants to empower local student leaders, not 'hijack movement'

Shubham Tigga & Alok Singh
Ranchi, New Delhi, August 16

HAVING PLAYED a central role in Jantar Mantar agitation against exam paper leaks only weeks ago, the CJP has largely remained in the background in Ranchi as students continue to protest against alleged irregularities in state government exams. The CJP's well-known faces from the Delhi protest — national convener Abhijeet Dipke and co-conveners Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka — have been absent from protest. And that, the CJP claims, is by design.

On August 9, Dipke had a video call with Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) leader Devendra Nath Mahato, who has been on a hunger strike. The following day, asked if he would travel to Ranchi, Dipke told reporters in Mahatara: "Mahato is leading the Jharkhand protest. He was leading protest effectively. We don't want to hijack the protest."

Dipke said he was in touch with Mahato and other student leaders and that a CJP team was in Jharkhand. Leading the 25-member delegation is Mukesh

Allrounder, an activist from Rajasthan with a past in AAP like many in the CJP, including Dipke and Ranka.

However, questions have been raised why the outfit that recently led one of the largest student agitations of the past few years — and is now looking to establish its presence across the country — has stayed away from Ranchi demonstrations.

"We have seen that students here have not supported the CJP ... If they want to come, they can come, but they should follow the right way of protesting. They should not repeat what the Left organisations did at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, where the protest turned violent," ABVP leader Satyam Mishra told *The Indian Express*. The RSS's student wing is one of the participants in the protests against the JMM-Congress government.

Mishra said the ABVP does not want outsiders to interfere with the protest and that the protest should remain peaceful. "Slogans like 'Azadi' are not required here. We don't need such an agenda in Jharkhand. We can protest peacefully."

The Indian Express reached



Mukesh Allrounder (left) is leading CJP delegation in Ranchi

out to both Abhijeet Dipke and Saurav Das to ask them about their absence from Ranchi, but they did not respond.

However, the CJP's legal affairs lead Ratna Singh told *The Indian Express*, "We have been saying our protest at Jantar Mantar was also supposed to be a leaderless movement and now, going forward, CJP is supposed to act like a political pressure group. We don't want people to hero-worship or think of the CJP as having three faces and expect everything from them. Since the July 25 victory (Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation), the youth have been empowered. They are capable of organising and fighting in their own way towards seeking accountability from any government."

Harsimrat writes to Shah, seeks NIA probe into attacks on Sukhbir

Raakhi Jagga & Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, August 16

MP HARSIMRAT Kaur wrote to Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday seeking a National Investigation Agency (NIA) probe into the August 13 kirpan attack on her husband and SAD chief Sukhbir Singh Badal in Maharashtra and an assassination attempt on him at the Golden Temple in December 2024.

Harsimrat Kaur described the August 13 incident in Maharashtra's Nanded as a "dastardly and heinous assassination bid".

The two assassination at-

tempts had "several disturbing parallels" and raised serious questions about whether they were connected and a "larger conspiracy" behind them, the former Union minister said in her letter to Shah.

"I write with a mix of personal pain and profound concern for our society, our state of Punjab and our country, particularly over the manner in which violence is being normalised and even justified by persons holding positions of power in Punjab, apparently as a means of pursuing political battles," wrote Kaur, who was present at the time of the attack at Gurdwara Mata Sahib Devan Ji in Nanded.



Army Chief begins Nepal visit

Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth arrives in Kathmandu on a four-day official trip on Sunday. He is set to visit the Nepal Army Headquarters on Monday. ANI

TDP MP backs PM's 'dimagi Naxal' remark: New 'form' threat to youth

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 16

TDP MP and former IPS officer Tenneti Krishna Prasad, an NDA ally, on Sunday backed PM Narendra Modi's "dimagi Naxals" remarks, saying a new form of "intellectual Naxalism" has emerged and poses a danger to the country and its youth.

"The forest Naxalites and Maoists have been removed from the forests; now this new form has emerged. Therefore, we have to remain extremely vigilant and protect our country, especially our youth,"

he said in a video statement.

The "dimagi Naxal" reference came from Modi's Independence Day address to the nation, in which he warned against people who were looking for an opportunity to trigger violence.

In an apparent reference to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, Prasad said, "Today, the forest Naxalites have gone, and a new form has emerged. I call them 'intellectual Naxalites'. They do not operate in forests; they operate in cities. They organise seminars in AC halls.

"They take foreign money and work to destroy our country. Those who run this so-

called intellectual Naxalism live in our country but repeatedly go abroad and conduct seminars and bring money from outside," he said, without taking any name.

Prasad said he served as an IPS officer for 35 years and during that period he fought Naxalism in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, where he witnessed the impact of the extremist left ideology on the lives of the young people.

"Whether it is Maoist, Naxalism, forest Naxalism or what I call intellectual Naxalism, both are prepared to destroy our country," he added.

With multi-layer barricading, Haryana seals Khanauri border to stop farmers' Delhi march

Express News Service
Chandigarh, August 16

HARYANA POLICE have set up multi-layer barricading along the inter-state border point Sunday and sealed it as farmers under the banner of SKM (Non-Political) gathered to enter Haryana through the Khanauri-Data Singh Wala border.

The Samyukt Kisan Morcha (Non-Political) had given a call for a 228-km 'Kisan Bachao Padyatra' from Data Singh Wala village on Haryana-Punjab border to Jantar Mantar in Delhi, which would culminate in a farmers' panchayat in Delhi on August 29. The march has been



At Khanauri border in Jind after farmers' 'Kisan Bachao Padyatra' call to march to Jantar Mantar, on Sunday. ANI

planned against the proposed India-US trade deal and to press for a legal guarantee for MSP.

On the Haryana side of Kha-

Protesters: If demands not met, Soren should quit



Students during an indefinite hunger strike in Ranchi on Sunday. PTI

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 16

AS THE JPSC-JSSC students' protest entered its 23rd day, protesters on Sunday announced a change in the "framework of their movement" as they issued an ultimatum to the Jharkhand government and warned of a march to Chief Minister Hemant Soren's residence on August 20 if their demands were not fulfilled.

The students also officially announced, for the first time, that they would demand the CM's resignation if the government fails to meet their demands. They also announced plans to burn the effigies of Soren, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and other leaders associated with the ruling alliance across all 24 districts of Jharkhand on Sunday evening.

The announcement marks an important turn in the student agitation, which has intensified since the August 10 march towards the Jharkhand Assembly, when protesters clashed with police and faced water cannons, tear gas and lathis.

Piyush Singh, a spokesperson for JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch, said the students have four principal demands: Cancellation of the JSSC-CGL (Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level) examination, cancellation of the 11th to 13th JPSC exams, cancellation of all exams conducted

through or linked to TDPL (the testing agency), and involvement of CBI in the inquiries.

Last week, as the government announced cancellation of three JPSC-linked exams, a minister said the CGL exam results could not be cancelled as the process was conducted under the monitoring of the Supreme Court and the High Court.

"If these demands are not fulfilled by the government, we will march towards the Chief Minister's residence. We are officially announcing for the first time that if these demands are not met, the Chief Minister will have to resign," Singh said.

Another student leader, Ravindra Paswan, said the protesters would now change the framework of their movement. "The time has come to change the framework of the movement. The Gandhian movement is over. Now we will become Bhagat Singh. Even if we have to take a bullet, we will take it on our chest," Paswan said.

Responding to the students' ultimatum, spokesperson of the ruling Jharkhand Mukti Morcha Manoj Pandey said the government has been taking the issue seriously since the beginning. Questioning the involvement of coaching operators and teachers, Pandey said, "Why is there a need for coaching operators or coaching teachers to come into this matter? Why are they guiding the students?" he said.

wire has also been installed. A police official from Jind district Sunday said the farmers do not have permission for the march.

SKM (non-political) leader Jagjit Singh Dallewal said the barricading has exposed the BJP government. "Earlier, they had a problem when farmers came with tractors. Now, a small group of farmers wants to march to Delhi, they still are not allowing us to proceed. This exposes the anti-farmer face of the government."

He also claimed that Haryana Police detained some leaders of the outfit at different places ahead of the march which was to start from Khanauri.

● FROM JANTAR MANTAR TO RANCHI, YOUTH PROTESTS HAVE PROMPTED CMs ACROSS PARTY LINES TO ANNOUNCE A SLEW OF WELFARE MEASURES IN THEIR INDEPENDENCE DAY SPEECHES

Jobs to exam coaching, how CMs are trying to douse discontent among youth

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, August 16

RATTLED BY the youth protests in Delhi and Ranchi, a theme running through the Independence Day speeches and announcements of political leaders — from PM Narendra Modi to CMs of BJP and Opposition-ruled states — was "yuva shakti (youth power)."

BJP CMs in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and Goa — all go to polls next year — made promises designed for the youth.

UP CM Yogi Adityanath announced a new youth policy to strengthen skills, innovation abilities, and employment of youngsters aged 16-35 years. "The government has taken strict action against cheating mafia and recruitment mafia, and the state's demographic dividend is being transformed

into a 'development engine'. For Gen Z and Gen Alpha, work has been rapidly advanced in areas such as AI, Machine Learning, semiconductors, startup ecosystem, data centres, defence manufacturing, cyber, robotics, EVs, agritech, fintech, deeptech and med tech," he said.

Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami announced "Mukhya Mantri Yuva Bhavishya Nirman Yojana", allocating Rs 7 crore for it, to improve opportunities of government school students for competitive exams. Free online coaching will be provided to 10,000 students in Classes 11 and 12.

Dhami also announced a "Yuva Ayog (youth commission)" and that the "Mukhya Mantri Yuva Swarojgar aur Udamita Protsahan Yojana (youth self-employment and entrepreneurship incentive scheme)"

will be launched for those in the 18-30 age group.

Goa CM Pramod Sawant announced that more than 2,000 jobs will be offered to youngsters through the Goa Staff Selection Commission.

A BJP leader in UP said the recent protests in Delhi had brought the problem of paper leaks and unemployment to drawing rooms of every household. "If the discussion continues for a long time, or a fresh agitation starts, that will certainly damage us electorally. The results of government's initiatives and measures to prevent paper leaks will be seen in the future, but the announcements and promises by the PM and CMs will hopefully offset some damage and help the party win the trust of youths," he said.

A senior BJP leader in Uttarakhand said that while unem-



CM Yogi Adityanath pays tribute to Atal Bihari Vajpayee in Lucknow on Sunday. PTI

ployment was an issue in the hill state too, like in the rest of the country, paper leaks were not. "Still, announcements by the

CM have been made to convince the youths that the government is taking steps for their employment and skill development and that they should not fall into the trap of the Opposition that is trying to mislead them."

Like in the states going to polls early next year, announcements poured in from other BJP-ruled states too:

GUJARAT: In the state where elections are due in late 2027, CM Bhupendra Patel announced that "for youth from the non-creamy layer section (in reserved categories), the family's annual income limit for foreign study loans has been increased from Rs 6 lakh to Rs 10 lakh".

ASSAM: In his 11 resolutions for a Viksit Assam, CM Himanta Biswa Sarma said a new department of "youth empowerment and development" would work for youth welfare. Sarma, how-

ever, said he doesn't believe in demographic concepts such as Gen Z or Gen Alpha. "These are concepts from Western culture. For me, they are my sons and daughters. For our new generation, we have a responsibility to work for them and use the state's resources."

BIHAR: Samrat Choudhary announced a State Examination Reforms Committee to make exams smooth, transparent, fair, and modern. A "student support portal" will be launched on August 17 to help redress students' grievances within 30 days, said the CM.

CHHATTISGARH: CM Vishnu Deo Sai announced a "CG Assistant for Competitive Exam" scheme for financial and logistical support to youth preparing for major competitive tests.

MADHYA PRADESH: CM Mohan Yadav said his govern-

ment had decided to observe 2027 as "Yuva varsh" and focus on quality education, skill development, entrepreneurship employment opportunities in public, private sectors and support for start-ups, among others.

RAJASTHAN: Though there were no youth-specific announcements in Rajasthan, CM Bhajan Lal Sharma in an interaction with youngsters in Bikaner assured them his government was fully committed to their all-round development.

Opp states join in

Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvir Singh Sukhu said, "Our Congress government provided government jobs to thousands of youths and ensured transparency in recruitment process. During our tenure, not a single recruitment paper was leaked, whereas during previous

BJP government's tenure, the police recruitment paper was leaked and large-scale irregularities occurred in SSC's recruitments, to the extent that papers were even sold."

Himachal goes to polls later next year. Sukhu said the government has dissolved the Subordinate Selection Board, and ensured that those responsible were in jail.

In Jharkhand, where students are protesting alleged irregularities in JPSC and JSSC exams, CM Hemant Soren said protecting the dreams of youths was his personal responsibility.

Soren said he had acted against the guilty and would ensure reforms in the system.

The CM also said his government had initiated an interactive programme "Chhatron Ki Baat — Chhatron Ke Sath" to seek students' suggestions.



100 DAYS OF BHOROSHA



A
New Chapter Begins
in West Bengal



Shilpo | Swastho | Siksha | Sushashon
Shoshoktikoron | Seva | Suraksha | Samriddhi



100 DAYS

PORIBORTON AT A GLANCE

» 100 DAYS OF SHILPO

- ₹54,000+ crore worth investment proposals
- ₹5,000 crore Investment Promotion Framework
- Single-window clearance for investments above ₹100 crore
- ₹100 crore Startup Fund to encourage new ventures and young entrepreneurs

» 100 DAYS OF SUSHASHON

- Anti-Goonda Act brought into force
- Janatar Darbar brings people's grievances directly to the Chief Minister
- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam implemented across the State
- Toll-free helpline to report bribery, extortion, illegal toll booths and illicit liquor trade

» 100 DAYS OF SURAKSHA

- 1,000+ acres transferred to the BSF to strengthen border security
- Durga Suraksha Squads and Pink Patrols patrolling streets to ensure women's safety
- Cyber Help Desks in every police station to combat cyber fraud
- Women's Police Stations in every subdivision and Women's Help Centres in every police station

» 100 DAYS OF SAMRIDDHI

- West Bengal's first Atal Incubation Centre (AIC Techno) launched in Kolkata, to nurture young entrepreneurs and startups
- Transparent OBC reservation framework ensures the annulment of the unlawful 17% reservation and ensuring a fair 7% reservation
- 2 crore+ trees already planted across the state under the Ekti Gaach Mayer Namey initiative
- New airports to come up in Purulia, Balurghat and Malda, with a second greenfield airport underway in Kalyani

» 100 DAYS OF SWASTHO

- Free treatment up to ₹5 lakh under the Mukhyamantri Swasthya Yojana
- 1.43 crore families covered under Ayushman Bharat
- 2,000-bed state-of-the-art hospital coming up in New Town, with 1,000 beds reserved for the underprivileged
- AIIMS and a state-of-the-art cancer hospital in North Bengal, along with modern state-run hospitals in the Sundarbans and Jangalmahal

» 100 DAYS OF SHOSHOKTIKORON

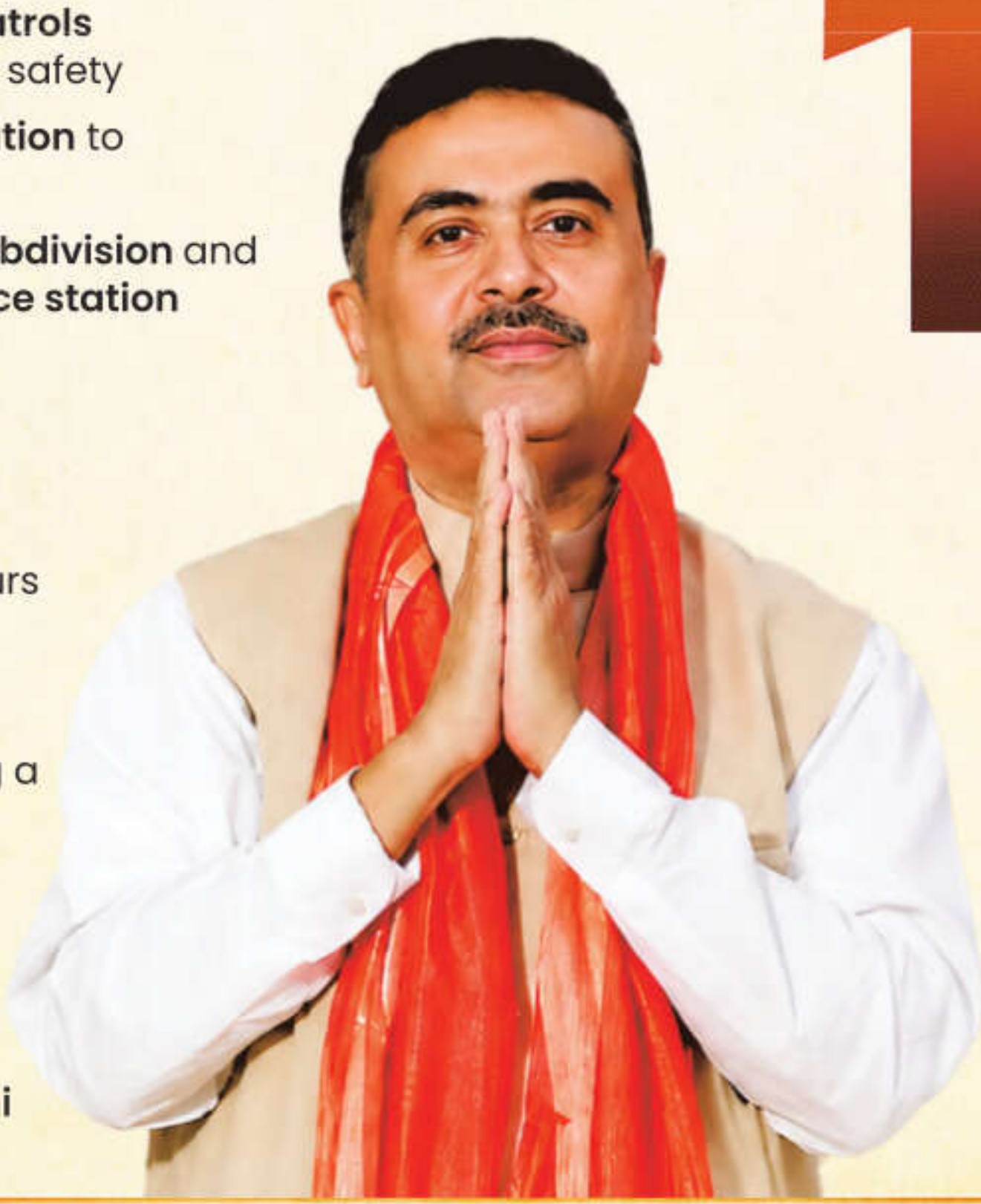
- ₹3,000 monthly credited to the bank accounts of 1.19 crore Annapurna beneficiaries
- Free travel for women on government buses
- To secure the future of the youth, work has already commenced for creating 1 lakh government jobs by the next year
- 33% reservation for women announced in government jobs

» 100 DAYS OF SIKSHA

- Higher Mid-Day Meal allocation and improved food quality in collaboration with ISKCON
- Nearly 35,000 books from libraries across West Bengal made easily accessible online
- ₹296 crore financial assistance to improve government and Bengali-medium schools
- Sanitary napkin vending machines installed in government schools; 10 lakh+ girl students covered under Kanyaratna

» 100 DAYS OF SEVA

- ₹60,000 provided to 10.20 lakh beneficiaries under Awas Yojana
- Fish and rice now served at Maa Ahar canteens
- ₹500 increase in monthly pensions for senior citizens, widows and persons with disabilities
- Daily food allocation for patients in government hospitals increased from ₹56 to ₹110



100

DAYS OF

BHOROSHA

A commitment to development.
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NEW GOVERNMENT | NEW DIRECTION
NEW WEST BENGAL

ICAD1263(17)2026

‘Weak leadership’: 3 lawyers’ collectives seek resignation of Bar Council head

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 16

THREE LAWYERS’ collectives, with over 700 members across the country, on Sunday demanded the resignation of Bar Council of India (BCI) Chairman Manan Kumar Mishra following the NALSAR controversy.

The lawyers said if Mishra does not resign, other members of the Bar Council should invoke a no-confidence motion against him. This comes a day after Mishra apologised to the law students – after first issuing a directive barring 2026 graduates of the Hyderabad-based university from enrolment with state bar councils, and later withdrawing the order.

All India Lawyers Association for Justice, National Alliance for Justice Accountability and Rights, and Queer Lawyers Association, which, according to their leaders, have over 700 members, have endorsed a letter to Mishra, which demands his resignation.

A press statement released by the collective read, “In light of the deeply disturbing and embarrassing episode between BCI Chair and NALSAR students,

we, as members of the legal fraternity, are deeply ashamed that the statutory institution that governs us is led by Mr Manan Kumar Mishra — a man so prone to arbitrariness that he frequently fails in upholding the interests and integrity of the Bar, in his pursuit of powers that be.”

The collective further argued, “The independence, integrity and autonomy of the legal profession is critical for a robust democracy.... Our ancestors in the Bar have made immense contributions to our great nation’s struggle for freedom from British Colonialism. This struggle was made possible only by great courage, integrity and capacity for protest against what people felt was unjust. We are concerned there is an immense decline in this capacity today, given such weak leadership.”

The lawyers said, “We have written to Mishra, expressing our discontent with his actions and demanding that he resign forthwith; failing which, we will soon be writing to the other members of the Bar Council of India to pass a resolution of no-confidence against him. It is time to raise the bar for the Indian Bar”.

Train students to meet AI challenges, tech part of changing world: CJI to law schools

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATIONS must make justice faster and not less fair, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said on Sunday while asking law schools to train students to meet the challenges posed by artificial intelligence.

Speaking at the second edition of the Vice Chancellors’ Conclave organised by National Law University, Jodhpur, on the theme ‘Legal technology and its roadmap: Positioning law as a leader in legal technology’, the CJI said whatever

path a student chooses after graduating in law, “they must be able to understand technology not as something external to legal reasoning, but as a part of the changing world in which they will work”.

He added that “the responsibility of four law schools therefore is not simply to familiarise students with new tools, but to equip them with the judgement, adaptability and ethical grounding needed to use those tools responsibly in whichever sphere they enter”.

“Ultimately, whether this technological future serves justice or subverts it, will depend



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

substantially on the habits we instil in our students today,” he said.

CJI Kant pointed out that there is “a defensive instinct to keep technology, particularly

the newer generative tools, out of the classroom altogether” due to anxieties about the risks around it.

He, however, added that prohibition was not the answer to that risk and changes of this nature do not wait for institutional comfort. “It is inevitable, and an institution that resists the inevitable does not stop it; it only forfeits its own role in shaping it. The better approach is to bring these tools into the classroom in a transparent, supervised manner, so that students learn not only how to use them, but also to use them appropriately and ethically. The

questions of artificial intelligence and academic integrity are therefore among the most important questions legal education must confront today...,” the CJI said.

The CJI stressed that “it is not enough for legal education merely to adapt to technology because adaptation, by its very nature, means responding to change after it has occurred. If law is truly to lead in this space... we must aspire to something more — to foresee change, shape its direction, and ensure that technology develops in service of the law and the values it seeks to uphold”.

8-year-old among 2 killed by big cats in UP’s Bahraich

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 16

AS MORE than 500 villages in Moradabad and Bijnor districts remain on high alert following a series of leopard attacks, two fresh wildlife attacks in Bahraich’s Katarniaghat Wildlife Division have triggered fear among the communities living on the fringes of the forest.

The attacks, reported from two separate ranges, left two dead, a woman and an eight-

year-old boy. The two incidents were reported from Dharmapur and Motipur ranges of the Katarniaghat Wildlife Division, where forest officials have stepped up efforts to track the animals.

“Teams from the forest department are camping in the affected areas and monitoring the situation. People of around 15 villages have been advised to exercise caution while venturing into fields or forest areas,” said Katarniaghat Wildlife Division Field Director H Raja Mohan.

Arunachal student dies by suicide in Kerala, protesters pin blame on college’s ‘harsh’ credit score system

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 16

AN ENGINEERING student from Arunachal Pradesh was found dead at his rented accommodation near his college at Kothamangalam in Ernakulam district on Saturday. The death triggered protests by students on Sunday who pinned the blame on the college’s “harsh” credit score system.

Higher Education Minister Roji M John has asked the college to discontinue the “year back” system, which requires a student to repeat an academic year, while directing the college to conduct a probe into the matter.

The deceased student was identified as Michi Marpu, 20, hailing from Papum Pare district in Arunachal Pradesh. He was a fifth semester B Tech student at Mar Athanasius College of Engineering, an autonomous institute, at Kothamangalam.

Police said they have registered a case of unnatural death and a probe is underway.

Marpu was staying as a paying guest on a rented premises along with other stu-

dents. Around 3 pm, he was found dead. A suicide note was also recovered, police said.

A student, who was part of the protest on Sunday and does not want to be identified, said, “The college had sacked him from the class one-and-a-half month ago. Even that decision was not properly communicated to him.”

In all colleges under the Kerala Technological University, the credit score is 18, whereas at Mar Athanasius, it is 22.

He feared that as he did not meet the credit score ceiling fixed by the college, he would be forced to repeat the entire year. The college is charging a hefty fee for supplementary exams.”

College principal Dr Bose Mathew said the victim had not been attending the classes since July when the fifth semester of the B Tech commenced. “He had lost (failed) four subjects in the previous semester. Our college is an autonomous institute and we have our own syllabus and credit score. Other autonomous colleges in Kerala have similar credit scores.

The protesting students have raised several demands, including reducing the credit score from 22 to 18. Our academic council will make a decision. We will also address the students’ demand to reduce the fee for supplementary examinations,” he said.

The college principal said the student had joined the college under the national quota. “We have had several students from Arunachal Pradesh and other states over the years,” he said.

Police sources said, “Prima facie, our probe showed the student has taken the extreme step due to issues related to studies. At present, we have registered a case of unnatural death. The suicide note also indicates issues about studies... The autonomous status of the college is a big issue. They can fix the norms and other processes. Hence, prima facie, we cannot find fault with issues like credit score fixed by the college.”

Minister John, meanwhile, told the media that the board of studies of Kerala Technological University had taken a decision in 2024 to introduce the “year back” system in the fifth semester. Accordingly, this session, the system was introduced.

“After the present government came to power, the matter came to our notice. In the first syndicate meeting of the university, it was decided to suspend the year back system. All the colleges under the university were told to abandon it. However, Mar Athanasius college has not taken a decision so far. I have asked the college to abandon the year back system. I have also asked the university to conduct a probe into the issue,” he said.

Power company engineer found hanging in Bihar’s Sheikhpura district, probe on

Press Trust of India
Sheikhpura, August 16

AN EXECUTIVE engineer of a power distribution company was found hanging inside his rented accommodation in Bihar’s Sheikhpura district on Sunday, police said.

Ashwini Kumar Chandra (35), a native of Hasanpur in Samastipur district, had joined the Sheikhpura divisional headquarters of South Bihar Power Distribution Company Limited as an executive engineer (civil) around nine months ago.

“Upon receiving information that Chandra had locked his room from inside and was not opening it despite repeated knocks, police reached the spot and broke open the door. He was found hanging from the ceiling fan,” Sheikhpura SHO Dharmendra Kumar said.

Preliminary information suggests that Chandra took the extreme step following an argument with his wife over smoking, he added.

However, the exact reason leading to his death could only be ascertained after proper investigation, Kumar said.

Chandra lived with his wife Pammi and their four-year-old son in a rented house near College Mor on Kachchi Road in Sheikhpura, officials said.

Following argument, Chandra went to his room and bolted the door from inside. When he did not open the door despite repeated attempts, his wife informed police, they added.

Undertrials clash at Himachal jail, several injured

Nahan: A clash between two groups of undertrials at the Model Central Jail in Nahan in Himachal Pradesh’s Sirmour district has left several prisoners injured, police said on Sunday.

Acting on a complaint filed by the prison administration, Nahan police has registered a case and launched a probe.

According to complaint lodged by Deputy Superintendent of Prisons, Sita Ram, clash broke out in Block A, prompting wardens to rush to the spot and control the situation. PTI

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Officers on their Balidan Diwas.

SH SATISH KUMAR, DEPUTY COMMANDANT 113 BN BSF 14.10.1964 – 17.08.2002	INSPECTOR G S THAPA 195 BN BSF 20.05.1940 – 17.08.1991	CONSTABLE JAGDISH CHANDRA BHARTI 11 BN BSF 17.04.1976 – 17.08.1999

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

Veer Balidani Head Constable Kedar Nath Mishra 131 Bn 28-9-1964 To 17-8-2006	Veer Balidani Constable Akhilesh Kumar 131 Bn 1-1-1981 To 17-8-2006

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to two valiant troopers of 131 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in a cowardly attack by militants in Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir, on 17 August 2006. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Baban Shah 35 Bn 2-7-1966 To 17-8-1988	Veer Balidani Constable R.U.P. Choudhary 35 Bn 7-8-1953 To 17-8-1988

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to two valiant troopers of 131 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a bomb attack by the LTTE rebels in Jaffna, Sri Lanka on 17 August 1988. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Lance Naik Zile Singh of 71 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a cowardly attack by militants while performing Naka duty on the Moga–Ferozepur Road, in Moga district, Punjab. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
Veer Balidani Lance Naik Zile Singh 71 Bn 1-3-1953 To 17-8-1990	

	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable H.R. Gadam of 5 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after succumbing to grievous injuries sustained in an IED blast in Anantnag district, Jammu & Kashmir. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
Veer Balidani Constable H.R. Gadam 5 Bn 3-7-1961 To 17-8-2005	

Veer Balidani Constable/Driver Khurshid Khan 119 Bn 5-7-1979 To 17-8-2020	Veer Balidani Constable Sharma Lavkush Sudarshan 119 Bn 20-11-1993 To 17-8-2020

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to two valiant troopers of 119 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating terrorists during a ferocious attack at Nawaf Mod, Kreeeri, Baramulla, Jammu & Kashmir, on 17 August 2020. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

Veer Balidani Constable Ayaz Ahmed Mir 130 BN 6-6-1982 To 17-8-2007	Veer Balidani Constable Sushil Kumar Patra 130 BN 25-12-1980 To 17-8-2007	Veer Balidani Constable Bhagwan Singh 130 BN 1-5-1981 To 17-8-2007	Veer Balidani Constable Y. Tejeswar Rao 130 BN 15-6-1981 To 17-8-2007

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to 4 bravehearts of 130 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating militants during an attack by militants near Kanwani, Pulwama, Jammu & Kashmir, on 17 August 2007. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

CT/GD HARBANSH LAL SCCL BELAMPALLI	CT/GD C. VIKRAMAN SCCL BELAMPALLI

CISF proudly remembers the supreme sacrifice of these brave-hearts. On this day, they laid down their lives at the altar of duty while fighting with the LWE outfits at SCCL Belampalli, Telangana. Their courage and bravery would remain an abiding source of inspiration for the force. The force will remain eternally indebted to them for their noblest deeds.

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पत्रांक: वरि. प्र./ (ई-निविदा सेल)/2026/795 दिनांक: 14.08.2026

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

महाप्रबन्धक (अभियन्त्रण) ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नोएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या- वरि. प्र./ (ई-निविदा सेल)/2026/794 दिनांक 14/08/2026 के माध्यम से उल्लेखित क्रम संख्या 01 से 18 तक के कार्य की ई-निविदाये आमंत्रित की जाती है। समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखते रहें।

क्र. सं.	कार्य का नाम / वर्क सकिंल	अनुमानित लागत
निर्माण कार्य		
1.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ज्यू-3 में डाडा रोडटी से हायर रोडटी तक आर.सी.सी. नाले की सफाई का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-ड्रेन)	रु. 20.56 लाख
2.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर स्वर्ण नगरी में अफोर्डेबल हाउस परिसर में नाली की मरम्मत और सड़क की रिपेयरिंग का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-5)	रु. 26.81 लाख
3.	गाम मिलक लच्छी, रोना जलालपुर, रोना याकूपपुर एवं अरेजा में तीन वर्ष तक मरम्मत का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-1)	रु. 78.88 लाख
4.	ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण के वर्क सकिंल-4, 5, 6, एवं 7, के विभिन्न टोडों एवं सेक्टरों में पैच रिपेयरिंग का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-5)	रु. 275.41 लाख
वार्षिक अनुदक्षण		
5.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में भनौता कट से भारत पेट्रोल पम्प (विलपुला रोडटी के ओर यू-टर्न) तक 130 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क का तीन साल के लिए (ईन सफाई, जंगल सफाई, कर्ब स्टोन की मरम्मत, पेंटिंग, रोड मार्किंग और अन्य विविध कार्य) रखरखाव/अनुदक्षण कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-7)	रु. 148.11 लाख
विद्युतीकरण के कार्य		
6.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ओमीकॉन-1 में 120.78 वर्ग मीटर क्षेत्र में स्थित (जी+3 चार मंजिला) मकानों का विद्युत कार्यों की मरम्मत और रखरखाव का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-ई.एच.एम.-2)	रु. 124.45 लाख
7.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के छपरोला आर.ओ.बी. और लिंक रोड एन.एच.-91 पर एल.ई.डी. हाई माइट लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-ई.एच.एम.-1)	रु. 57.01 लाख
8.	ग्रेटर नोएडा पश्चिम के सेक्टर टेकनॉन-4 और सेक्टर-16 सी. और सेक्टर-4 में सड़क चौड़ाकरण के कारण मौजूदा स्ट्रीट लाइट नेटवर्क का पुनर्व्यं स्थापन और 24 सी. और 30 सी. चौड़ी सड़कों पर स्ट्रीट लाइट लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-ई.एच.एम.-1)	रु. 209.86 लाख
उद्यान विभाग		
9.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर चाई-5 में शहर की सड़क पर सेन्ट्रल वर्ज और हरित पट्टी का विकास एवं रखरखाव एक वर्ष के लिए। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 70.21 लाख
10.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में ओमीकॉन-1ए और आरसी ग्रीन तथा, जू-3, साइड और सेक्टर ओमीकॉन-1ए बैंक साइड सेन्ट्रल वर्ज में वृक्षापेयण और दो वर्ष हेतु रखरखाव का कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 109.33 लाख
11.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर के.पी.-2 में पार्को और ग्रीन बेल्ट में पेड़ों, झाड़ियों और लॉन का रखरखाव के साथ-साथ सिविल कार्यों की मरम्मत कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 124.11 लाख
12.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर के.पी.-2 में पंचवटी पार्क कलाग्राम और प्रोमोनाडे पार्क में दो साल के लिए वृक्षों झाड़ियों और लॉन का रखरखाव के साथ-साथ सिविल कार्यों की मरम्मत कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 124.46 लाख
13.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर के.पी.-3 में पार्को ग्रीन बेल्ट और सेन्ट्रल वर्ज में लगे पेड़ों, झाड़ियों और लॉन का रखरखाव एवं तार फैसिलिंग का कार्य की मरम्मत कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 127.75 लाख
14.	ग्रेटर नोएडा 130 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क (सेक्टर ओमीकॉन-3) के साथ पार्क और ग्रीन बेल्ट का दो वर्ष हेतु सिविल अनुदक्षण कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 131.30 लाख
15.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर चाई-3 के 60 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क पर लगे पेड़ों, झाड़ियों और लॉन का रखरखाव के साथ साथ सिविल कार्यों का मरम्मत कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 138.97 लाख
16.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ज्यू-1 में लगे पेड़ पोथों एवं लॉन तथा सिविल कार्यों सहित दो वर्षों तक के लिए अनुदक्षण कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 139.35 लाख
17.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर स्वर्ण नगरी में पार्को और हरित पट्टी में पेड़ों झाड़ियों और लॉन के रखरखाव सहित दो वर्ष के लिए सिविल कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 153.00 लाख
18.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के एस. के. रोड जंक्शन से 130 मी. रोड पर आमका रोडटी, होली पब्लिक स्कूल से नदी की नदीया रोडटी, सेक्टर-36 एवं सिगना-2 जंक्शन से ईकोटेक-1 (एक्साट) रोडटी एवं ईकोटेक-1 (एक्साट) से डाडा रोडटी पर वृक्षापेयण एवं दो वर्ष तक अनुदक्षण कार्य। (वर्क सकिंल-उद्यान)	रु. 162.46 लाख

क्रम सं.-1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, एवं 18 तक के कार्यों की दिनांक 18.08.2026 से 31.08.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 02.09.2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जाएगी, एवं क्रम सं.-4 एवं 8, पर अंतिम कार्य के दिनांक 18.08.2026 से 01.09.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 03.09.2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जाएगी।

वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (ई-निविदा सेल)

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EXPRESS special

The loneliness of Tej Pratap: RJD first family to tottering outfit to reality show

Santosh Singh
Patna, August 16

ONCE A KEY face of the Lalu Prasad-led Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD)’s first family, former Bihar minister Tej Pratap Yadav’s political space has been increasingly shrinking since his dramatic expulsion from the party in May 2025 and his loss in the state Assembly elections later that year.

But even as Tej Pratap, the elder son of former chief ministers Lalu Prasad and Rabri Devi, looks to regain his political standing, he has found ways to keep himself busy – from maintaining a regular social media presence to starring in a reality TV show “Bhojpuri Bawaal”.

Last week, on August 9, Tej Pratap, 38, said in a post on X: “Very soon, the entire country and all of Asia are about to witness something new. Something special and fresh is coming along with the one and only Mallika Sherawat. For now, it’s a suspense... so hold your hearts steady and don’t let too much anxiety show on your face!”

The former Bihar health minister and two-time MLA might well be keeping himself busy with these activities, his political stock has dipped significantly in recent years.

After being expelled from the RJD in May 2025 in the wake of a social media post, which indicated a “long relationship” with a woman even as he fought a divorce case with his estranged wife Aishwarya Rai, Tej Pratap floated his own party, Janshakti Janata Dal (JJD), just months before the November 2025 Assembly polls.

While the JJD fielded a slew of candidates in the Assembly polls, it failed to open its account. Tej Pratap himself finished a distant third in the Mahua seat behind the candidates of the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) and the RJD.

Since then, Tej Pratap has looked to recapture political space in the



Tej Pratap Yadav

state. At times, he has praised Jan Surraaj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor. He has also invited Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke to Bihar. He has even thanked Chief Minister and BJP leader Samrat Choudhary for “sending him to Beur Central Jail” following his participation in a students’ stir in Patna over the NEET paper leak last month.

Tej Pratap’s political isolation has come about in recent years. It was not too long ago that he shared the same residence with his parents and younger brother Tejashwi Yadav at 10, Circular Road – just behind the CM’s residence at 1, Aney Marg.

Things changed for the worse after the NDA’s thumping victory in the 2025 Assembly polls, which later forced Lalu and Rabri to vacate their official residence. Tej Pratap vacated his own official residence after his loss from Mahua and has been living in the official residence of an RJD MLC since.

“The 2025 elections dealt a severe blow to Tej Pratap in particular. He finished a distant third behind LJP (RV) and RJD in Mahua, the constituency that had first sent him to the Assembly (in 2015). The JJD, which became a political party just before the Assembly polls, is an almost insignificant outfit. From being a health minister to being politically irrelevant, Tej Pratap lost the political plot in a matter of a decade. His political fortunes can revive only if the RJD

is able to bounce back and Tejashwi patches up with his elder brother,” a senior RJD leader said.

Tejashwi is currently the RJD national working president as well as the Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Assembly. While Tej Pratap has been trying to maintain family ties and reconnect with his relatives, the RJD has shown no indication of bringing him back.

On a personal note, however, Tejashwi reciprocated the brotherly bond by meeting Tej Pratap after his release from the Beur jail recently, while Lalu also attended his birthday party this April. Despite being cornered politically, Tej Pratap however continues to be followed by the media for sound bites.

On Saturday, while reacting to Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s “dimagi Naxal” barb in his Independence Day speech, Tej Pratap said, “Let the PM explain who is ‘dimagi Naxal’. He should also probe if such elements are in his party (BJP) as well.”

As for his take on Bihar politics, he has not

CJP volunteer’s father who was assaulted after ‘assessing’ govt school dies in Bengal

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, August 16

THE COCKROACH Janta Party (CJP) on Sunday demanded the immediate arrest of the assailants responsible for the alleged assault that led to the death of Janab Mafik, father of CJP volunteer Shaik Abdul Hafeez, in West Bengal’s Bankura district. Hafeez and his family were allegedly attacked on Thursday after they visited a government school in his village in the Kari-sunda area to assess it as part of the CJP’s ongoing ‘School Thik Karo’ (improve the schools) campaign. Mafik died Saturday from severe head injuries sustained during the alleged attack, the CJP said in a statement.

The CJP announced Sunday that a CJP National Working Committee delegation, led by co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka, will visit West Bengal on Monday to stand in solidarity with Hafeez.

In a social media post, CJP founder and national convener Abhijeet Dipke alleged that the volunteer’s family was attacked by “goons allegedly from the BJP”. According to Hafeez, on August 13, he visited the local government school in his village in the Karisunda area to assess the condition of the school’s infrastructure as part of CJP’s nationwide campaign. He alleged that later that evening, armed individuals, whom he identified as alleged “local BJP karyakartas”, allegedly forcibly entered his house and demanded that he record a



Janab Mafik, father of CJP volunteer Abdul Hafeez, died of injuries on Saturday. EXPRESS

video statement apologising for highlighting the school’s conditions while claiming that he had done so under external influence. When Hafeez refused to comply, the miscreants allegedly attacked him. Hafeez sustained a severe neck injury, while his father, Janab Mafik, who had intervened to save his son, suffered a critical blunt-force trauma to the head. His father succumbed to his injuries on Saturday.

Speaking to the media, Hafeez said, “Police arrived and we rushed my father to the hospital, but many BJP workers had surrounded the hospital and were not allowing us to leave... While we were returning home from the hospital, the assailants again surrounded us in a dark area and assaulted us for the second time. They took my mobile phone and deleted all the videos from social media.”

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari claimed no BJP workers were involved in the incident, and vowed strict action against those responsible.

THREE SUSPECTS ARRESTED

Bengal Congress leader, son shot & hacked to death

CM flags ‘TMC link’ of assailants; Mamata faction distances itself

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, August 16

CONGRESS LEADER Anisur Rahman and his son Abu Sufian, 24, were first shot at and then hacked to death by unidentified miscreants near the Bethuadahari railway crossing in Nadia district on Saturday evening.

The attack was carried out just 200 metres from their residence returning home in a car. Meanwhile, the police have arrested three persons in connection with the murder.

Rahman was a member of the Pradesh Congress Committee and General Secretary of the Nadia District Congress Committee. According to family members, Rahman’s son was studying law and planned to go to London for further studies.

The assailants allegedly opened fire at the vehicle before attacking the two men with sharp-edged weapons. The car



in which the duo was travelling has been riddled with bullets and the windows were smashed. Both died on the spot due to excessive blood loss, officials said.

The bodies of both the father and the son have been taken to the local Nakashipara hospital for a post-mortem examination.

Mourning his death, “He (Rahman) was a long-time Congress leader who worked for the people. He must have been a victim of political enmity, but his son had nothing to do with politics. We want justice.”

The arrested accused are Fatema Bibi — the head of Har-



(Top) Congress leader Anisur Rahman; (left) West Bengal Congress chief Shubhankar Sarkar with Rahman’s kin. PTI

nagar Gram Panchayat from the TMC; Sageb Sk; and Mithu Sheikh. The arrests were made after Rahman’s family alleged that Bibi was linked to the murders.

The three accused were produced before Krishnanagar court, which remanded them to nine days in police custody. The police are also scanning CCTV footage from the area to track down the assailants.

Reacting to the double murder, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said in a press conference on Sunday, “The SP (Superintendent of Police) informed me that Jabbar Shiekh, who is in jail, is responsible for

the murder. Already, his wife, who is a TMC pradhan, has been arrested.”

Trinamool Congress MLA from the Mamata Banerjee-led faction, Kunal Ghosh told mediapersons, “We condemn the killings; the police should investigate the matter. The blame is now being given that a TMC leader is involved; now we have to see whether that person belongs to the ‘good TMC...”

Senior Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury said, “We demand a proper and impartial investigation and exemplary punishment for the guilty at the earliest.”

—WITH PTI INPUTS

Ensure extradition pleas are submitted timely, jail facilities meet global norms: MHA to states

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 16

THE MINISTRY of Home Affairs has asked states and Union Territories to ensure timely processing of extradition requests for fugitives abroad, flagging that delays by state police and investigating agencies can hamper efforts to bring them back, while also directing setting up of prison facilities in central jails that meet international standards, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

According to a source, “The MHA has sought updated details on the status of internationally compliant prison facilities and cases proposed to be withdrawn from extradition proceedings.”

India has brought back 274 fugitives from 36 countries since 2021 — a sharp escalation in extradition and deportation efforts. Earlier this month, in a communication to Chief Secre-

taries and DGPs of states/UTs, the MHA has said it had been observed that even after fugitives are traced or arrested abroad on the basis of Interpol notices, the state police or investigating agencies concerned often delay sending provisional arrest requests or formal extradition requests to the ministry, the source said.

Such delays, the communication said, adversely affect India’s efforts to secure return of fugitives, as foreign authorities are bound by their domestic laws and treaty obligations. “If formal extradition requests are not submitted within the stipulated time, the fugitive may be released, the period of provisional arrest may lapse, or the person may flee from the foreign country’s jurisdiction, making the process of tracing and arresting them again extremely difficult,” the source said.

This comes after a meeting last month with top officials of

states/UTs, and central agencies, where issues related to strengthening extradition processes were reviewed, the source said. According to the source, the ministry has underlined that preparing a legally sound extradition request is primarily the responsibility of the investigating agency or state police concerned. The extradition process, however, requires coordination among the investigating agency or state police, the CBI through Interpol, the Union Home Ministry, the Ministry of External Affairs and the Indian mission concerned.

The MHA has advised all states/UTs and law enforcement agencies to prepare extradition dossiers in advance for cases in which Interpol Red Notices have been issued, so that provisional arrest or extradition requests can be sent immediately once a fugitive is located or arrested abroad, the source said.

During the meeting last

month, the source said that discussions were held on “setting up extradition cells with sufficient staff, developing prison facilities in accordance with international standards, converting Interpol Blue Notices into Red Notices, and delays in forwarding extradition requests in cases where fugitives had been located abroad.”

The MHA also noted that some states and agencies had been reluctant to proceed with extradition in matrimonial disputes and other cases which, according to them, may not meet the legal threshold of extradition. However, decisions in such matters had not been communicated to the MHA, the source said.

The ministry has also directed that all pending extradition matters be reviewed and cases unsuitable for extradition be identified or which they propose to withdraw from the extradition process.



The flooded school in Kendrapada. Over 5 lakh people have been affected due to flood-like situation in northern Odisha districts.

Flood water cuts off Odisha residential school, leaves 300 students stranded

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, August 16

NEARLY 300 STUDENTS, including over 100 girls, of a state-run residential school in Odisha’s Kendrapara district are stranded after rising waters of Brahmani River inundated the area amid incessant rainfall over the past 24 hours.

Officials said on Sunday that the students of the Kulasahi Ashram School in the district’s Pattamundai block have been shifted to the first floor of the school building after flood water entered the school premises. At present, the school is completely cut off due to the rising water level. The students were still on the premises when the last reports came in.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Kendrapara district collector Raghuram Iyer said all the students are safe. “The school premises are surrounded by flood water due to rising water levels in the Brahmani River. Senior officials were sent to the school to take stock of the situation. We haven’t taken any decision to evacuate the students from the campus,” said Iyer.

The administration is keeping a close watch on the situation, the collector said, adding, adequate food and drinking water are available for the students.

An official, who visited the school, said the kitchen and drinking water system at the school is intact. A fire service team with boat has been deployed near the school. “In case there will be a rise in the water level, and if there is a need for evacuation, we are ready for it,” said an official.

Officials said the school, run by the scheduled caste and scheduled tribe department of the state government, is located in a low-lying area close to the riverbank.

Meanwhile, over 5 lakh people have been affected due to flood-like situation in several northern districts due to heavy rain while the situation is grim in Bhadrak, Balasore and Jajpur. More than 2.5 lakh people from the low-lying areas of the affected districts have been shifted to safe shelters after flood water inundated several habitations.

Odisha Chief Secretary Anu Garg on Sunday directed the district collectors to keep a close watch on the situation. Three senior IAS officers have been deputed by the state government in Balasore, Bhadrak and Jajpur to monitor the overall relief, evacuation and restoration measures on the ground.

At least 36 teams of Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force (ORDAF), seven teams of NDRF and 36 fire service teams have been deployed with boats and other equipment in the affected areas to help the administration in relief and rescue operations.

“The administration has been put on alert while leaves of all government officials in the affected districts have been cancelled. The water resources department has also sent senior engineers for surveillance on the situation and for necessary intervention,” said the chief secretary.

Chief minister Mohan Charan Majhi is scheduled to visit the flood affected areas in Bhadrak and Jajpur on Monday, said officials.

Navy sailor, wife, 2 children found dead at Mumbai home; cops suspect suicide

Apoorva Agashe
Mumbai, August 16

AN INDIAN Navy sailor, his wife and their two children, including a two-month-old infant and a three-year-old boy, were found dead at their South Mumbai home in Navy Nagar, Cuffe Parade police said Sunday.

The deaths came to light on the night of August 15 when police received information that a family has been found dead in Navy Nagar.

“It is suspected that the sailor died by hanging and the wife and children died due to

poisoning. The bodies have been sent for postmortem,” a senior police official from South Mumbai said.

Police have identified the deceased as Puranmal Shambhul Mehra, 30, the sailor, his wife Oma Puranmal Mehra, 28, and their son, Yash Puranmal Mehra. Police said so far no suicide note has been recovered. “We suspect the couple had disputes due to which the family took extreme steps,” police said.

In a statement, the Indian Navy said it was providing all necessary assistance to the family.

No full stops in Bengal SIR

fear they have been deleted as they are yet to even get an acknowledgment from tribunals on their applications.

All remain unsure of what awaits them next: detention, deportation, denial of government benefits, a long court case, or re-application from the start?

The state BJP government has talked about all of the above as possibilities, while the ECI says reapplication — starting all over again as a “new voter” — is an option.

Sabia Khatun, 42; father Samsul Alam, 72; Residents of Bolpur, Sabia and Samsul have been struck off the voter list by a tribunal, though Samsul’s son Intekhab Alam has got in. They heard in May that the tribunals had ruled against them, says Intekhab.

While Samsul works as a helper at a cloth shop in Kolkata, Sabia is divorced. Before the 2026 elections, in which they could not vote due to their SIR status, both had been voters in the Bolpur Assembly constituency.

A factory worker, 43-year-old Intekhab says: “There is panic and fear in the family. My name, my uncles’ names are in the voters’ list, but that of my father and sister are deleted. My father worked in Kolkata and therefore his name was not on the voters’ list of 2002 (which is seen as conclusive proof by the ECI). My father and sister were called for hearings, where they gave all the documents, including their secondary board and

higher secondary board certificates. But then their names went to the tribunal. In May we learnt that their names had been deleted. They got no notice.”

The family then moved the Calcutta High Court. On August 4, the court directed the tribunal to once again adjudge Samsul’s case, while Sabia’s petition is yet to be heard. In his order, Justice Krishna Rao said: “... the Appellate Tribunal is requested to consider and dispose of the appeal preferred by the petitioner as early as possible, preferably within a period of three months from date.”

Speaking over the phone from Birbhum, Sabia tells *The Indian Express*: “What can I say? Every day I see ministers saying that those struck off the voter list will not be a part of government schemes like ration. I am still getting my rations. But we live in fear.”

In his very first Cabinet meeting, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said that those deleted in the SIR will not be able to avail state government welfare schemes, though exceptions will be made for those whose applications are pending before tribunals or who have applied under the Citizenship (Amendment) Act. Other ministers have since repeated the warning.

Sabia and Samsul’s Booth Level Officer (BLO), Kabita Rajak, told *The Indian Express*: “Samsul’s parents too are not in the 2002 voters’ list. They may

have given school certificates, but I don’t remember.”

Manjura Begum, 31: A resident of Arambagh in Hooghly, the 31-year-old says she came to know on July 1 that her name was “excluded” from the voter list. Married to Sheikh Jiadul Hussain, a carpenter, Manjura has three children, and has voted earlier in the Arambagh Assembly seat.

Says Hussain: “My wife’s parents were voters in 2002. We gave this and other documents to the BLO, but then her name went to adjudication. Again, during the hearing, we gave all the documents. Then her name went to the tribunal. Now she is not a voter anymore.”

The process was marked by errors, Hussain says. “Manjura has four siblings, but the notice to her stated there were seven of them. Now, all her brothers and sisters have cleared the SIR, but she has been dropped.”

On July 28, Manjura moved the Calcutta High Court, and is waiting for a hearing. Her lawyer Saloni Bhattacharya says: “This is purely harassment of people. When we were pleading the case, the ECI lawyer said it was not necessary to call people for a hearing (before the tribunals). But we contested saying that my client had a right to be heard.”

Questioning the functioning of the tribunals, Bhattacharya says: “My client, like others, was not even given a reason for their deletion. The tribunals are not assigning reasons or giving any written order based on which

one can approach the courts for redressal. The process is very slow and people are confused. How many people have the capacity to approach the High Court?”

Hussain says they are worried about word getting out about Manjura’s status. “What will our neighbors think when they learn we are one of the ‘deleted’ ones?”

Manjura shoots back: “We are deleted, not departed. We and our families have to live here.”

However, the bravado soon slips. “We are so tense. I have three children... what will happen to me? Will they throw me out of the country? Will our rations be stopped? How about the formalities that one has to do for bank accounts or LPG connection? Will we be able to do it without our names in the voter list?” says Manjura. “It would have been better if we had died,” she murmurs.

Asked about her case, her BLO Saiful Mullick said: “There are 1,017 voters in the booth I work for, names of 105 were deleted, including Manjura... My personal opinion is they may be genuine voters. Without showing any reason, their names were deleted.”

Javed Khan, 48: A resident of Hooghly, Khan says he found out last month that the tribunal had ordered his name struck off the voter list.

“My mother, brother and wife’s names are there, but mine was dropped. They did not even call me to ask for my documents,” says Khan, who has been a voter in the Sreerampur

Assembly seat.

A construction worker, the 48-year-old, who lives with his wife, son and mother, is not clear what to do next. “My father’s name was in the 2002 voter list. But mine was deleted. I asked the BLO, he too is clueless.”

BLO Khurshid Anwar said: “I really don’t know why his name has been deleted.”

Amina Paswan, 50: The 50-year-old lives in a slum along the railway tracks near Nimtolla in Kolkata, and makes flower garlands for a living. After losing her husband 17 years ago, she raised her son on her own.

Amina says that she found out in April that while her son Rabi, 30, had made it to the voter list, she was out, despite attending a hearing. “Then, with the help of a local NGO, I submitted my appeal to the tribunals offline.” She never heard anything from the tribunals, she says, not even an acknowledgment.

The ECI website shows “excluded” against her name.

Amina, who earlier voted in the Shyampukur Assembly seat, says: “My husband’s name was not in the 2002 voters’ list, though he came from Bihar long back. But his brother’s name was there. I gave my documents linked to my husband’s, along with other documents. My son submitted papers linking to his uncle, and his name was cleared.”

Scared of what is to come, Amina says: “I get a widow pension from the government along with rations. This has not stopped, but I fear it will soon. I do not have money to go to

court. I just earn Rs 200 daily selling flower garlands.”

Her BLO Kalyan Bisi said: “I don’t want to talk about it.”

Pinki Das, 31: Amina’s neighbor at the Nimtolla slum, Pinki works as a domestic help. Her husband Sacchu, 45, is originally from Madhubani in Bihar but settled in Kolkata years back, she says. He is in the voter list.

“We got our voter card, Aadhaar card, e-shram card, everything made here. I have never even voted in Bihar, but voted here (in the Shyampukur Assembly seat). I have four children, all born here,” she says.

Pinki says after her name didn’t make it to the SIR final list, despite her attending a hearing at a local school on January 6, she applied to the tribunals. “I never got a receipt,” she says, leaving her in the dark about her status.

Pinki, who has four children, says her family depends on her earnings. “My husband, a rickshaw puller, is a drunk. What will I do if my name doesn’t make it to the voter list? My rations are continuing, but for how long? I am not a Bangladeshi.”

Of Pinki’s four children, three are in school while another is training in hotel management with an NGO. “What will their future be?”

Her BLO Kalyan Bisi said: “I don’t want to talk about this.”

Soni Devi, 30: A neighbour of Amina and Pinki, Soni says she finds herself in the same boat. “My in-laws are from Begusarai, Bihar. But, we are not voters there. For years we have

lived here and made our voter card here, along with Aadhaar and other documents... This is our home.”

It’s not just her “but also my three children who are at the mercy of the government”, Soni, who voted in the Shyampukur Assembly seat earlier, says. “If I am not a voter, what will be their status when they grow up?”

BLO Kalyan Bisi said: “I don’t want to talk about it.”

Sheikh Chotu, 35; wife Guria Bibi, 31: A rickshaw puller, Sheikh lives with his wife Guria in a slum in Rajabazar area of Kolkata. Both are now “excluded” from the voter list, after a tribunal order.

It makes no sense, Sheikh says. “In the last elections, we both voted (in the Belegghata Assembly seat). We filled our SIR forms and submitted the papers. While not even a response came for my wife, nor was she called for hearings, in my case, the BLO first told me everything in my form was fine. Then he said I have to come for hearings. I gave all the papers. But still they deleted my name.”

Sheikh, whose brothers have been cleared as voters, says he along with him had papers establishing their links to their father, whose name was in the 2002 voters’ list.

Guria says their life may never be the same. “Our neighbours, when they get to know we are deleted from the voter list, may have a different opinion about us. Moreover, till now we get rations. I don’t know whether it will continue.”

Their BLO Md Fakkrudin said: “We submitted their forms

and papers. Now, the office and the (tribunal) judges will decide. What can I say, I am just a BLO.”

Asma Khatun, 30: Asma, whose husband is a rickshaw puller, says she was confident her case had no loopholes as the names of both her parents were in the voters’ list of 2002.

Then came the “excluded” notification. Pointing out that she has voted in four previous elections in Bengal (in the Belegghata Assembly seat), Asma says: “Now I don’t know what will happen. I gave my ration card, voter card, birth certificate and other papers to the BLO. I was called for a hearing but later told my name was deleted. Now, even my application to the tribunals has been rejected... I have three children, where will I go now, if they drive us away.”

BLO Md Fakkrudin BLO said: “The office and judges will decide... I am just a BLO.”

Kahakasa Shakil, the coordinator of NGO Mukta Kantha Mahilla Samity, which is helping the deleted voters in Kolkata slums, says: “There are a number of such people. We helped them submit appeals to tribunals on April 10. Out of the 54 people for whom we helped file appeals offline, no (acknowledgment) receipt has been received for 17. We don’t know why.”

The court option is not simple either, adds Shakil. “We wanted to approach the Calcutta High Court on behalf of these people. But the procedure, we were told, is that it is the individuals who have to appeal. These are poor people... they cannot afford the expense.”

The Indian EXPRESS

~ FOUNDED BY ~

RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

In youth-driven Viksit Bharat, celebrate ‘dimag’

IN HIS speech marking the 80th Independence Day, Prime Minister Narendra Modi returned to themes he has eloquently outlined earlier — and sought to connect them to a new motif. As he has done often, he divided the nation’s journey into two, before-and-after 2014, with everything, from poverty alleviation to the embrace of new technologies, picking up pace in the last 12 years. “*Yeh raftar, yeh vistar*”, this speed and this scale, he said, was visible for the first time since Independence. Several by-now familiar keywords and exhortations were embedded in his picture of a nation on the move, guided by “*shakti ki saptaadhara*”, a seven-point reform vision — “*atmanirbharta*”, “innovation hub”, “vocal for local”, “start-up India”, “reform express”. He framed the nation’s trajectory against the backdrop of mounting global crises, from the pandemic to the weaponisation of resources amid wars in Ukraine and the Middle East. What was new at the Red Fort, however, was the PM’s invocation of “*yuva shakti*”, or youth power, and his attempt to link it to the goal of “Viksit Bharat”. In a speech that comes on the heels of a student movement that drew national attention to the education and employment crises, the Prime Minister sought to reclaim and relocate the “young” — from the image of the protester on the street, ranged against government and establishment, to the driving force of the India reform story, who is also its prime “*labharthi*” or beneficiary.

The young received special attention from the PM. He announced a programme for AI training and free online coaching classes for competitive examinations. He spoke of the Innovation Fund, and promised to bring together “*aapke sapne*”, especially Olympic dreams, with “*sansadhar*” or resources. The young, said the PM, could also help official enumerators conduct the ongoing Census exercise more accurately. With echoes of the upsurge at Jantar Mantar still to fade, these evocative mentions of the young, the invitation to them to join a nation-wide project, were an attempt to restore and retrieve, and take the edge off the moment.

But the speech had a sharp edge of its own. Talking about his government’s successes in tackling the scourge of Naxal violence, the PM articulated a remaining challenge — while “*hathiyari* Naxals (armed insurgents)” have been defeated, there is a need to remain wary of the danger posed by “*dimagi* Naxals (those with Maoist thinking)”. The latter, he said, must be identified and isolated so that the youth can be brought together to build a developed country. The connections the PM made in this formulation — his equation of an armed insurgency with ideas/dissent/ideology, and his linking of both to the young — are troubling. For, there is no equivalence between “*hathiyari*” and “*dimagi*”, and the bogey of the enemy within is at odds with the country he paints in the rest of his speech. There is no place for isolating or targeting anyone on the basis of their ideas — their “*dimag*”. The PM is right when he says *yuva shakti* will fuel the journey to Viksit Bharat, but that calls for celebrating the power of thought and freedom from fear, so that questions are asked and there is an unafraid search for answers. Only that can shape and refine what it means to be *viksit*.

Attack on Sukhbir Badal deepens Punjab unease

THE ATTACK on Shiromani Akali Dal president Sukhbir Singh Badal in Nanded is reprehensible. The investigation will shine more light on this disturbing episode, but in Punjab, it can be said to be the latest in a recent series of developments that have deepened a sense of unease. In no particular order: Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann called on the Governor to seek a 10-day parole for Jagtar Singh Hawara, one of the convicts in the 1995 assassination of former Chief Minister Beant Singh; *Satluj*, a film that streamed for only a few hours, has revived memories of Punjab’s dark decade of militancy; a march to Chandigarh by the Shiromani Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) demanded the release of its jailed leader, Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh, and other prisoners of the militancy era, the Bandi Singhs.

It is striking that a state confronted by a host of pressing challenges, be it drugs, gangsters, a faltering agricultural economy or the continuing exodus of its young, should be spending so much political energy looking backwards. The renewed traction around the Bandi Singhs, particularly among the young, shows how unresolved history can travel across generations. Issues rooted in the panthic imagination can be recast for a generation that did not experience the violence but has inherited its unanswered questions. Political parties must take the blame for turning such issues into electoral instruments, but failure to resolve several longstanding questions has handed them this ammunition. Chandigarh, the sharing of river waters and the status of Sikh prisoners are unresolved legacies that have been allowed to fester for decades. It’s time to confront these issues rather than repeatedly rediscover them at election time.

The question of Punjab’s river waters must be settled through constitutional processes. The cases of Sikh prisoners, including those convicted in high-profile assassinations, must be considered through the framework of law and justice, though the passage of time has added another layer to the debate: The perception of discrimination. Political parties must understand that emotions cannot be turned on and off, come elections, at will. Once unleashed, they acquire a life of their own and can overwhelm the very political actors who sought to harness them.

FREEZE FRAME BY EP UNNY



V ANANTHA NAGESWARAN AND AKASH POOJARI

A COMPLAINT has been travelling fast online that the government’s E20 petrol wrecks engines and empties the tank faster. The charge is loud, but it is also, on the main point, wrong. However, dismissing it outright would be a mistake because beneath the noise lies a real problem and a much larger question.

Start with the engine, and the evidence does not support the fear of damage. Ethanol carries about two-thirds the energy of petrol, so a litre of E20 takes you a little less far, but the loss is small and does not signal any malfunction. Ethanol is only a fifth of the blend, so the energy penalty is around 6 to 7 per cent, not the 30 per cent doing the rounds. Carbon monoxide and unburnt hydrocarbons actually fall, which is good for the environment. On durability, which is the primary point of contention, the record is reassuring and counters the online narrative. The US, one of the global leaders in ethanol blending, had the Oakridge National Laboratory run 86 vehicles for a cumulative total of nearly 10 million kilometres on blends up to E20 and found no increased wear in cars not rated for E20. India’s own testing by ARAI, the petroleum institute, and Indian Oil reached the same conclusion. Thus, social-media worries about engine damage do not hold up.

However, one exception is genuine, that is, India has roughly 75 to 80 million older two-wheelers built before BS4 that run on carburettors. A carburettor cannot sense the extra oxygen in the blend and adjust for it, so on E20, the engine draws in too little fuel for the air it draws in and runs hot. Further, older rubber seals that are not rated for ethanol are a separate problem, as they degrade on contact with the fuel regardless of engine temperature. Retrofitting those seals with ethanol-compatible ones is cheap. Still, it happens one vehicle at a time, and covering 75 to 80 million two-wheelers that way will take years, even if every workshop starts today. The original roadmap anticipated this and requested that a lower-blend fuel remain on sale for these vehicles, but that fuel quietly vanished from the pumps and needs to return. Restoring a lower blend at the pumps, say, E10, alongside the option to buy E20, would calm most public concern, lower total ethanol use instead of raising it, and protect the existing fleet while the retrofit programme catches up.

With the engine argument settled, one must also ask the harder question that nobody is shouting about. How much further should blending go? Moving from E20 to E27 or E30 is a different decision altogether, because that is where fuel begins to crowd out food.

Consider the two import bills India is trying to shrink. The crude oil bill is huge, around Rs 11-12 lakh crore a year. The edible oil bill is far smaller, roughly Rs 1.6 to 1.75 lakh crore. Ethanol at E20 trims only 3 to 4 per cent of the crude bill. The edible oil gap looks less daunting and is far more closeable. India already produces about 40 per cent of its cooking oil and aims to reach

Once land and water are committed to fuel, and distilleries and cropping patterns are built around it, pulling back can be painful. When some moves are easy to undo, prudence says to move the reversible ones first

The historian who didn’t lose hope



CLAUDE MARKOVITS

SUMIT SARKAR, who passed away on August 13 at the age of 87, was that rare combination of a great historian and a lovely human being. I leave it to others, more competent, to appraise in detail his considerable contribution to the history of modern India. I will dwell instead on my personal memories of him. I was privileged to get to know Sumit through a personal connection: My wife, Piyali Chakravarty, was a childhood friend of his till the end, a friendship I shared.

Although we met first in Calcutta, and later in Oxford, where Sumit and his wife Tanika were spending a year, we really became friends in the late 1970s when they spent some time with us in our Parisian flat and we had long chats in the evenings, very much in the tradition of *addas*, while listening to records of French revolutionary songs. When it was our turn to spend a year in Delhi, this friendship grew and we were constantly in and out of each others’ homes.

I have particularly fond memories of the few days Sumit and I spent together in Paris in the late 1980s. I was then trying to learn Bengali and, as a beginner, was finding my way through the famous primer written by Rabindranath Tagore, *Shahoj Path*.

In between visits to Parisian historical landmarks, about which Sumit was often more knowledgeable than an old Parisian like myself, we would spend time reading together through the text. Sumit was vastly amused at some of the stories recounted in the book, and at what it revealed of Tagore’s view of society. He even said it was worth having a closer look at the text, although he does not seem to have pursued that project.

Talking to him on any subject, whether history, politics or literature, was always enlightening, as he had a vast store of knowledge on a variety of topics, and was never boring. He did not take himself too seriously, the way many academics tend to do, and always applied a good dose of his particular brand of humour to even the most serious questions.

Raised in a Brahmo milieu with strong communist leanings, his father Professor Susobhan Sarkar being a stalwart of the

Bengali intellectual left and a hugely influential teacher, Sumit remained a Marxist throughout his life, despite the growing unpopularity of that school of thought in India and elsewhere. An original contributor to Subaltern Studies with their then Thomsonian project of “history from below”, he parted ways with the group when they fell under the spell of postmodernism and postcoloniality. He wrote a famous article about the decline of the subaltern in *Subaltern Studies*, which his former co-authors preferred to ignore rather than attempt to refute. He still believed that some form of “history from below” was a feasible project, although he had lost some of his illusions about the possibilities of recovering the voices of the downtrodden.

For him, as for many progressive intellectuals worldwide, the collapse of the socialist bloc and more generally of the Left was painful to digest but he did not take refuge in nostalgia. He retained a hope that things somehow would correct themselves at some point, which they did not. He was particularly alarmed at the growth of the Hindutva brand of Hindu nationalism and the threat it posed to Indian society and democracy.

He wrote about this threat in a series of pieces that were polemical but lucid, and did not become invectives. He was alert to the fact that, by undermining belief in the existence of historical truths, postmodernism had unwittingly helped in the growth of Hindu historiographies of India which had little consideration for facts.

The last years of his life were darkened by a host of physical ailments which he bore with courage and stoicism, helped by the care of Tanika and their son Aditya, both fine historians. The last time I met him was in Leamington Spa in England, where Tanika and he were spending a holiday with Aditya. He was frail, but still lucid, taking full part in the conversation, and still capable of laughing at the absurdities of the world. He will be sorely missed by us, and we share the grief of Tanika and Aditya.

The writer is a French historian of India. His latest publication is *India and the World: A History of Connections*, c. 1750-2000

72 per cent by 2030-31. A gap that the government can not only close fully but also stop subsidising is worth more than one you can only nibble at forever.

The feedstock has shifted, and that turns a distant trade-off into a direct one. Maize now supplies about half of India’s ethanol, and grains together nearly 67 per cent. Maize competes with soybean, groundnut and mustard for the same fields. Two forces pull land towards it. First, ethanol from maize is procured at a fixed price well above the sugarcane route, which keeps the crop attractive, whatever the market says. Second, the leftover grain from distillation is sold as animal feed, undercutting soybean meal. Weaker meal prices, in turn, drag down soybean prices. The oilseed farmer loses twice.

Similarly, water needs a clearer eye too, especially when it comes to the headline figures, that is, thousands of litres of water used for every litre of ethanol. The figures generally quoted mix two very different things. Green water is rain that the crop would have received anyway. Blue water is drawn from rivers, canals, groundwater pumps and wells. It is the blue water that is scarce, and cane in Maharashtra and Karnataka draws heavily on already-stressed sources. So the water rule should target blue-water use, not the frightening total.

Even the climate case is unsettled. Any blending beyond E20 would come almost entirely from grain, and Indian life-cycle studies do not agree on whether grain ethanol is cleaner than the alternatives once cultivation and processing are counted. The green argument for going further may not withstand closer scientific scrutiny.

That is not to say that the ethanol programme has not delivered

● WORDLY WISE
Speech is power. Speech is to persuade, to convert, to compel.
— Ralph Waldo Emerson

Those before us had less. But they gave more



MANPREET SINGH BADAL

KARTAR SINGH Sarabha was 19 years old when the colonial rulers hanged him at the Lahore Central Jail. He had already crossed an ocean, printed a newspaper, and come home knowing exactly what was waiting for him. Bhagat Singh was 23 years old. Madan Lal Dhingra, 25. Most of the men the Ghadar movement sent to the gallows were farmers’ sons from the villages of the Majha, Doaba and Malwa regions who could not have told you the first thing about political theory. They decided that some things were worth more than a life.

I want to begin there today because we have got into the habit of thanking our freedom fighters in the abstract — as though they were a category in a history textbook rather than young men with names, families and dreams, born in villages that many of us still drive past. Punjab paid a heavy price for this freedom. At Jallianwala Bagh, in the Ghadar trials, on the Komagata Maru, in the ranks of the INA. And then again in 1947, when the freedom we had bled for arrived as a line drawn across our own house. Millions were uprooted; families broken; a province cut in half, and its people made to walk out of homes their ancestors had built. And here is the part we do not say often enough: They did not become bitter. They arrived in Amritsar, Ludhiana, Jalandhar, and Firozpur with nothing and started again. They ploughed, traded, drove trucks and sent their children to school. They fed this country during the Green Revolution, and guarded it on the borders. Not one of them asked what the nation was going to do for them.

So let me ask the uncomfortable question. Somewhere between that generation and ours, we changed the relationship. We stopped treating India as something we built, and started treating it as something that owes us. We queue at consulates. We take our grievances to the street before we take them to the classroom or the field. We measure a government by what it hands out, and we measure ourselves by very little at all. I do not say this as an accusation against our young people, but as an admission by my generation. We inherited a Punjab that had been rebuilt once, and we did not build on it. We let our water fall, our soil tire, our industry drift, and our best young minds board flights. That failure is ours, not theirs. But here is what gives me hope. The restlessness that took Sarabha to California and our soldiers to Gallipoli and Kohima and our farmers to Rajasthan’s desert is still in us.

So to the young men and women of Punjab, and of India, I want to say this. Be revolutionaries again, but choose your revolution well. Wage it against your own limits first. Learn a skill so well the world has to come to you. Finish the degree. Stay off the poison taking our boys one by one. Look after your body and mind. Then go to your street. Teach one child who is falling behind. Save one field’s worth of water. Employ one person. Build something — a business, an institution — rather than assuming everything worth building has to be built somewhere else.

That is not a smaller revolution than the one Sarabha fought. We are not yet the country our freedom fighters imagined. We are closer than we have ever been. Whether we get there is not a question for the government. It is a question for the 23-year-olds. Those before us had less, but they gave more.

The writer is a former finance minister of Punjab

40 YEARS AGO

August 17, 1986



Art 249 extended to J&K

THE CENTRE has extended the operation of Article 249 to J&K. This was done secretly a fortnight ago by amending the Presidential Order of 1954, which extended the Constitution to the state. Since the state legislature is suspended, the amendment was approved by Governor Jagmohan.

Scattered riots in Pakistan

WITNESSES SAID the police wounded 12 people in Karachi during a third day of scattered riots when protesters attacked govern-

ment buildings, burned vehicles and clashed with authorities. Around 1,000 were arrested in Thatta district. Protesters also marched to demand the release of jailed opposition leaders, including Benazir Bhutto.

Car-bomb blast in Iran

ELEVEN PEOPLE were killed and about 100 injured when a car-bomb exploded in the holy city of Qom, in Central Iran, Radio Tehran reported. The radio said pilgrims, women and children were among the victims. It accused “agents of the United States” of responsibility for “shedding the blood of innocents”.

Andhra villages inundated

GODAVARI FLOODWATERS entered Dowlaiswaram town in Andhra Pradesh where many houses and office buildings were submerged in five to six feet of water by noon. Water from the swollen river first began leaking through a big hole in the wall by the side of the barrage. The crack widened and floodwaters poured in, submerging the town. As water began entering Dowlaiswaram town, a large number of people carrying their belongings could be seen climbing the Kothapeta Hill by the side of the town. Five thousand people were evacuated.

● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**

Republicans are taking deliberate steps to make health care less affordable.

— *The New York Times*

India's sweet revolution depends on this: Safeguard the bee, sustainability is key



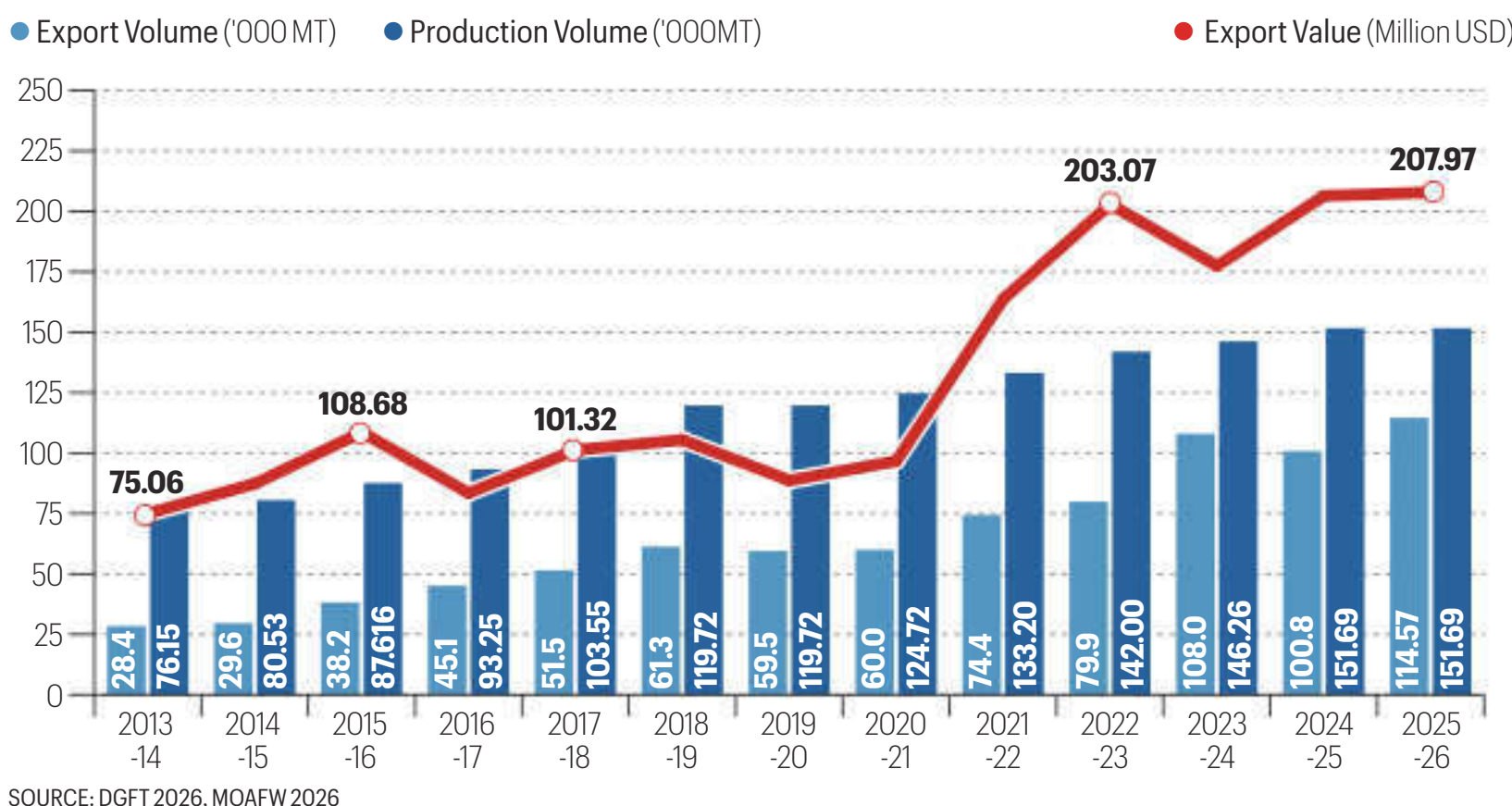
ASHOK GULATI, SUVANGI RATH, AND TANMOY ADHIKARY

INDEPENDENCE DAY this year coincided with the US's National Honey Bee Day. A honey bee is a small insect that can sit on a fingertip. Why is it accorded such importance in the US? According to the UN's Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO), the quiet role of bees as pollinators is responsible for almost one-third of global crop output. It enhances yields for 87 of 115 leading food crops.

Bees do more than improve yields. They enhance the nutritional quality of farm produce. If India has to make its agriculture productive and nutritious, bees must be treated as farmers' best friends. While passing by the mustard fields of Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan or the apple orchards of Himachal Pradesh, one realises what these insects can do. They have helped India emerge as the second-largest producer of honey in the world, after China, and the third-largest exporter of honey after China and New Zealand in value terms.

Beyond the pollination service, bees have helped farmers augment their incomes through apiculture (honey bee farming). India's honey production has nearly doubled over the last decade, from about 76,000 tonnes in 2013-14 to roughly 1,51,000 tonnes in 2025-26, signalling real scale in supply and capacity. Interestingly, almost 70 per cent of India's honey production is exported (\$208 million in 2025-26), and India accounts for around 8.4 per cent of global honey exports. However, the export basket remains highly concentrated: The US absorbed about 76 per cent of India's exports (\$157.8 million) in 2025-26. Such concentration carries risks for India's export

India's Honey Production and Export Trends



SOURCE: DGT 2026, MOAFW 2026

markets, a taste of which was felt when the US suddenly imposed high tariffs on goods imported from India. It was a big blow to Indian honey exporters and farmers, but the turnaround was also very swift in terms of diversifying export markets.

India's response was pragmatic. Shipments to countries such as the Netherlands, Belgium, Germany, and Israel have started reflecting a shift toward markets that value natural, sustainably sourced honey. At the same time, EU consumers are willing to pay a premium for traceable and environmentally responsible products, traits that India's multifloral and organic honey varieties can uniquely offer.

However, India's domestic market remains limited despite its large population. India's per capita honey consumption remains low (about 37 gm per year) — this suggests enormous potential that's yet to be tapped. As awareness of its health benefits spreads and retail penetration improves, a do-

mestic market can help stabilise producer incomes while supporting premium-quality exports.

This diversification mirrors a classic economic lesson: Trade barriers often compel resilience and innovation. Rather than being confined to one large buyer, India's honey sector is now spreading its wings across geographies, reducing dependence on a single market and building stronger foundations for long-term export growth. However, unit value realisation remains a constraint: Indian honey's unit value is about \$1,858 per tonne, well below the world average and far from premium categories like New Zealand's Manuka. Upgrading quality, traceability and branding is therefore essential. Also, price realisation can improve if exports are in branded retail packs rather than wholesale unbranded volumes.

Reforms and investments will determine whether this moment becomes a structural transforma-

India must look beyond honey exports and recognise bees as an essential, unpaid agricultural workforce

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Our nationalism

PERFORMATIVE NATIONALISM — shrugging off the flawed reality — refuses to fade from the theatre of Indian politics ("The nationalism that evokes pride, the nation we are", *IE*, August 16). Deriving instant gratification from empty rhetoric, along with cutting corners, is a primary cause of India's substandard socio-economic standing. The more perfunctory the declarations are, the less tangible the groundwork. Dignified human existence for a vast populace has yet to materialise, rendering the vision of a Viksit Bharat by 2047 more of a hollow platitude. India will only truly arrive when the dignity of a good life reaches the hands of its hardest workers, for true national pride is anchored in the souls of its citizens.

Raghvi Sharma, Sunam

Women's freedom

CONCERNS ABOUT women's safety, freedom and equal opportunity remain relevant despite progress ("An I-Day wish for my daughter", *IE*, August 16). Families and schools must teach boys respect, consent and shared responsibility from an early age. Public spaces need better lighting, transport, policing and swift action on complaints. Women should not have to restrict their choices for safety. Progress will come when institutions work, and social attitudes change, allowing women to study, work, travel and participate in life without barriers.

A Senthil Kumar, Kaniyur

Test for new law

THE QUESTION is not merely whether the previous policy was perfect or whether its replacement was necessary. It is whether the process of replacement itself has become a means of politically distancing the present governance pattern from both the failures and the achievements of the one before it ("What was promised by NREGA's new version, where it falls short", *IE*, August 13). A policy may be replaced, but the history of governance through which it operated cannot simply be erased. The test of VB-G RAM G will lie in its ability to show whether it has genuinely corrected the failures that justified its introduction.

Agnishikha, Gurugram



ARURJYOTI SAIKIA

IN THE third week of July, several south-bank rivers of Upper Assam rose with terrifying speed, unleashing torrents that swallowed paddy fields and grazing lands and swept through villages and towns. Several districts, once strangers to such catastrophic floods, found themselves engulfed in a disaster beyond imagination.

Assam's growing vulnerability to floods is rooted in a long history of shrinking safety margins in a landscape that, for centuries, enjoyed stability. In July, Upper Assam felt the brunt of the disaster even before the Brahmaputra swelled to its highest. Relentless rains pounded the Naga Hills and Arunachal Pradesh, soaking the slopes and unleashing sudden torrents into the southern tributaries. Many pointed to the region's land use — stone and boulder extraction from riverbeds and hillsides, a common sight in both highlands and lowlands — as a culprit that hastened the rainfall's journey, turning it into catastrophic floods downstream.

Cushioned between the Eastern Himalaya to the north, the Patkai and Barail ranges to the east, and the Bay of Bengal to the south, Assam is shaped by multi-layered environmental forces that have worked together for millennia. The southwest monsoon weaves together highlands, floodplains, billions of tons of sediments, and the ever-shifting channels of hundreds of rivers, creating a living, interdependent system. Each year, the monsoon decides whether Assam will bask in gentle rains or battle devastating floods. The July

Loss of forest deepened when, in the mid-20th century, a techno-bureaucratic campaign to build embankments set out to shield floodplains from floods once seen as predictable and nourishing for agriculture

Assam floods are not only story of a river's vagaries

flood brought this reality into sharp focus: Rainfall far beyond Assam's borders unleashed waters that surged across its land.

The highlands of Nagaland and eastern Arunachal Pradesh, which feed the rivers of the south bank of Upper Assam, have undergone dramatic land-use transformations in recent decades. Driven by growing populations, cultivation cycles have become shorter and more intense. Where once a colonial system of extraction dominated, today small-scale coal mining, woven into the fabric of local economies, and which competes with the highland agrarian economy, thrives through complex networks of speculators. Such pressure on uplands, along with relentless logging and expanding infrastructure, erodes the land's ability to absorb rainfall.

The south-bank districts of Upper Assam, at the heart of the recent flood, were once among the Brahmaputra valley's most resilient regions. Thick forests, scattered settlements, and a safe distance from the Brahmaputra's main channel defined these lands. But in the mid-19th century, this calm began to unravel as these areas drew the attention of colonial tea planters. Where rain once vanished quietly into the forest floor, the land was transformed into sites of plantations, mineral extraction, and farms that could no longer hold back the water.

The loss of forest deepened when, in the mid-20th century, a techno-bureaucratic campaign to build embankments set out to shield settled floodplains from floods once seen as predictable and

nourishing for agriculture. These barriers interrupted the flow of sediment. By 1988, even after thousands of kilometres of embankments had been built, two-thirds of the valley still lay open to flooding. During the July floods, embankments along the southern tributaries gave way before the main river crested, unleashing sudden breaches and a fall of water on an unembanked plain.

This inherited vulnerability has now deepened, as shown by new evidence that the monsoon is fast transforming. Meteorologists report that India's rainy season has become more unpredictable, marked by sudden downpours separated by long, dry spells rather than simply more rain overall. Studies focusing on Northeast India echo these findings. The big gap between intense rainfall and weakened landscape paints a fuller picture of the flash floods than only focussing on the quantity of rain.

The flooding in Upper Assam is not just a seasonal misfortune but the outcome of vulnerabilities built over two centuries. Unfortunately, the state's ecology has been treated as a puzzle for engineers and each crisis has been seen in isolation and the deeper ecological story given scant respect. Assam's environment is inching closer to its tipping point, but it is not yet beyond repair. We need to understand and retain the intricate connections between highland and lowland, water and land, forests and floodplains, and accept that the resilience lost over generations cannot be rebuilt by technology alone.

The writer is a Guwahati-based environmental historian

Note to Bar Council: Disagreement is part of justice



MAYANK MAKHLJA AND NAMAN SHARMA

IN THE legal drama *12 Angry Men*, about the deliberations of a jury during a murder trial, one juror insists that before sending a young man to his death, they should at least examine the evidence, despite 11 others disagreeing. It is a reminder that disagreement is a necessary part of justice. The Bar Council of India's (BCI) decision to withdraw its order stopping the enrolment of 2026 graduates of NALSAR University of Law is welcome. But it raises a more fundamental question: Can the regulator of the legal profession use its statutory authority to punish law students for expressing disagreement with a constitutional functionary?

On August 13, the BCI chairman directed State Bar Councils not to enrol NALSAR's 2026 graduates until further orders, following reports that some students had opposed Chief Justice of India Surya Kant's proposed participation in the university's convocation. The BCI sought details of those who initiated or organised the campaign. Later that day, the BCI found that the vast majority were innocent and consequently allowed all 2026 graduates to enrol with the State Bar Council of their choice.

The original direction deserves constitutional scrutiny because it concerned not merely professional regulation but the use of professional power in response to dissent. A law student does not surrender constitutional freedoms merely because he or she intends to become an advocate. Article 19(1)(a) guarantees citizens the freedom of speech and expression. Article 19(1)(b) protects peaceful assembly. These rights are not absolute, but the Constitution identifies the grounds on which speech may be reasonably restricted. Disagreement with the conduct, views or public actions of a constitutional office-holder is not, by itself, one of those grounds.

The Supreme Court's decision in *Shreya Singhal v. Union of India* is instructive. The Court struck down Section 66A of the IT Act because its vague and overbroad restrictions on expression could not be justified under Article 19(2). The judgment reaffirmed that the state cannot suppress speech merely because it is inconvenient, unpopular or offensive to some person or authority. The Court has also repeatedly recognised the constitutional importance of peaceful protest. In the Ramlila Maidan Incident case, the Court described freedom of speech and peaceful assembly as basic features of a democratic system and warned against arbitrary state action that frustrates these freedoms.

The Advocates Act, 1961 sets out the functions of the BCI. The Act does not give it unlimited power to punish conduct it considers objectionable. Section 24 specifies eligibility for enrolment, while Section 24A provides specific disqualifications. A regulator cannot create a new disqualification by executive instruction when Parliament has prescribed the conditions for enrolment. If particular students cross the line into misconduct, they should be individually identified and proceeded against under the appropriate mechanism. The Karnataka High Court's 2024 decision in *Sri S. Basavaraj v. Bar Council of India* is significant. While dealing with the BCI's supervisory powers, the court held that general supervision and control over State Bar Councils does not automatically confer power to issue "gag orders". If the BCI cannot use general supervisory power to silence advocates, it is difficult to justify an even broader use of that power against students who have not yet entered the profession.

There is an irony in the episode that should not be missed. Law schools teach students to question authority, while lawyers are expected to challenge executive action, question administrative decisions and defend unpopular causes. A profession that treats disagreement as evidence of unfitness risks teaching the wrong lesson. The BCI's responsibility is not merely to protect the "dignity" of the profession; Section 7 of the Advocates Act also requires it to safeguard the rights, privileges and interests of advocates and uphold constitutional standards.

That responsibility should encourage constitutionalism, not conformity. The BCI's withdrawal is a reminder that regulatory power has limits. For a country governed by the rule of law, the test of institutions is not how they respond to obedience. It is how they respond to dissent. If tomorrow's lawyers are punished for disagreeing with today's authorities, we should not be surprised when tomorrow's courts have fewer lawyers willing to disagree. A democracy needs lawyers who can say "no" to power and still be allowed to practise law.

Makhlja is a Supreme Court lawyer and former special public prosecutor for the Enforcement Directorate. Sharma is a final-year student at Maharashtra National Law University, Nagpur



MOANA BHAGABATI

A FRIEND recently remarked that my current work as a life coach was "just for pocket money". The comment lingered, not just because it stung, but because it revealed something larger about how we view women's work. Why is it that when a woman begins a new career later in life, especially after years devoted to family and caregiving, we instinctively assume it must be a hobby, a way to stay busy, a bit of extra spending money, rather than a serious professional choice made on her terms?

The question feels especially urgent given the Supreme Court's recent judgment describing homemakers as "nation

builders", and assigning a notional value of Rs.30,000 per month to unpaid domestic labour while calculating compensation in a motor accident case. The judgment has opened a national conversation that resurfaces every few years and then fades, about what counts as work and who gets to decide.

For generations, women have been told their work at home matters, while being treated as though it does not count. A woman may spend decades managing budgets, caring for children and parents and in-laws, providing emotional support, solving crises, and creating the stability that lets everyone else pursue their ambitions. Yet she is often met with the phrase: "Just a housewife".

That single word "just" reveals the problem. Stepping away from paid work to care for family is not an absence of work. The labour remains. The pay cheque disappears,

and with it, somehow, the recognition. I experienced this directly.

For more than two decades, academia was not merely my profession, it was part of my identity. Then family responsibilities pulled me away. The years that followed were filled with caregiving, problem-solving, emotional labour, logistics, and support. Alongside, there was continuous work of a voluntary nature supporting people in need

Women are first undervalued for the unpaid years they give to family and society. Then if they try to return to paid work, especially later in life, they are undervalued again

of emotional anchor. They were demanding and productive years but left no line on a resume, or a figure a salary slip could capture.

That is where the judgment and this kind of experience meet. Women are first undervalued for the unpaid years they give to family and society. Then if they try to return to paid work, especially later in life, they are undervalued again. The same "just" that shrinks a homemaker's labour also shrinks a 50-something woman's profession into something done "for pocket money".

Both judgements rest on a narrow idea of what counts as real work, who is allowed to do it, and when. Caregiving years build judgement, patience, crisis management, and emotional intelligence. A woman who returns to paid work after this is not starting from nothing. She is starting from years of practice, carrying capabilities that no intern-

ship or entry-level role could have taught her.

The ruling matters because it forces a legal reckoning with contribution. But the social reckoning still has to follow it into far more ordinary places. An employer who treats unpaid years as a liability and age as a ceiling isn't just being unfair to one woman. They are discarding a deep reserve of skill the country can't afford to waste. The years women spend caring for others are not empty or irrelevant. They are years of labour, growth, and quiet expertise. Recognising that has to mean more than a single judgment, however welcome. It has to change how résumés are read, how interview panels are trained, and how a society finally decides that beginning again, at any age, for any reason, is never just about pocket money.

The writer is a life coach

After protest, Alwar students promised new classrooms, RO water facility

Parul Kulshrestha
Jaipur, August 16

IT STARTED with a section of a road at a government school in Jodhawas village in Rajasthan's Alwar collapsing on Thursday, August 13.

Though no one was injured — the room in question has been closed for over a year — it scores of students at the school in Thanagazi town gathered in the school compound and began a protest, footage of which were widely circulated, finally catching the attention of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

The next day, CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka and others joined the students.

In the evening, Ranka posted a video on social media, announcing that the demands of the students have been accepted. District Education Officer Manoj Sharma told *The Indian Express* that the school had six functioning rooms and as many which were declared as unsafe following a survey.

"The roof, a part of which collapsed, was in a room that had already been declared unsafe. No one used to sit in that room. Students got scared due to the incident and started protesting. We accepted their demands. The sub-divisional magistrate (SDM) has promised that under the VB-G Ram G Mission, three new rooms will be constructed. We have also sent a proposal to the state government for four new rooms."

The students and CJP leaders also demanded that the toilets should be repaired. The administration has assured them that things will improve within 15 days.

Road connectivity is another major problem faced by the students. The school is situated near the Ruparel river. As water river swells during monsoon, students often have to wade through ankle-deep water.

In a hand-written note submitted to the students, the authorities have assured to make the culvert on the river motorable within 48 hours, and build a bridge in four months.

The students have also been promised installation of RO-filtered drinking water facility.

NTA ADMITS TO ERRORS IN PAPERS

UGC-NET retest for 3 subjects on Sept 9 & 10

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

THE NATIONAL Testing Agency on Sunday announced that it will re-conduct the UGC-NET June 2026 examinations in English, Commerce, and Sociology subjects after a committee found that the three question papers contained many factual, typographical, translation errors and a significant number of questions repeated from previous examinations, concluding that the papers did not meet the standards of a "fair and error-free examination".

In its notice, the NTA clarified that the re-tests will be conducted on September 9-10, with no additional examination fee charged from candidates who appeared for these three subjects. The English paper will be held on September 9 from 9 am to 12 noon in Shift 1, while the Commerce paper will be conducted the same day from 3 pm to 6 pm in Shift 2. The Sociology paper will be held on September 10 from 9 am to 12 noon in Shift 1. According to the NTA, a committee's findings recorded the three papers containing factual, typographical and translation errors. These included misspelled names of prominent scholars, incorrect or garbled book titles, errors in the wording of questions, grammatical mistakes, gender and number agreement errors, punctuation errors and non-standard terms for established concepts. The committee also found that a significant number of questions had been repeated from previous examinations.

The decision follows complaints from candidates after the original UGC-NET examination, conducted from June 22 to 30 across 87 subjects. The examination determines eligibility for Junior Research Fellowships and Assistant Professor positions and is also used for admission to PhD programmes.

grammes.

The latest UGC-NET controversy comes at a particularly difficult moment for the National Testing Agency, which has faced mounting questions over the reliability and capacity of the body that conducts some of India's most consequential examinations. The NEET-UG paper leak controversy led to protests by students in several states.

Although the nature of allegations in this particular UGC-NET are different from a paper leak, this adds to a series of disruptions that have dogged the UGC-NET in recent years. In June 2024, the government cancelled the examination, saying it had received inputs indicating that its integrity may have been compromised.

On Sunday, the agency said: "NTA concluded that papers carrying such defects do not meet the standards of fairness and error-free examination."

For the other 84 subjects in the June 2026 examination, however, the process will continue without interruption. The NTA said results for those subjects would be declared on schedule and that the allocation of Junior Research Fellowship seats and the issuance of eligibility certificates for Assistant Professor positions and PhD admissions would not be delayed by the retest.

The agency has also set a floor for the number of candidates who can qualify for Assistant Professor eligibility in the three affected subjects. The number will be equal to 6 per cent of the candidates who appeared in the original June examination or the retest, whichever is higher.

The NTA said the allocation of JRF seats, Assistant Professor eligibility and PhD eligibility in the three subjects would be carried out according to the examination's information bulletin. Numbers already allocated to each subject, it said, would not be reduced after the retest.

‘Ashoka-era stupa, bigger than Sanchi’: 90 years on, Ujjain mound comes under renewed focus

Striking engineering and construction, says 1938 survey report

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 16

THE MADHYA Pradesh government has begun a push to excavate and restore monuments linked to Mauryan-era emperor Ashoka, beginning with a fresh excavation of Vais-hya Tekri — after an almost 90-year-gap — in Ujjain.

The project comes amid a push by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav who has expressed interest in speeding up the excavation and restoration of the site, which belongs to his constituency of Ujjain.

Ujjain was an important city in the Mauryan world, and Ashoka was considered traditionally associated with it before he became emperor.

Dr Shivakant Bajpai, ASI Superintending Archeologist (Bhopal), told *The Indian Express*, "We have sent a proposal to the DG, ASI, for excavation of the site. It will take at least three years for the excavation to yield meaningful results and may also take several more years for completion. Restoring the stupa will be another monumental task and our objective is to ensure it is restored without inflicting any damage to the site."

The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) believes that there is a possibility that a stupa larger than the famous Sanchi stupa may exist at this site. However, there is a need for a deeper scientific study to establish the fact.

The renewed focus on Vais-hya Tekri is significant because the first excavation, carried out in 1938-39 by the Archaeological Department of the erstwhile



Vaishya Tekri has an estimated height of 100 feet against the 54-foot stupa at Sanchi, according to the excavation report

Gwalior State, had already established that the enormous mound was not a natural formation but the remains of a major stupa.

The original excavation report, preserved in the Annual Administration Report of the Archaeological Department, Gwalior State, for Vikram Samvat 1995 (1938-39), provides a detailed account of what archaeologists found beneath the mound.

The excavation report described Vaishya Tekri as a "huge stupa", estimating its base at approximately 350 feet in diameter and its height at not less than 100 feet. The height of the stupa at Sanchi is approximately 54 feet.

ASI officials said the name of the mound (ortecri) stems from the queen of Emperor Ashoka, who came from the Vaishya or merchant community. Ashoka is believed to have had a palace built there during his viceroyalty of Ujjain. However, at the time, the first archeologists who excavated the site opined that "excavations do not bear out the tradition."

What the 90-year-old report said

The monument's size was only one part of what fascinated the excavators; its construction was unlike what they had encountered elsewhere. Instead of

a conventional solid brick structure, the heart of the monument was made from local blackish murum, rammed hard to form the massive core. The exterior was then faced with brick masonry laid in mud mortar.

"The hearing is made up of local blackish murum rammed hard, while the facing is composed of brick masonry laid in mud mortar," the excavation report stated. The bricks were exceptionally large. The report recorded the biggest as measuring 22¼ inches by 18¼ inches by 3¾ inches, while another variety measured 22¼ inches by 15¼ inches by 3¾ inches.

"The size of bricks indicates that the structure belonged to the Mauryan period (3rd century BC)." That conclusion was further supported, the report said, by two coins recovered during the excavation — a punch-marked coin and a cast Avanti coin.

The archaeologists consequently considered a possible connection with Ashoka, but again stopped short of presenting it as an established fact and opined that "it is possible that the stupa is one of the many which Asoka is said to have built." The ancient builders had also substantially altered the landscape around the stupa. The report says the

enormous quantity of murum used for the core had been quarried from the surrounding area. The excavators found that these quarry areas had effectively formed a regular square moat around the stupa, while leaving a gap between the moat and the monument itself. On the western side, they found evidence of a passage across the moat.

"In the centre of the West side of the moat there are the vestiges of a passage across the moat, for worshippers coming from the city, which was situated in that direction," the report said.

But the first excavation also demonstrated just how much of Vaishya Tekri had already been lost. "The facing of the stupa has all but disappeared and it is not possible from what has survived to determine the exact plan and elevation of the stupa," it said.

Most striking was the engineering at its base. "An unusual and ingenious engineering device has been employed in the construction of the masonry at the bottom of this stupa..."

"This part of the masonry is built up in the shape of a bowl which supports the superstructure and with its slanting sides, resists the oblique thrust of the filling which is wide at the bottom and gradually narrows down as it rises up towards the top," it said.

The report also suggested that the monument had originally been taller than what survived. "The existing altitude of the stupa is slightly less in proportion to its base as compared with other stupas of the period but this can be explained by the fact that the top has been washed away," said the report.

The government and ASI will first have to secure control of the archaeological site. Ujjain district administration has sent a proposal to acquire the surrounding private land for Rs 40 crore for the excavation to begin in the first place.

Pistol goes off at Varanasi airport during security check, two injured

Express News Service
Lucknow, August 16

IN A FREAK incident, two security officials at Varanasi's Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport were injured on Sunday morning after a licenced pistol accidentally fired during checking.

The incident took place around 9:30 am when a passenger, identified as Azamgarh-based businessman Kamlesh Rai, was getting his licenced pistol screened before boarding the Air India Express flight IX-1810 to Mumbai.

During the inspection of the firearm, one round accidentally went off, leaving two screeners injured. The bullet hit one screener in the leg and the other standing nearby in the thumb.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* over the phone, Puneet Gupta, Director of Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport, said, "Two high-class screeners, a man and a woman, were injured during verification of the weapon being carried by an Air India passenger. The weapon somehow fired during screening. Both officials are not critical. We have handed over the investigation to the local police."

The injured screeners have been identified as Suman Kumari and Rohit Rai.

Meanwhile, police have detained Rai for questioning. He has been booked for endangering the life or personal safety of others.

Assistant Commissioner of Police (Varanasi) Prashant Singh said the investigation is underway, adding that the Airports Authority of India (AAI) is also probing the incident separately. Police said they would initiate the process to cancel Rai's arms licence.

3 held for raping 19-yr-old girl in Lakhimpur Kheri

Press trust of India
Lakimpur Kheri, August 16

THREE YOUNGSTERS were arrested for allegedly gang-raping a 19-year-old woman in Uttar Pradesh's Lakhimpur Kheri district, a police official said on Sunday.

Circle Officer Vivek Tiwari told reporters that the three accused, Siddharth (22), Madhumesh Mishra (23), and Vishu Kanojia (19), have been arrested.

Superintendent of Police Dr Khyati Rag said that the incident occurred on Saturday afternoon. One of the accused, who was on friendly terms with the woman, allegedly invited her to his home, when his parents were not present. He, along with two other friends, allegedly gang-raped the woman. The three fled the scene after her condition deteriorated. The survivor returned home and informed her grandparents about the incident.

Her family then took her to the district hospital, where she is undergoing treatment, and informed the police. SP Garg informed that all three accused are residents of the same area and a case has been registered against them under Section 70(1) (gang rape) of the BNS.

Kiran Parashar
Chamarajanagar, August 16

PROTESTS CONTINUED for the second day in Chamarajanagar and Mysuru on Sunday, seeking justice for three men killed in an alleged exchange of fire with forest officials in Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary early on Saturday morning. The families are demanding an independent probe, monetary compensation and the arrest of forest officials involved in the shooting.

Political parties in Tamil Nadu, including the DMK and PMK, claimed that the three victims were Tamils and questioned the officials' claim that they were poachers.

Hanur Police have registered an FIR against forest officials involved in the incident under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which deals with punishment for murder, after a formal complaint was lodged by the wife of one of the deceased, officials said.

Karnataka CMD K Shivakumar has already ordered a magisterial probe into the deaths of Antony Swamy (50),



John Rose Peter (42) and Kumar Sawariyappan (35), who lived in a tribal area near the protected forest. Joseph Mahima Das (44), who was accompanying the three victims, was injured in the incident.

Assistant Commissioner of Kollegala sub-division, Dinesh Kumar Meena, said they have initiated a probe. "The deputy commissioner has sought a report within a week. We have visited the spot and have gathered information. We are waiting for reports from police and other agencies," Meena said.

Forest officials said the men were poachers and were carrying at least 2kg of wildlife meat, and they opened fire at the pa-

trolling vehicles when confronted. Three of the four men were killed in self-defence, forest officials said. However, the families of the victims said the men were searching for cattle when forest officials shot them.

Inspector General of Police for the Southern Range M B Boralingaiah informed the media that the deceased were residents of Thomiyarpalya and neighbouring villages in Hanur taluk in Chamarajanagar district.

Boralingaiah said police have registered a murder case on a complaint from Mary, wife of Antony Swamy.

On Sunday, villagers gathered outside the KR Hospital where the bodies were taken for post-mortem. Mysuru Superintendent of Police Mallikarjun Baldandi told *PTI* that the families had consented to the post-mortem examinations.

In her complaint, Mary stated that two of their cows didn't return after grazing on August 14. Around 6.30pm, Antony, along with three others, left in search of the cows. Around 7am on Saturday, Mahima Das called Mary and

narrated the incident.

According to Mahima Das, between 3 am and 5 am, forest officials opened fire at them without provocation, Mary stated in her complaint.

The bodies were shifted to a government hospital, and when the news spread, villagers gathered and protested, rejecting the forest officials' version. Angry villagers and family members of the deceased even vandalised the Shagya forest office in Hanur on Saturday.

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar ordered a magisterial inquiry into the shootout. "I received information about the incident at 5 am. The truth will be known after the investigation. The shootout took place in a forest area. Several witnesses have been questioned, and items and guns have been seized," the CM had said.

Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary is spread across three districts — Chamarajanagar, Mandya and Bengaluru South (formerly Ramanagara). It is home to a variety of animals, including sambar, spotted deer, barking deer, elephants, tigers and leopards.

IPS officer's 94-year-old mother murdered inside UP home, cops suspect robbery

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 16

THE 94-YEAR-OLD mother of a serving IPS officer was murdered at her home in Malipur area of Ambedkar Nagar district of Uttar Pradesh on Sunday. Police said that they suspected robbery as a possible motive since several pieces of jewellery were missing from her body.

The woman has been identified as Indravati, mother of Superintendent of Police Ashutosh Mishra, who is posted in Lucknow.

She was found dead with a cloth stuffed into her mouth and injuries visible on her body, said a police officer.

The incident came to light around 9 am when a domestic help arrived at the house and found the main door locked from outside. "She opened the door and found Indravati lying unresponsive on a cot in the verandah. She alerted a neighbour, who informed the family and police," said a police officer.

A case of murder and robbery has been registered against unidentified persons at Malipur police station on a complaint lodged by Mishra.

According to police, the officer had visited his ancestral home at Rurha Dhamrua village on Saturday and returned to Lucknow later that evening.

In his complaint, Mishra said his uncle, Sachindra

Mishra, called him around 3:50 pm and told him that his mother had suffered a heart attack and died. When Mishra reached the village, he and his uncle examined the body and noticed that several pieces of jewellery were missing, including a gold chain, a tulsi necklace with gold beads, a nose pin and earrings. Her anklets were also missing. Blood was visible around her mouth, and a green towel had been stuffed inside it. Two injury marks were also visible on her lips.

Mishra told police that the circumstances indicated that his mother was murdered and that the assailants took away the jewellery she was wearing.



Arshdeep Singh Dang will now have to go through another year of training before handling fighter jets on the frontline

am privileged to represent my community on an international stage. I am the first Sikh to achieve this since World War II, but I don't want to be the last." "Sikhs made a major con-

tribution to the British Indian Army during World War II. Several Sikhs were awarded the Victoria Cross, the highest British gallantry honour. But since then, there haven't been any no-

● BORN IN CHANDIGARH, FLIGHT LIEUTENANT ARSHDEEP SINGH DANG MOVED TO THE UK WITH HIS PARENTS WHEN HE WAS SIX

Britain's first Sikh fighter pilot since World War II: ‘Want my success to inspire others’

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, August 16

WITH HIS roots in Punjab, Indian-origin Flight Lieutenant Arshdeep Singh Dang, 28, has become the first Sikh to graduate as a fighter pilot in Britain's Royal Air Force (RAF). He is the first Sikh to attain wings from a Fighter Squadron of the RAF since World War II, according to the RAF.

A fastjet pilot graduation ceremony was held at RAF Valley in North Wales on Friday (August 14), where the British Air Force announced, "Arshdeep Singh Dang has graduated as the first Sikh to attain wings from a Fighter Squadron since WW2."

Arshdeep told *The Indian Express*: "It was my paternal grandfather Sardar Santokh

Singh Dang's dream that my father should be a pilot. But my grandfather died when my father was just 6. So my father never really had those opportunities or resources to fulfil his wish. My parents encouraged me, and I started to believe I could be a pilot."

Arshdeep's father Jagdeep Singh Dang is a native of Ludhiana, and his mother Gagan-deep Kaur is from Amritsar. However, Arshdeep was born in Chandigarh in 1998, and the couple moved to the UK when he was 6. "I attended a school in Mohali for 2 years or so, but I don't really remember much. However, we keep visiting Punjab to meet our families. Two years ago, I visited Amritsar and Ludhiana," says Arshdeep. In the UK, the family lives in Southall.

Arshdeep attended the University of Bristol, earning a BSc (Hons) in mathematics and philosophy. He graduated from Officer Training in February 2022 and Elementary Flying Training in 2023. After serving in Cyprus, Dang was streamed to Fast Jet in 2024. He commenced his Fast Jet lead-in training in March 2025, followed by Basic Fast Jet training in July the same year.

He was sent solo to Texas in October 2025 and passed his wings test in July 2026. On August 14, 2026, he graduated as the first Sikh to attain wings from a Fighter Squadron since World War II. He will now undergo another year of intense training before handling fighter jets on the front line.

Arshdeep was the only pilot of Indian origin in his batch. "I

am privileged to represent my community on an international stage. I am the first Sikh to achieve this since World War II, but I don't want to be the last." "Sikhs made a major con-

tribution to the British Indian Army during World War II. Several Sikhs were awarded the Victoria Cross, the highest British gallantry honour. But since then, there haven't been any no-

table achievements. I want my success to inspire others. We always have a chance to create history, not just in the UK, but in the entire world," says Arshdeep.

"Although it was my grandfather's dream to see my father as a pilot, my pillar of strength has always been my mother. She kept us grounded, humbled and never made us feel low even when we had financial constraints. She anchored our family through the toughest times. She kept those Punjabi roots and Sikh values imbibed in us even after we moved from India."

Arshdeep said: "There's a very strict rule in our home. We speak Punjabi to each other, and no other language is allowed in the house. We always visit the gurdwara, have langar, and keep the core values of Sikhism intact

in our hearts. During tough flights, the forever Punjabi spirit of "*chardi kalan*" (always in high spirits) helped me a lot."

Gauravdeep Singh, Arshdeep's Ludhiana-based cousin, said, "He has made Ludhiana and Punjab very proud."

Several notable Indian-origin fighter pilots, including Sikhs, served with distinction in Britain's Royal Flying Corps (RFC) and Royal Air Force (RAF) in both World Wars.

Lieutenant Indra Lal Roy was a legendary fighter pilot of Indian origin who served in the British military during WWI and became India's first and only "Flying Ace", claiming 10 aerial victories with RFC and RAF in 1918. He was the first Indian ever to receive the Distinguished Flying Cross (DFC).

The most notable Sikh fighter pilots in British military history are Lieutenant Hardit Singh Malik, the pioneering WWI aviator known as the "Flying Sikh", and Squadron Leader Mohinder Singh Puji, a celebrated WWII fighter pilot who wore his turban proudly in combat. Both men broke racial and structural barriers to fly fighter aircraft for British air services.

Malik flew with French Air Service and later received an honorary commission as pilot in the British Royal Flying Corps (later the RAF) in 1917. Squadron Leader Puji volunteered for RAF in 1940 and flew Hawker Hurricanes across Britain, the harsh North African deserts, and dense Burma jungles. He earned the Distinguished Flying Cross for his bravery.

13 MAJOR AGRARIAN STATES INCURRED OVER RS 1.3 LAKH CRORE IN FARM POWER SUBSIDIES IN FY25

States ring-fence agri losses to ease DISCOMs’ financial stress

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 16

AMID FALTERING efforts to resolve the solvency of electricity distribution companies (DISCOMs), state governments are increasingly resorting to an easier fix: hiving off agricultural consumer load into separate entities and freeing up the rest of the utility from the burden of agri-supply losses. At least three states, Telangana, Maharashtra and Haryana, are pursuing plans to segregate agricultural consumers from existing DISCOMs and create separate entities for one of the power sector’s most heavily subsidised categories.

While Telangana and Maharashtra have created separate agriculture DISCOMs, neither is fully operational. Haryana’s proposal for a dedicated agricultural DISCOM was deferred after opposition from power sector employees.

Agriculture accounts for nearly one-fifth of electricity consumption and is the sector’s most heavily subsidised consumer category. With tariffs often below the cost of supply, DISCOMs rely on state subsidies and cross-subsidies from commercial and industrial (C&I) consumers, making them vulnerable to delays in subsidy payments — which can strain working capital and constrain investment in network up-

grades, affecting reliability and power supply quality.

According to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India, state governments spent nearly Rs 1.9 lakh crore on energy subsidies in 2024-25, mainly to support DISCOMs and provide subsidised electricity to farmers and households, making power the largest component of their subsidy bill. The 13 major agrarian states, accounting for 99% of India’s agricultural electricity sales, incurred over Rs 1.3 lakh crore in farm power subsidies in FY25, as per a report by the Council on Energy, Environment and Water.

Most state-owned utilities continue to incur losses and rely on borrowings to fund operating shortfalls and accumulated liabilities. Public sector DISCOMs have accumulated losses of Rs 6.77 lakh crore and borrowings of Rs 7.11 lakh crore. Telangana, Maharashtra and Haryana’s DISCOMs are also loss-making, with thousands of crores in debt.

A new DISCOM, old liabilities

In its December order last year, the Telangana government attributed the creation of this third DISCOM — Telangana Rythu Power Distribution Company Ltd — to the deteriorating financial position of the state’s two existing distribution companies: the Southern Power Distribution Company of Telan-

• SUBSIDY DELAYS SQUEEZE DISCOMS

AGRICULTURE ACCOUNTS for nearly one-fifth of electricity consumption and is the power sector’s most heavily subsidised category

WITH TARIFFS often below cost of supply, DISCOMs rely on state subsidies and cross-subsidies from C&I consumers

THIS LEAVES them vulnerable to delayed subsidies, straining work-



ing capital and limiting network investment and supply reliability

gana Ltd and Northern Power Distribution Company of Telangana Ltd, whose combined accumulated losses stand at Rs 69,741 crore against a borrowing of Rs 59,230 crore.

In March, the new entity was created to supply electricity to agricultural and select water-sector consumers. Subsequently, over 29 lakh agricultural consumers, along with several hundred others, were transferred to the new utility.

Liability, too, moved with load. The new entity would be liable for Rs 26,950 crore in payables to state-owned power-generating companies and a working capital loan of Rs 9,032 crore. Against this, the state government infused Rs 5 crore in equity, along with assets — agriculture distribution transformers worth Rs 2,792 crore and agriculture low-tension lines

valued at Rs 2,137 crore.

However, without commercial and industrial consumers, the financial viability of agriculture-focused DISCOMs remains uncertain, with fears they could become heavily dependent on government subsidies. “These DISCOMs will become exclusive government subsidy-based agencies. If you mop out all profitable areas, where is the financial estate of these DISCOMs? The purpose of these DISCOMs is to segregate losses and enable privatisation of profits,” said K Ashok Rao, patron at All India Power Engineers Federation.

Cleaning up the balance sheet

In Maharashtra, MSEB Solar Agro Power Ltd was carved out of state-owned Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSEDCL) as a

subsidiary of its parent, Maharashtra State Electricity Board (MSEB) Holding Company, to function as a deemed distribution licensee and retail supplier for agricultural consumers, including billing.

Under the restructuring scheme notified in May, Rs 32,679 crore of MSEDCL’s Rs 59,527 crore in pending agricultural dues will be written down, with the state government assuming an equivalent liability through government securities. MSEDCL will create a corresponding reserve to write down the agricultural receivables, despite carrying Rs 90,659 crore in borrowings and an accumulated loss of Rs 35,671 crore.

Shrinivas Bobade, President of Maharashtra-based Subordinate Engineers Association, said the entire exercise is nothing but paperwork to clean up the balance sheet of MSEDCL, as it seeks to go for an IPO. “If MSEDCL’s balance sheet shows such huge receivables from the agricultural consumers, who would like to invest? So, they created this agriculture DISCOM to make their books better,” he told *The Indian Express*.

Queries sent to the state governments, MSEDCL and MSEB Holding Company, and Telangana Rythu Power Distribution Company remained unanswered till the time of filing this report. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NxtGen takes cloud services overseas

New Delhi: Indian sovereign cloud and artificial intelligence infrastructure provider NxtGen has launched SpeedCloud Global, taking its managed cloud and AI services to international markets as competition intensifies among cloud providers to serve growing demand for AI compute.

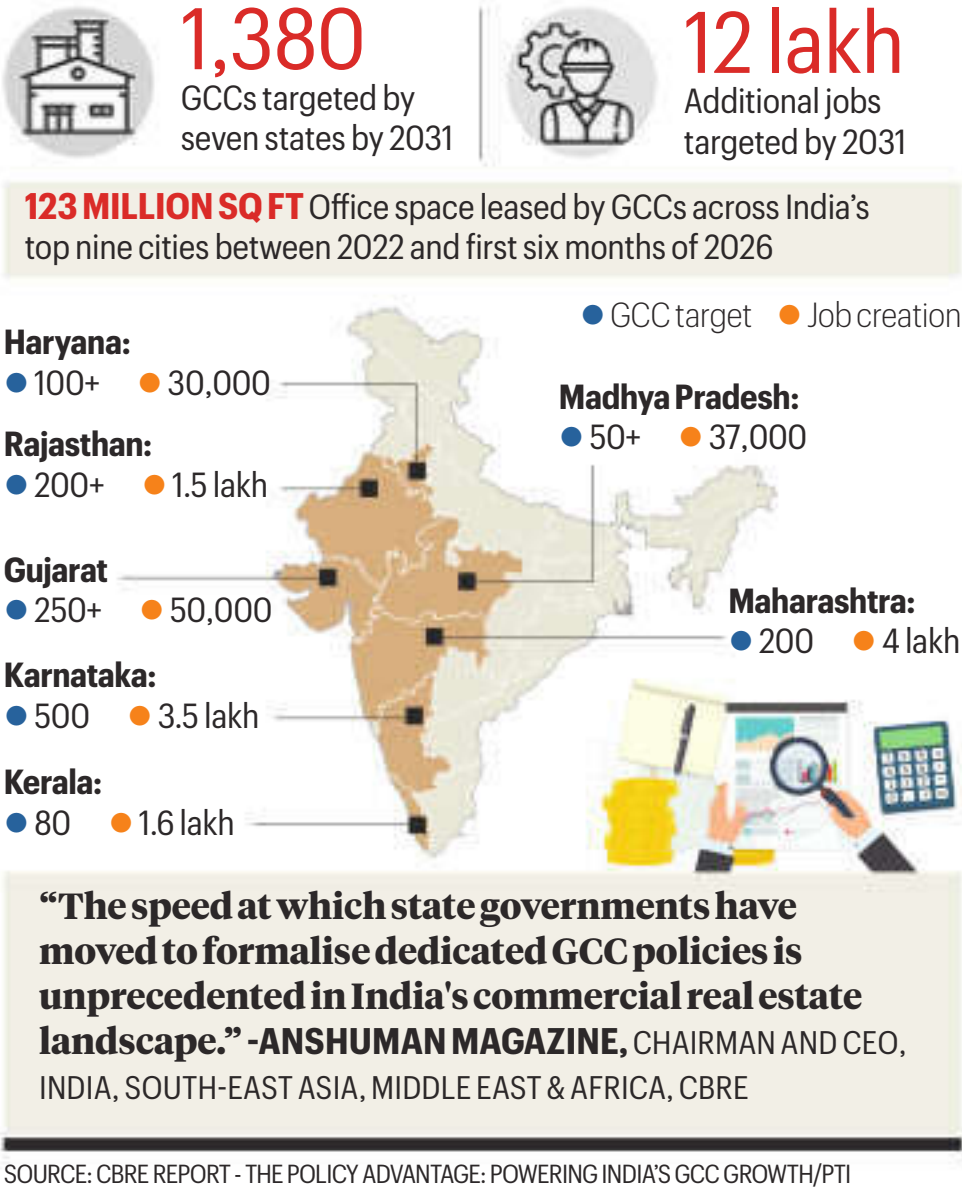
The company said the service would offer general cloud workloads at 39-48% lower cost than leading hyperscalers, with deployments possible in as little as 48 hours. It did not identify the overseas markets it would initially target or disclose investment details for the expansion.

“India is no longer only the back office of global technology; it is now building world-class cloud infrastructure and competing on performance and cost, on its own terms,” NxtGen MD and CEO A S Rajgopal said. **ENS**

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• 7 STATES TARGET 12 LAKH GCC JOBS BY 2031

Seven states have come up with dedicated policies to set up Global Capability Centres (GCCs), aiming to create more jobs, according to a report by CBRE.



Govt aims to clinch 5 BITs in 2-3 months

Prasanta Sahu
New Delhi, August 16

THE GOVERNMENT is aiming to finalise new bilateral investment treaties (BITs) with the European Union (EU), Saudi Arabia, Switzerland, Oman and the Maldives in the next two to three months, offering enhanced flexibility to foreign investors including a shorter timeline to exhaust domestic remedies before initiating international arbitration.

Simultaneously, the Cabinet will consider the proposed BIT 4.0 regime, which revises the model text for a better balance between sovereign interests and foreign investment as well as creates a flexible framework for future negotiations.

A flexible model would allow India to tailor provisions based on the partner country’s strategic importance and investment ties, sources said. **FE** reported recently that

• A RECENT CAG REPORT FLAGGED THAT E.COLI BACTERIA WAS FOUND IN STATIONS DRINKING WATER

Railways orders filtration system at stations after CAG report

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, August 16

AFTER THE Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India flagged poor drinking water quality at the railway stations and even said that total coliform bacteria, including E. coli bacteria, were found during its testing, Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw on Sunday directed some immediate corrective measures like a new ‘tank to tap’ water filtration system at around 20,000 locations, including water coolers.

The officials said regular water testing at the source and outlet points will be conducted.

“From now onwards, the water quality of stations will be monitored at the board level. There will be scheduled cleaning and maintenance of storage tanks. Progress and water quality reports will be published periodically to ensure transparency. This action is part of a larger drive to address all CAG observations and improve the overall travel experience,” said a senior railway official.

In a recent report titled ‘Passenger Amenities and Sanitation at Non-Suburban Railway Stations in Indian Railways’, the CAG said E. coli bacteria was found in drinking water samples collected from taps in eight rail-



E. coli bacteria was found in drinking water samples collected from taps in eight railway stations out of 49 stations. **REUTERS**

way stations out of 49 stations.

These stations are Coimbatore, Palakkad, Hyderabad, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus, Bhiwandi Road, Kalyan, Lon-

Gen Z’s buy-now, pay-later habit fuelling unsecured loans, worrying regulator

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, August 16

TWO MUMBAI-BASED teenage girls travelled with their mother to Busan, South Korea, to attend a concert of Korean boy band BTS in June, financing much of their spending through a credit card.

A young couple travelled to Thailand for a vacation last year, spent well beyond their budget on credit cards, and have since then resorted to rotating money through third-party vendors to create artificial cash flow, according to a personal finance post on Reddit warning about funding small luxuries with debt.

While India’s household debt has surged in recent years, financial sector regulators are particularly concerned about the composition of that debt. Non-housing retail loans — largely used for consumption — now account for more than half of household borrowings, and have grown faster than housing, agriculture and business loans, a trend flagged in internal discussions among policymakers.

As of March 2026, non-housing retail loans — primarily the consumption segment — constituted 58.4% of households’ total borrowings, up from 54.9% of total household debt in March 2025. Average outstanding debt per borrower rose to Rs 4.78 lakh as of March-end 2025, from Rs 3.41 lakh as of March-end 2018, according to Ministry of Finance data. The sharpest increases have come in some personal borrowing categories. Outstanding loans against gold jewellery jumped to Rs 4.61 lakh crore as of March 2026 from Rs 74,738 crore in March 2022, while other personal loans’ outstanding stood at Rs 17.32 lakh crore as of March 2026 compared with Rs 9.02 lakh crore in March 2022, data shared in Parliament on Monday (August 10) showed.

While the risks to the Indian financial system from household lending remain contained, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has flagged household debt accumulation, particularly among lower-rated borrowers, as requiring “close monitoring”. Gross NPA ratios stood at 0.7% in secured retail loans and 1.7% in unsecured retail loans at end-March 2026. The “exposure to these sectors requires close monitoring as

DRI uncovers Rs 2,500 cr areca nut import racket

New Delhi: The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has dismantled a network involved in importing South-East Asian areca nuts into India by falsely declaring them as Bangladeshi origin and fraudulently availing concessional duty benefits under the South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA).

The finance ministry said an investigation by the DRI has so far revealed a potential revenue loss of more than Rs 2,500 crore. Nine persons have been arrested.

The import of areca nuts into India attracts customs duty of 100%. However, eligible imports of areca nuts under the SAFTA agreement are fully exempt from customs duty. **PTI**

• Non-food bank credit, outstanding personal loans (March-end)

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Personal Loans	34,66,075	41,82,767	53,46,691	59,71,696	69,39,750
Consumer Durables	17,834	20,985	23,445	23,201	21,962
Housing*	17,38,473	19,91,164	27,18,712	30,10,477	33,55,963
Education	83,693	96,482	1,19,380	1,37,456	1,55,824
Vehicle Loans	4,04,756	4,87,597	5,73,391	6,22,793	7,38,678
Loans against gold jewellery	74,738	89,370	93,301	2,06,284	4,61,373
Other Personal Loans	9,01,595	11,62,345	14,27,872	15,35,197	17,31,838

NOTE: FIGURES IN RS CR; SOURCE: RBI

*(INCLUDING PRIORITY SECTOR HOUSING)

risks to asset quality could increase, especially if overall economic conditions weaken due to the West Asia conflict and impact borrower cash flows”, the RBI had said in its latest Financial Stability Report.

Unsecured personal loans remain a particular vulnerability: In the small-ticket personal loan segment of less than Rs 50,000, fintech firms have gained a higher 56.8% market share, after strong 41.6% credit expansion, well above the overall segment growth of 20.1%. Delinquencies stood at 6.4% as of March 2026. About 70.5% of fintech loan books are unsecured, with roughly half of these loans extended to borrowers under 35. As per the latest CIBIL TransUnion data, the share of India’s credit-eligible population that is credit-active has risen from 11% about a decade ago to around 28% now.

Of the credit-eligible population of 890 million, close to one-third have, over the last year, taken a loan or have a loan running, or are paying EMIs or credit card bills. Almost half of this credit-active population has a consumption loan — credit card, personal loan, or consumer durable loan — while nearly 10% have an entrepreneurial loan or business-oriented loan.

The number of credit-active consumers with consumption loans and business loans grew fourfold and tenfold, respectively, between 2017 and 2024, TransUnion CIBIL data showed. Consumption borrowing has been driven substantially by younger consumers, including Gen Z, often with repayment tenures of less than three years.

“What we need to continu-

ously monitor is that while encouraging credit growth, are we incentivising need-based credit. The other thing is the ability to pay, especially in certain segments such as younger borrowers where the leverage has gone up. In the case of consumption loans, for instance, the lender cannot be in a position to fully qualify income information and if on account of the increased leverage, the consumer is in a situation to pay or not,” an executive with a credit bureau said.

The share of over-leveraged consumers rose threefold — from 5% in FY17 to 18% in FY24 — before easing marginally to 15% in FY26 after industry intervention, with excessive borrowing concentrated among younger consumers. Their share in the country’s credit-active base has increased from 33% in 2017 to 39% in 2026.

Even as unsecured retail lending has moderated — it forms 25% of retail loans and 8.3% of gross advances — its asset quality has weakened relative to the overall retail portfolio. Its gross non-performing asset ratio stood at 1.8% vis-à-vis 1.2% in March 2025, with stress particularly visible in private sector banks.

The trend suggests a growing propensity to incur debt for immediate consumption rather than asset creation. Outstanding credit card debt crossed Rs 3 lakh crore last fiscal, while delinquencies — payments overdue between 90 and 360 days — rose more than 40% year-on-year, as per the data from CRIF High Mark, an RBI-registered credit bureau.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• BRIEFLY

Govt sets LPG output targets for refiners

New Delhi: The Centre has for the first time fixed maximum cooking gas LPG production targets for individual public- and private-sector refineries and upstream firms, as it seeks to build a domestic supply buffer after the West Asia conflict. The Petroleum and Natural Gas Ministry, in an August 13 order, specified maximum LPG production levels for 21 refineries and upstream firms, with combined production potential set at 63,810 tonnes a day. **PTI**

RBI may incur \$9-12 bn in FCNR hedging costs

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) could incur \$9-12 billion over five years in hedging costs if foreign currency non-resident (bank), or FCNR(B), deposits mobilised under its special swap window reach \$70 billion, with economists estimating annual hedging costs at 2.5-3.5%. The RBI has already received \$52.3 billion through FCNR(B) deposits as of August 13, which would translate into a five-year hedging cost of about \$6.5-9.1 billion at the same range of annual costs. **FE**

What is Truth API?

An application programming interface, or API, essentially allows one computer system to automatically obtain information from another. Truth API packages publicly available posts from some of Truth Social’s most influential accounts into a structured, machine-readable stream that computers can consume almost instantly. All this results in those with access to the API receiving posts on Truth Social milliseconds before regular users.

TMTG launched the product on August 1 after announcing it in July as its first data-licensing business. The feed covers posts from influential Truth Social accounts, provides round-the-clock access, and includes a historical archive going back to 2022. The crucial selling point is speed.

Instead of a trader manually refreshing Trump’s Truth Social profile, or waiting for a phone notification, an algorithm can

Why is it controversial?

At the heart of the controversy is a key question on whether investors who

can afford tens of thousands of dollars each month receive faster access to statements made by the sitting US President that could move financial markets, even if it is just a matter of milliseconds. The posts themselves are public. TMTG has stressed this distinction, with McGurn saying the company’s customers only receive “published and publicly available posts fractionally faster”. Commercially licensing real-time public data, it argues, is commonplace across technology, media, and financial-information businesses.

And selling faster data feeds may not in itself be unusual or necessarily illegal. Lawyers cited by *Reuters* have pointed out that technology platforms can offer different speeds of access to public information even if that leaves some market participants at a disadvantage. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, AUGUST 17, 2026

NEW S M A K E R S I N T H E N E W S R O O M

WHY SHUBHANSHU SHUKLA

Shubhanshu Shukla spent 20 days at the International Space Station last year, becoming only the second Indian — the first in over four decades — to travel to space. His journey stirred the imagination of an entire generation of youngsters for whom space travel might not be as remote a possibility as it was for their elders. After his return, Shukla has taken on the role of a space ambassador, motivating students to reach for the sky. Currently, he's on ground zero, preparing for the Gaganyaan Mission planned by Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). His book, *The Second Orbit*, details the experiences of his space journey.

Amitabh Sinha: Your book, *The Second Orbit* (Penguin), starts with 14-year-old Shubhanshu Shukla writing to his future self. And he wants his future self to reply to him. Could tell us about how this idea of the book came about?

The book idea was suggested by many people, even before I went on the mission. When I was in the US, I was advised that I should keep track of what is happening and journal it. The idea of a book was not in my mind at that time. After the space journey, I have been meeting and talking to many people. It was then that it was suggested that I should write a book. I also realised that it's not possible for me to be everywhere, in every school, in every college. So, a book is a good way to do this. I was able to relive those moments. If I had not done it at this point, then probably some of them would have been lost.

Amitabh Sinha: Tell us about the year-long process of training that you went through, the excitement, the anxiety, the sheer scale of achievement.

To become an astronaut, the sheer number of disciplines that you need to train in increases significantly. When you are up in space, there is nobody else. You have to be the pilot, commander, your own doctor, researcher, scientist, plumber, mechanic, everything has to be you. I learned microbiology, medical procedures, it was fascinating.

As for the scale, in hindsight, it is even bigger than what I probably had in mind. But when you are in training, you cannot let your mind think like that. If you do, you start taking the pressure of the enormity of it, then it has a crippling effect and you don't function very well. I don't function very well. It was only when I was in space did I realise the enormity of it — something larger than life, and something you never thought would happen.

Amitabh Sinha: From the launch (on June 25) till your return, were there any crisis moments that were completely unexpected?

Going to space is a managed crisis. Life should not exist in space. There is nothing that supports life, no air, no water. It is a harsh environment. The sheer energy and force that you experience when you are escaping the pull of gravity from Earth, it is phenomenal. So, just to give an analogy, imagine you are strapped to a seat and the seat is sitting on top of 500 tons of propellant and then you light it on fire. It is not a normal thing, but it is managed very well. That is why there are so many people reviewing these things.

When you reach space, everything is actually unexpected. You are taught very well, you are trained very well, but the environment that you experience when you reach there, that cannot be simulated on the ground. Microgravity is the new element which actually changes everything because things don't behave the way they behave when you are on the ground. Everything is new, everything is a delta that you have to navigate and experience only when you are there. There is a saying in the space flight community that you are ready for a space flight when you finish one.

Amitabh Sinha: The Gaganyaan is yet to happen. When you were selected for it, this was just before Covid and Axiom was not on the horizon. There were many delays. At any point, did you think that probably this is not going to happen?

Yeah, that is what was happening. Even in well-established programmes, like the United States and the Russian ones, the average time before an astronaut flies to space is around five to six years. Some astronauts have been selected and never flown. That also happens. So, there is no certainty that you will get to fly. Anything can change in a moment. That is why it was important to enjoy what you are doing when you are not flying.

Even now, after this flight has happened, I do not know when the next one is. If you look at the career of an astronaut, they probably fly two to three times to space, and if they are flying from the US, it is for six months at a time. So, about three times is 1.5 years. Now, for a career that spans 40 years, 1.5 years is the time that is spent in space. The rest 38.5 years is on the ground. So, if you do not enjoy that, then it is very difficult.

Amitabh Sinha: Our Gaganyaan programme is scheduled in the next year or two. Have you transformed into a trainer of sorts for your colleagues?

Not for my colleagues because we all went to Russia together, we were trained there. They, too, are experienced pilots in the Air Force. Actually, I am the junior most among the four of them. One of them came to the US as well for the Axiom Mission and underwent training. But yes, there are lessons to be learned.

The primary objective of doing the Axiom Mission 4 was to learn as much as we could and then how do we use that experience to enable our own mission. That is a major exercise that we are doing right now.

ON HIS LEARNINGS FROM AXIOM

I learned the importance of being a follower. Everywhere, even at the IAF, we are taught to be leaders. But, it is important to listen to others, learn from their experiences and unlearn a few things of your own

ON AN ASTRONAUT'S CAREER GRAPH

An astronaut flies two to three times in his life. From the US, it is six months at a time. About three times is 1.5 years. For a career of 40 years, the rest 38.5 years is on the ground. So, you have to enjoy what you do

'Today's kids are brilliant... you have to be with a dream for a long time, work on it, only then will it happen'

Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla on training for space travel, how the process and working at Axiom Space is different from working on the Gaganyaan Mission with ISRO and why the vastness of the space was overwhelming. The session was moderated by Amitabh Sinha, Climate and Science Editor, *The Indian Express*



Astronaut and Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla (right) with Amitabh Sinha, Climate and Science Editor, *The Indian Express*, at the Noida office last week RENUKA PURI

Amitabh Sinha: Do you see any difference in the way Axiom was preparing itself and the way ISRO has been doing it? Are there any noticeable differences?

Axiom Space is a private company which was coordinating missions to space. It didn't actually own any hardware for the missions. The International Space Station is owned by NASA and its international partners. The vehicle in which we flew to space was SpaceX's Crew Dragon vehicle and the rocket was Falcon 9. So that was owned by SpaceX. Axiom did not own any hardware. What ISRO is doing is we are trying to make our own hardware: the capsule, the spacecraft in which the astronauts will go. So it's a very different nature of work. Here, we are trying to make it in-house and launch Indian astronauts on our own vehicle and in our own capsule. This is heavy engineering work, and robust processes and review mechanisms are being set up. So, it can't be compared.

Anonna Dutt: What are the learnings from your journey that have brought in changes to processes in the Gaganyaan Mission?

These are such complex processes that it is very difficult to put a finger on something. I travelled to space but there was a team from ISRO which was also there to see how things were happening. We witnessed this end-to-end execution of the entire mission. ISRO has launched many successful missions in the past but human space-flight is something that we are attempting for the first time and it requires a different ecosystem. We were able to see the scale of operations and what the different disciplines are that we need to address before we actually send people to space and bring them back. That is the biggest learning. There are obviously more segmented, pointed, objective lessons that are being applied, there are so many.

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: How do you

look at life on Earth from space?

When you look back at Earth, from that perspective, it does change something in you. Even in aviation, you never see Earth as a whole. The first feeling that I got — everybody may have different experiences — but the first feeling that I got in space was that this felt like home. The planet felt like home. It really gave me that perception that I am from here. I am not pinpointing India. I am saying that I am from Earth. That was a very strong feeling I had.

The second thing, the vastness. Earth is massive. We know the dimensions but we have not seen it. So when you see that, it feels very big. But if you think about it, it is not the biggest planet. You can fit 1,300 Earths in Jupiter. And our solar system is not the biggest one in our galaxy. And our galaxy is not the biggest in the cluster that we are in. The cluster is not the biggest in the supercluster. So you can go on and on till the end of the universe. So your position, actually where you are, is very average, there is nothing special about

this. So, the thought of the vastness of space is overwhelming.

Amitabh Sinha: Most of us were very young when Rakesh Sharma went to space, and we heard his famous line, 'Sare Jahan Se Accha'. Was it at the back of your mind that you also had to come up with something which everyone remembers?

Yes, of course it was there, and even today when I speak to Sir (Rakesh Sharma), I tell him that he made my life so difficult by saying something so profound. When I was speaking from space, I was aware of the enormity of the situation. I had written a few lines but sometimes those moments are so overwhelming that you forget everything. I just spoke whatever was coming to my mind. There was no competition to say something as profound as him, but the primary feeling was this: It has taken us 40 years to reach here but this time it is different. It won't take us this long to be back in space again. India has changed a lot from

what it was in 1984, our position has changed, things have changed.

Amitabh Sinha: You mention in your book that the stay at ISS was very busy and you seldom had time to enjoy the view. Are there certain things that couldn't do on ISS that you would like to do on the Gaganyaan flight?

Several things, but the nature of the mission will also be very different. The ISS mission was known, established, doing experiments and coming back. Gaganyaan will be a prototype mission. It will be more about proving the technology, testing out systems and communicating with the ground. But yes, if there is time and things that can be planned, I would definitely do a lot of things very differently.

Amitabh Sinha: More photography?

Absolutely. And I would not plan the mission during monsoons because you don't get to see India at all.

Anuradha Mascarenhas: The NDA (National Defence Academy) is known for physically and mentally demanding exercises. Were there any particular drills that you disliked as a cadet but today you are grateful for?

There are two types of fun in life. There is Type A fun and Type B. Type A fun is when you are having fun in the moment, and later when you think about that experience, you still enjoy it because it was so memorable. Type B fun is where when you are doing it, you absolutely hate it. But when you look back, you really enjoy it. The NDA experience is Type B fun, most of it. It prepared you for life. That is what actually takes you to the extremes of what you think is possible.

Jayashree Narayanan: What is your message for Gen Z and Gen Alpha who are watching you?

The kids, from what I have seen, are bril-

liant. The way their thought process works, there are no restraints on them. There are no boundaries within which they feel they have to think. That is why they have been able to break free. And that is very important for us as a nation because the first step to achieving something big is to dream about it.

The second part of it is that dreaming is just one aspect. You have to really be with that dream for a long time and work on it, then only will it happen. It doesn't happen overnight. It doesn't happen in one or two days. Whatever they want to do or achieve, they will have to give it time and they will have to give it effort for a sustained period.

Divyanshu Dutta Roy: The younger generation is often said to be chasing instant gratification. Would you make a case to children and teenagers to follow your path instead, which is a path of rigour, diligence and discipline?

I think everyone understands what it requires to get to the place where you want yourself to be. You have to like what you are doing. Then it doesn't feel like a burden. Sometimes, you might not like certain things but are forced to carry on. That is where discipline comes in.

Instant gratification is probably one of the biggest challenges that the current generation is facing. Patience levels are dropping. It happens to us also. In our times, the challenge was of scarcity. Things were not available. Today, the problem is of abundance. Everything is available. So, there is a lot of distraction, and the challenge is to focus on your goals. That is a skill that has to be developed. You saw the Skyroot launch which happened recently. This work has been happening for the past decade. Those 10 years are very important for this exciting time. You have to invest time, there is no other way. You can temporarily become famous overnight, but that is not going to sustain. You have to do something meaningful for a long time for it to be really effective.

Shalini Langer: Once you've seen space, what do you think of God?

I've always believed that there has to be some sense to what is happening around us. For instance, you don't realise as we are sitting in this room, you are moving at a speed of around 30 kilometres per second. Your solar system is probably moving at around 700 kilometres per second at the same time. Now, this entire thing is explained by science. But even that understanding is limited because science itself is evolving. So I believe that there must be something which is making all this happen, and we should be grateful for what we have, and that is what makes your life peaceful and good. The experience of space definitely has strengthened my belief in the things that I used to believe even before going to space.

Shalini Langer: What about people who are paying to go to space, space tourists?

I hope more and more people go to space and the cost comes down so that more people can experience this — going out and looking at Earth from the outside. Because fundamentally, things do change when you have that perspective and change for the better. Change in the sense that you really feel that you are all in this together — this is your planet and you have a responsibility towards it. So, if you are able to get that perspective, if 100 people can get it, great. If 1,000 people can get it, even better. So it should happen. But again, you have to be very responsible in doing it.

Karishma Verma: After your mission, your mother's reaction went very viral. So what was that conversation after the mission that you had with your mother?

She could not come to Delhi because of health reasons. When I went to Lucknow for the first time (after my return), the first words that came out of her were: "Beta ab ho gaya hai. Dobara mat jaana (It's done, don't go again)."

Shiny Varghese: Space technology has given us carbon water filters and GPS systems. What new technology did you wish you could have back home?

The water reclamation system on the International Space Station recycles about 98 per cent of the water. And so you really don't have to carry a lot of water to space. This would be something that if we can scale it up and use it on Earth as well, it would be a huge benefit to all of us. Conserving water and using it more resourcefully, that is something that we can do with a lot more of.

Amitabh Sinha: You have worked in teams at the IAF. How was working with the Axiom team different, given that everyone was from a different country? What were your learnings?

I learned the importance of being a follower, and to learn from others. At IAF, and everywhere else, we are taught how to be leaders. And that is good. But I think, it is important also to be able to listen to others, learn from their experiences and probably unlearn a few things of your own.



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WHAT EARTH FELT LIKE FROM SPACE

The first feeling I got in space was that this felt like home. The planet felt like home, that I am from here. I am not pinpointing India on the planet. I am saying that I am from Earth. That was a very strong feeling

WEEKLY CAPSULE

Ozempic reveals craving centre

OZEMPIC-LIKE drugs appear to weaken more than hunger — they may also reduce cravings for alcohol and other addictive substances. Scientists are increasingly tracing this effect to the lateral septum, a brain region that helps connect memories and surroundings with rewarding experiences. Packed with GLP-1 receptors, it may act as a crucial control point between thinking about a reward and feeling compelled to pursue it. The discovery could open new approaches to treating addiction as well as obesity. GLP-1 activation directly in the lateral septum has recently been shown to reduce food craving in mice.



Keratin for regrowing bone

KERATIN EXTRACTED from sheep's wool helped damaged bone regenerate in animals, producing tissue that was more organised and structurally similar to healthy bone than tissue grown with conventional collagen scaffolds. The discovery by King's College London could turn an agricultural byproduct into a promising new material for regenerative medicine. It is a naturally derived material and is often discarded as waste by the farming industry, giving it potential as both a renewable and scalable resource. Collagen membranes generated more bone overall but the one with keratin scaffolds was more secure.



Blood test as health radar

UCLA RESEARCHERS have created a simple, relatively inexpensive blood test that showed promise in early studies for detecting several types of cancer, multiple liver diseases and signs of organ problems at the same time. The approach works by examining fragments of DNA that circulate naturally in the bloodstream. Since cells release DNA into the blood, these fragments can contain molecular clues about the health of many different organs. The test could eventually provide a more affordable way to detect disease earlier while also giving doctors a broader picture of a person's health.



Fruit juice lowers depression

A DAILY GLASS of 100 per cent fruit juice or a smoothie may help improve more than just fruit intake. In a small four-week trial, participants who added one to a healthier diet showed significantly lower depression scores, hinting that a simple dietary change could also support mental well-being. Researchers at Newcastle University evaluated changes in mood using validated questionnaires that measure symptoms of anxiety and depression. Participants who consumed fruit juice and smoothies alongside whole fruit had lower depression scores than the control group.



Why we repeat decisions

WHY DO we keep making the same choices even when better options are available? Researchers found that simply repeating a decision can reshape what we prefer, causing familiar choices to feel better than alternatives. Instead of weighing every option from scratch, the brain often remembers what it chose before and repeats it. That shortcut may help explain many everyday habits and seemingly irrational decisions. The results of a study by TUD Dresden University show the pattern could influence shopping decisions, habits, and recurring routines.



INTERPRETATIONS OF MALADY

DR SURANJIT CHATTERJEE

SENIOR CONSULTANT, INTERNAL MEDICINE
APOLLO HOSPITAL, DELHI

H1N1 or flu: Fever is done but why does weakness remain?

Fatigue, body ache or a return of fever after an illness may be part of recovery

A PATIENT RECENTLY came to the clinic after recovering from a viral fever. The fever had settled, the initial tests were no longer concerning and he had started going back to work. But he was still feeling unusually tired. On some days, he felt almost normal. On others, even routine activity left him exhausted. A few days later, he developed body ache and a mild fever again. His immediate concern was that the first infection had returned. This is a situation that can be confusing for patients, particularly during the monsoon, when dengue, chikungunya, influenza, H1N1 and other infectious microbes can circulate at the same time. The symptoms can overlap and recovery is not always a straight line. Fever is one of the most visible signs of an infection, so people often use it as a measure of recovery. Once the temperature becomes normal, they expect their energy to return as well. But the body may take longer to recover. During an infection, a person may eat less, lose fluids, sleep poorly and remain physically inactive for several days. The immune response to the infection also takes time to settle. As a result, weakness, poor appetite, body ache and reduced stamina may continue even after the fever has gone. This does not mean that the infection is still active. A negative test is reassuring, but it is not a measure of how quickly the body has regained its strength. Why then do some patients feel better and then worse again? One reason is that people often return to their routine too quickly. After several days of illness, a person may feel better for a day or two and resume full working hours, exercise or travel. The following day, the fatigue may become much more pronounced. This can feel like a relapse but sometimes it is simply the result of doing more than the body is ready for. A gradual return to activity is therefore important. Strenuous exercise should not be resumed simply because the fever has disappeared. Many ask me if a new infection is possible. This is where overlapping infections become important. A person recovering from one viral infection can still be exposed to another infection. Seasonal infections may produce similar early symptoms such as fever, body ache, headache and fatigue. It can, therefore, be difficult to determine from symptoms alone whether someone is still recovering or has developed another illness.



A person recovering from one viral infection can still be exposed to another. Somebody may be diagnosed with viral fever and later test positive for dengue

Government guidance also notes that one infection does not necessarily exclude another, and co-infections can occur. For example, a patient may recover from influenza, return to work and then develop fever again after a fresh exposure. Another person may initially be diagnosed with a viral fever and later test positive for dengue. These situations need clinical assessment rather than assuming that every recurrence of weakness is simply "post-viral fatigue." There is another reason why a returning patient should not simply be reassured because the fever has come down. In dengue, the period when the fever starts settling can be important. The critical phase generally occurs around this time in patients who develop complications. Warning signs include persistent vomiting, severe abdominal pain, bleeding, increasing drowsiness, difficulty breathing, restlessness or reduced urine output. These symptoms require prompt medical evaluation. Platelet count is also not the only measure of recovery in dengue. Hydration, blood pressure, haematocrit (percentage of your blood that is made up of red blood cells and is evidence of plasma leakage) and the patient's overall clinical condition are important in deciding how the illness is progressing. If there is no evidence of a continuing or new infection, the focus is usually on recovery. Adequate sleep, regular, balanced meals, sufficient fluids and gradual physical activity are important. It is also important not to start antibiotics simply because fatigue continues. Antibiotics do not treat viral infections. Steroids and other medicines should similarly not be taken without a clear medical reason. Most people improve gradually. But persistent or worsening symptoms deserve reassessment. A returning fever, breathlessness, chest discomfort, repeated vomiting, fainting, confusion, reduced urine output or a significant deterioration in general health should not be dismissed as weakness after a viral infection.

Kidney transplant, low cost and high access: Doctor who treats – and teaches

With subsidised dialysis, crowdfunding and a push for early screening, the Chennai nephrologist is tackling fund barriers and offering accessible therapy

Arun Janardhanan

LOOKING AT Chandran driving an auto rickshaw in Chennai, one would not know that he had a kidney transplant over a decade ago. Or that he had no money for the surgery although his wife had volunteered to be a donor. That's when Dr Georgi Abraham turned to crowdfunding so that the procedure could be done. Today, Chandran lives to see his son excel at his job. "Ever since then, I realised that transplant is often a question of money before medicine," says Dr Abraham, the veteran nephrologist who is now working actively through his foundation (Tamilnad Kidney Research or TANKER, Chennai) to make transplants accessible to patients with kidney failure. "The medicine has advanced dramatically. Donor-recipient matching is better, screening is more sophisticated and newer anti-rejection drugs have helped transplanted kidneys survive longer. But for a poor patient, the path from dialysis to transplantation can still depend on whether a family can assemble enough money to cross the distance between having a donor and reaching an operating table," he says.

He is building a low-cost, high-access transplant-care model built around reducing the biggest recurring costs through subsidies, expanding the donor pool by efficiently recovering kidneys from deceased donors and ensuring post-surgery care as anti-rejection medicines are expensive but ensure the transplants last longer. On average, a kidney from a living donor functions for 15 to 20+ years, while a deceased donor kidney lasts 10 to 15 years with the right follow-ups. "Many organ recipients abandon this stage because of high costs," says Dr Abraham. "Immediately after the transplantation, the cost of anti-rejection medication, depending upon the match between the donor and the recipient, could be as high as Rs 20,000 or Rs 25,000 a month to as low as Rs 10,000 a month," he says. That expenditure generally declines over time as the amount of immunosuppression required decreases.

He is working with the Madras Medical Mission to provide free or subsidised HLA (human leukocyte antigen) testing — this assesses donor-recipient compatibility — for economically disadvantaged transplant patients. Such testing can cost up to ₹40,000. The approach is to reduce the financial barriers at every stage of transplantation — from subsidising dialysis and helping patients pay for the transplant to making essential post-transplant medicines and tests more affordable. "If some assistance can be given for post-discharge compliance, then, like Chandran, a patient can meet the cost of medication from their own earnings. Since Chandran's transplant has lasted, his requirement for anti-rejection drugs is relatively low now," he adds.

Dr Abraham has already worked on reducing dialysis costs by pioneering peritoneal dialysis, a home-based treatment for kidney failure. It uses the lining of the abdomen (the peritoneum) and a special cleansing fluid to filter waste and extra fluid from your blood. One of his patients, Shanti Raj Mohan, lived with kidney failure and dialysis for 23 years. "Shanti taught me that you could be a very purpose-driven person despite having kidney failure," says Dr



ARUN JANARDHANAN

Abraham, who has provided more than 9.04 lakh free or subsidised dialysis sessions to 3,378 patients. The foundation currently provides close to 10,000 dialysis sessions a month through 16 centres, with most treatments offered free through a combination of government health insurance, civic bodies and private donors.

In the early 1990s, obtaining the dialysis fluid was difficult. "Initially it was a Herculean task because the government did not permit import of dialysis fluid to India until 1994," Dr Abraham says. That changed when the fluid was placed under open general licensing in 1994. India now has domestic manufacturers supplying peritoneal dialysis fluid across the country. Yet Dr Abraham says the treatment remains underused. "The reluctance is because of logistical and reimbursement problems," he says.

These days he is busy with a more elementary question, why wait for the kidneys to fail? A question that has fuelled his campaign for targeted kidney screening through primary health centres across panchayats in India, using simple creatinine, urine and blood-pressure tests. The goal is to identify chronic kidney disease among high-risk populations before irreversible damage sets in. His proposed screening model is strikingly simple: a creatinine blood test, a urine examination and a blood-pressure measurement. Those who should be prioritised, he says, include people with diabetes, hypertension or heart disease, those with a family history of kidney disease, people who have previously suffered acute kidney injury, those using alternative medicines and people above 45.

"A simple blood test to measure creatinine, using a strip with a meter, and a simple urine test can identify most of the time whether you have kidney disease or not," says Dr Abraham. The urgency is considerable. He cites a 2016 publication in *The Lancet* that estimated the prevalence of chronic kidney disease in India at about 17.2 per cent. Even a relatively small failure to detect disease early can translate into an enormous number of people eventually reaching advanced kidney failure.

"Over 46 years, kidney care in the country has changed. Today, people in their 60s, 70s, 80s and even 90s undergo dialysis.

Dr Georgi Abraham with his honours and testimonials at his terrace museum



SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO



Kidney transplantation has become safer because of better donor-recipient matching, improved screening and newer anti-rejection medicines. Patients who once might have been considered too old for aggressive treatment can now be kept alive for years," he says. Yet India has not built an equally ambitious preventive screening infrastructure so that people don't reach that stage. Transplantation, for one, cannot solve the problem at population scale. There will never be enough donor kidneys for everyone who needs one. "We cannot provide transplants to all the patients who are on dialysis. This will never happen in any part of the world," says Dr Abraham.

Besides, India now has roughly 3,300 kidney specialists, according to Abraham, compared with a very small pool two decades ago. He hopes that number can rise to 10,000 within another decade. "During a recent visit to AIIMS in New Delhi, I had watched a colleague facing a clinic load of more than 100 patients. To get every detail from each takes time," he says.

That gap is one reason Abraham believes screening cannot remain confined to specialist centres. If kidney disease can be identified earlier at the primary-care level, some patients can be monitored and treated before they reach the point where dialysis becomes inevitable, he reasons. He is also wary of assuming that India can simply import its understanding of kidney disease from Western countries. His own team recently examined lipid profiles of 1,000 dialysis patients and found differences from patterns described in developed countries. "We need to have a strong platform for research to deal with our own diseases, our own disease patterns and how to treat them cost effectively," Dr Abraham says.

He is equally cautious about another common assumption: that India is witnessing a distinct epidemic of kidney disease among the young. What has changed, he argues, is visibility. India's population has expanded, diagnostic methods have improved, kidney biopsies and imaging are more accessible, patients are more aware and the number of trained nephrologists has risen substantially. "The challenge now is to ensure that greater visibility comes early enough to make a difference," he says.

A MODEL THAT WORKS

Dr Georgi Abraham's outreach programmes are a combination of education, interaction, screening, counselling and referral.

CHILDREN'S WORKSHOP



AT HIS kidney workshop as part of his Catch 'em Young project, children are told how their two kidneys act like tiny strainers that clean the blood and turn extra water and waste into pee. "We explain that when the kidneys get hurt, it is like their filter getting clogged. Then we focus on how taking care of their bodies helps the filters stay clean and strong rather than focussing on scary sickness. We show them how drinking plain water helps flush the system like washing out a dirty cup. We explain how too much salt or packaged junk food makes the kidneys work overtime, while fresh fruits and vegetables give them an easy job. We remind them not to hold their pee for too long so that they can avoid infection," says a volunteer. "There is a tendency among very young people to have high blood pressure in the country," says Dr Abraham, recommending annual blood-pressure checks for children from age three.

AWARENESS TALKS

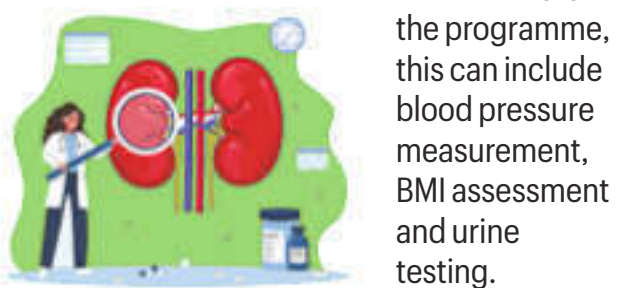
THIS INVOLVES helping people understand the connection between diabetes, high blood pressure, obesity, smoking, unhealthy diets and kidney disease. "Kidney awareness should begin with routine blood pressure and blood sugar monitoring. Systolic blood pressure — the top reading — should generally be kept around 120 mmHg, while people with diabetes should monitor HbA1c (the average blood sugar count of three months). It is normally below 5.6 per cent but ideally should remain below 6.5 per cent in diabetics, and below 7.1 per cent in older diabetics," says Dr Abraham.

BUILDING A SCIENTIFIC TEMPERAMENT



HE WARNS against unnecessary antibiotics, painkillers and unmonitored Ayurveda, Siddha or homeopathic medicines because of damaging effects on the kidneys. Since the kidneys filter waste from the blood, they are highly exposed to concentrated toxins present in unregulated supplements. This damage can manifest as acute kidney injury (AKI), chronic kidney disease (CKD), kidney stones, or complete renal failure.

BASIC HEALTH SCREENING



may add blood tests such as blood glucose, creatinine or imaging when medically appropriate to eliminate risks.

DEPENDENT ON the programme, this can include blood pressure measurement, BMI assessment and urine testing. Some camps

Partnering with liver: The liver and kidneys are linked as a cooperative filtration and chemical processing team. Severe liver damage can change blood flow. This tricks the kidneys into shutting down, causing sudden kidney failure. If one organ fails, extra toxins stay in the blood and stress the other organ.



Link with the heart: The kidneys and heart are closely linked. Kidney problems can raise the risk of a heart attack and heart problems can damage the kidneys. Damaged kidneys often cause blood pressure to rise. High BP damages

arteries and increases the chance of a heart attack. Kidney disease is associated with inflammation and changes in blood vessels, making atherosclerosis (plaque buildup) more likely. Poor kidney function can cause the body to retain sodium and fluid, increasing blood pressure and putting extra strain on the heart.

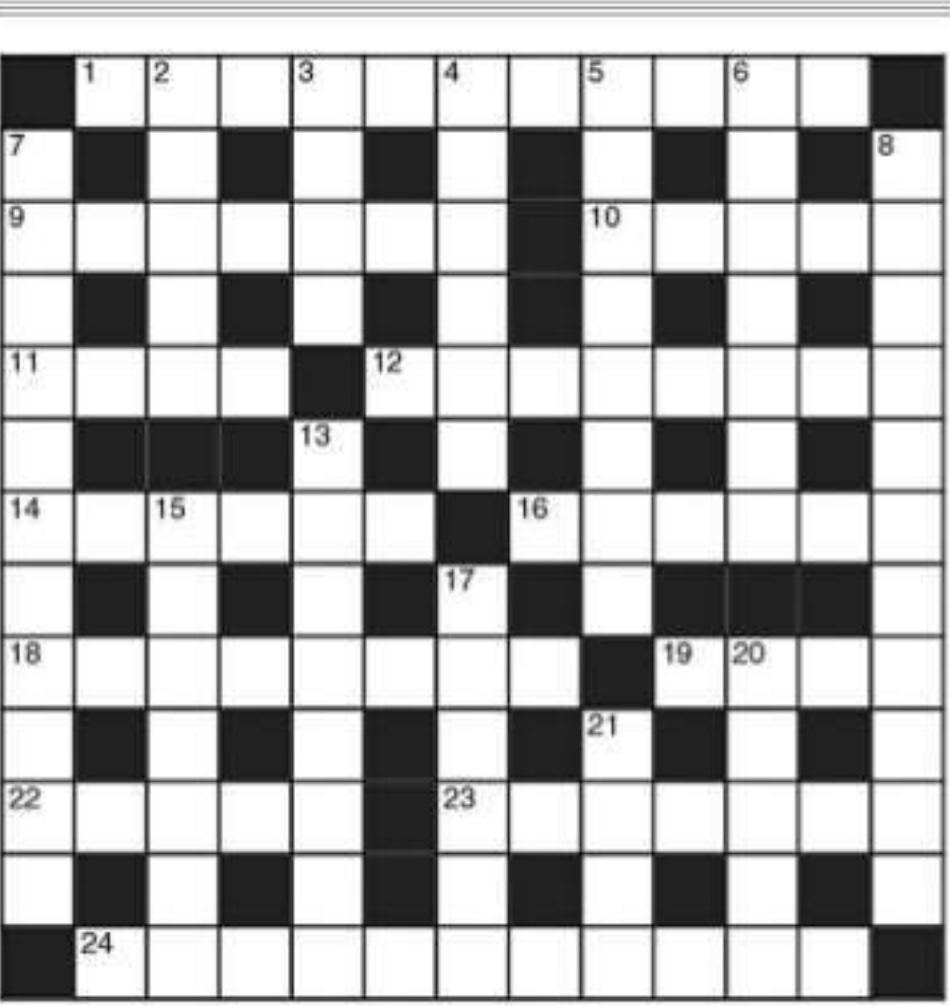


When diabetes is a risk: The filtering units of the kidney are filled with tiny blood vessels. Over time, high sugar levels in the blood can constrict these vessels. Without enough blood, albumin (a type of protein) passes through these

filters and ends up in the urine where it should not be. Diabetes damages nerves, which carry messages between your brain and your bladder. Damaged, your brain won't sense your bladder is full. If urine stays in your bladder for a long time, bacteria grow, triggering a urinary tract infection.

CROSSWORD

6069



- ACROSS**

1 Sphere of the occult (7,4)

9 Multiply without going forth (7)

10 Managed for example to turn round the stove (5)

11 Fuel container in military vehicle (4)

12 Don't give up in attempt to get a win (3,5)

14 Pot is upset by relatives. Get a cloth (6)

16 A poem's positive points (6)

18 Boring unusual rites have nothing on me (8)

19 Passage for one from Oslo (4)

22 A giant among stars (5)

23 His is a searching examination by all accounts (7)

24 When it's too humid to hunt? (5,6)
- DOWN**

2 Steal in and get the bird (5)

3 Spring is something one may associate with flowers (4)

4 They're cold-blooded and they're calculating (6)

5 Cheap items don't allow profits (8)

6 Neckline that may bring out a whistle (7)

7 Difference achieved by best exam candidates (11)

8 Where people may drive after the service (6,5)

13 Gives no answer in debate? (8)

15 Not wholly biased (7)

17 Black marks for slanderous attacks (6)

20 Top in garden party presentation (5)

21 It is thought to be almost perfect (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6068 **ACROSS:** 1 Silent, 4 Shamrock, 9 Uncurl, 10 Gardenia, 12 Lots, 13 Party, 14 Etna, 17 Agony columns, 20 Bathing belle, 23 Okay, 24 Using, 25 Styx, 28 Radiator, 29 Desist, 30 Landlady, 31 Archer **DOWN:** 1 Skullcap, 2 Location, 3 Norm, 5 Heartburning, 6 Made, 7 Ornate, 8 Koalas, 11 Man of his word, 15 By-law, 16 Snobs, 18 Flatfish, 19 Selector, 21 Corral, 22 Pardon, 26 Yawl, 27 Gear

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

There is no _____. You must always start with something. Afterward you can remove all traces of reality - Picasso (8,3)

DNPA A

RETAR

AOOTTT

AISBCS

Afterward you can remove all traces of reality - Picasso

ANSWER: There is no abstract art. You must always start with something. Afterwards, you can remove all traces of reality - Picasso

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6413

3			4	9		6		
				1	3			
	7			2				5
		2			4			8
7		6					9	2
5				7	8			
			9	5				
		2		8	1			3

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6412

7	2	4	3	1	6	5	8	9
9	8	5	4	7	2	6	1	3
1	6	3	8	5	9	4	2	7
4	1	6	7	8	3	2	9	5
5	9	7	2	4	1	8	3	6
8	3	2	9	6	5	7	4	1
6	5	9	1	2	4	3	7	8
2	7	1	5	3	8	9	6	4
3	4	8	6	9	7	1	5	2

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a fun-loving, playful day. Enjoy talking with everyone. Sports and fun times with kids will appeal. Be prepared to cooperate with others, because you might have to go more than halfway when dealing with spouses, partners and close friends. Tonight: Cooperate.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Discussions with an older family member might take place today. The concern could be about practical repairs. If so, wait until the Moon alert is over to commit to anything. Meanwhile, a work-related romance might begin. Tonight: Get better organised.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a great day for a short trip. You'll enjoy talking to siblings, relatives and neighbours. Wait until the Moon alert is over to commit to anything. It's also the perfect day for a date. Tonight: Socialize.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You'll enjoy entertaining a home today. In fact, it's the perfect day for a romantic date. You also might have a practical, serious discussion about money or finances. If so, wait until the Moon Alert is over to agree to anything. Tonight: A warm conversation.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): In the morning, things are a bit laid-back, but as the day wears on, your energy will pick up. Enjoy talking with others. Discussions about legal or medical matters might be practical and serious, but wait until the Moon alert is over to act. Tonight: Check your money.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You'll enjoy some privacy today, especially because you might be involved in discussions about taxes, debt or shared property. You might want to figure out how to divide something. If so, wait until the Moon alert is over. Tonight: Patience.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a tricky day. The first thing to know is there's a Moon alert for most of this day. Nevertheless, it's a favourable time for discussions and making plans, but not for agreeing to anything. It's a marvelous day to socialise. Tonight: You're in charge.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): People will listen to you today. You have some sensible ideas you want to share, especially related to your job, your health or even a pet. Check the Moon alert. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Enjoy the company of friends. You might discuss travel opportunities or issues related to the law, medicine, or higher education. Be aware of the Moon alert. Tonight: Friendships.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You make a great impression on others today, because people see you as warmhearted, generous and attractive. Meanwhile, practical discussions about finances and shared property might occur. Tonight: You're noticed.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): This is a friendly, sociable day. Enjoy talking with others, especially people from different cultures. Travel will appeal. Someone older or wiser might have advice for you. Romance is percolating. Tonight: Explore.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Discussions about how to share or divide something will favour you today. However, don't agree to anything important during the Moon alert. Meanwhile, this is a friendly, romantic day full of fun possibilities. Enjoy yourself. Tonight: Check your finances.

UPSIDA

कार्यालय बहिष्कृत प्रबंधक (निविदा) बरेली
निर्माण खण्ड-न्याय, बरेली
उपनिर्देशक अधिकारी
E-Mail-cd11@upsida.co.in

पूर्णकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना

एतद्वारा सूचित किया जाता है, कि विभिन्न औद्योगिक क्षेत्रों के अन्तर्गत विकास/अनुसंधान कार्य हेतु सरकारी विभागों/सार्वजनिक उपक्रमों/निगमों/प्राधिकरणों/निगमों/नगर निकायों में पंजीकृत फर्मों/उद्योगों से ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं, जिसको अपलोड करने की समय सीमा निम्नवत् है:-

अग्रिम 01 की निविदा दिनांक 17.08.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे से दिनांक 06.09.2026 को अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड की जा सकती है, जिसे दिनांक 07.09.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे खोल जायगा (पूर्वाह्नकालीन)।

निविदादाताओं द्वारा केवल शपथपत्रों की मूल प्रतियाँ निविदा प्रपत्रों में उल्लिखित दिनांक तक कार्यालय में जमा की जा सकती हैं। ई-निविदा के माध्यम से आमंत्रित की जाने वाली निविदाओं का विवरण निम्नवत् है:-

क्र.सं.	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की लागत (रु. लाख में)
1.	Annual Maintenance work at I.A. Lakhimpur, Distt.-Lakhimpur Khiri, (U.P.)	Rs. 3229204.00

नोट:- निविदादाता अपनी निविदाओं में समस्त कर राशियाँ दर्ज अंकित करें। जी.एस.टी. अलग से देना होगा।

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0130068121-1

I, Shri Krishna S/o Ram Bahadur Dubey R/o Plot No. 74-a, F/F, Kh.no.22/19 And 22/2 Indraprastha Enclave, A-block (presentlygoyla Vihar), New Delhi 110071 have changed my name to Shri Krishna Dubey for all purposes.

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Devinder Kumar Dixit S/o Sh. Ram Vilash Dixit R/o H. No. B-592, Gali No.1, Madanpur Khadar, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No.175/2019 U/S 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS Kalindi Kunj, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Devinder Kumar Dixit** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Devinder Kumar Dixit** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Devinder Kumar Dixit** of **FIR No.175/2019 U/S 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS Kalindi Kunj, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **17.09.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Azad Sehrawat
Judicial Magistrate First Class-10
Room No.307, 3rd Floor, South East District
Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/11437/SE/2026(Court Matter)

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Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ranjeet Singh** of **FIR No.55/2020 U/S 279/338 IPC, PS Rajouri Garden, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **16.09.2026**.

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BANGLADESH'S HISTORIC WIN IN NUMBERS

3 Bangladesh needed only 3 Tests to register their first Test victory on Australian soil. That makes them the quickest Asian team to achieve the feat

1995 The result also ended a remarkable run for Australia. Before Bangladesh's victory, Australia had not lost a home Test to an Asian team other than India since Pakistan defeated them in 1995

9 The nine-wicket victory is Bangladesh's second-biggest Test win by wickets. Their biggest remains the 10-wicket victory over Pakistan in Rawalpindi in 2024

2 Bangladesh's victory in Darwin is only their second Test win in the traditional SENA countries - South Africa, England, New Zealand and Australia



Bangladesh secured their first win on Austrailian soil after losing their first two Tests way back in 2003. AP

Darwin triumph marks Bangladesh evolution

Tigers' historic nine-wicket win over Australia was more than an upset — it was a coming-of-age moment that showcased their pace-bowling strength, resilience and growing belief in Test cricket

Sandip G
New Delhi, August 16

BANGLADESH WILL forever remember the old, quaint city of Darwin, in Australia's Northern Territory. There, on August 16, they etched the most memorable moment in their cricket history, a golden hour of surreality, when they hammered (and a hammering it was) Australia by nine wickets. "This is the biggest moment for Bangladesh cricket, and this encourages us to do something special in the future," Bangladesh captain Najmul Shanto said after the game, face beaming and eyes moist.

He was not exaggerating. The feat and its nature were shudderingly implausible. Bangladesh out-skilled, out-powered and out-muscled a full-strength Australia at home, even if the stage was far away from the grand citadels of the country, the outlier locale reserved for whom the elites of the world condescend as minnows.

Maybe that was Bangladesh's stirring inspiration. To be snubbed of the prime venues of the vast country; to be treated like a fixture-formality; to be considered trivial to not invite for a Test series in 23 years; to be mocked and ridiculed after a third-string domestic side bowled them out for 54 in the warm-up; to be not taken seriously; to be cast off from the T20 World Cup in India early this year. They are a cricketing nation fuelled by emotions; just that, often, they let the rage of emotions self-destruct them. In Darwin, they harnessed the

India's WTC final aspirations take a further hit

HEADING INTO the two Tests in Darwin and Galle, Bangladesh were in fourth position on the World Test Championship (WTC) table, one place above India, but it was largely considered a statistical quirk. After all, they had played just four games – losing 0-1 in a two-Test series in Sri Lanka, and beating Pakistan 2-0 at home. They were expected to face sterner Tests when they travelled away from the subcontinent.

India had garnered positive vibes from the 2-2 draw in England before thrashing the West Indies 2-0 at home. But the balloon was pricked by a 0-2 reversal at home to South Africa. The two Tests in Sri Lanka were touted as the first step towards qualifying for the WTC title

blend of pride, anger and hurt to produce something monumental and imperishable.

The seam-friendly conditions did not over-excite their fast bowlers, prone to bouts of over-exuberance. Seamer Hasan Mahmud, who embodies the discipline Bangladesh exhibited, probed nasty lines and plugged away on stingy lengths. Only 26, and if his body holds up, Mahmud could be his country's tour de force in numerous heists overseas. He is already the most complete fast bowler Bangladesh has produced, a combination of robust pace, capacity to swing the ball laterally and supreme control.

E. clash next year. But while Bangladesh tore up the script in Darwin, rain added to the frustration of Shubman Gill & Co after a fruitful first day, and with rain on the radar for the next three days in Galle, the visitors have all to do to stay in the hunt.

After the events in Darwin, the difference between India and Bangladesh on the WTC table has ballooned to over 18 percentage points. India probably didn't expect Bangladesh to keep up their momentum, but Nazmul Hossain Shanto and his team have rapidly improved in Test cricket.

If events in Sri Lanka don't

go to plan, India could be mired in mid-table as their last two assignments in the WTC cycle are New Zealand away (always a tricky proposition) and Australia at home for five Tests, where they may need something like a 4-0 win to stay in contention.

As things stand, Australia (77.77%) still lead ahead of South Africa (75), New Zealand (72.22), Bangladesh (66.67) and India (48.15).

India may also not be able to rely on results elsewhere helping them too much, as teams in the top four play among themselves in most of the remaining series, so any points dropped by one contender will be taken by another. **ENS**

He has painted his country's cricket culture with a new identity. Moving on from left-arm spinners, Bangladesh is now a pace bowling country. Mahmud, Taskin Ahmed and Ebadot Hussain nailed all 10 of Australia's wickets in the first innings. In the second day, they claimed four, with Mahmud ejecting the openers and the centurion Cameron Green.

After they bundled out Australia for 198, the batsmen exhibited insuperable resolve to maximise the advantage. Another long-standing stereotyped Bangladesh myth was put to bed. That they don't exude Test-match temperament, that

they are feeble of both mind and technique. But Tanzid Hasan illustrated the skill and mind to compose a hundred of classical Test match virtues. Captain Najmul Hossain Shanto and Mehidy Hussain Miraz, who snared five wickets in the second innings, strung together valuable knocks to dispel the resolute comebacks the hosts are famed and fabled to produce. They did an Australia to Australia, to squeeze and strangle them to submission, to shut every door, window and crack of hope on their opponents.

Whenever Australia, toppers of the Test pile and favourites to nail the WTC final spot, tried to

force a comeback, Bangladesh didn't wither; rather, they stubbornly broke the resistance. They shed their inferiority complex. They remained unfazed when Steve Smith threatened to barge Australia back; they remained unshaken when Mitchell Starc & Co ratcheted up the aggression. Their spirit was tigerish, and not paper-tigerish as it once was. The emotions found the perfect balance.

Red-ball resurgence

The victory could be a symbolic moment in their cricket history—and just their second in a SENA country. It's the real coming-of-age moment for a country, since its red-ball debut at the stroke of the century never really seemed to crack the mood of the format. At times, they seemed to care less for Test cricket, obscured by the obsessive desire to find the tunes of shorter formats, where success was easier to find.

The resurgence could not have been better timed, for there has been a startling decline in competitiveness in Test cricket. If Bangladesh can go one step further and wrap up the series, the longest form of the game could smile after years. And the quaint and ancient town of Darwin would strike an emotional chord with Bangladesh's passionate cricket fans.

BRIEF SCORES: Australia 198 and 284 all out in 95.1 overs (Cameron Green 104; Mehidy Hasan Miraz 5/66) lost to Bangladesh 426 and 57/1 in 14.2 overs by nine wickets

Persistent rain dictates India's approach to victory

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 16

HAVING ALREADY lost plenty of overs and time to rain at Galle, India came out with a totally different intent on Day Two. Persistent showers since morning delayed the start on Sunday till 2.35 PM, pouring cold water on India's hopes of batting once and big.

So, they had to alter the game with an eye on the weather forecast. With rain expected to play a part over the remaining three days as well, the question now is whether India could find time to push for a win. In total, 54 overs were lost.

Having ended Day One at 288/2, India's intentions were evident. They wanted to bat much of Day Two and be in a position from where they can't lose the Test. With 460/9 on board, thanks largely to Devdutt Padikkal's 167, they can still manage to overcome the weather equations and win, but it will take some effort from the bowling unit. Unless they shut the hosts to a low total in the first essay, then the chances of enforcing follow-on looks bleak.

But the intent seems clear. It is the path that India are willing to take.

From the moment they came out to bat, the domination they showed on the first day was missing. While Padikkal resumed from where he had left off, for India to bat Sri Lanka out of the game, Rishabh Pant held the key.

During his brief stay on Saturday, he had been at his attacking best. Even on Sunday, he tried to keep the scoreboard moving in quick time. Resultantly, Sri Lanka took the new ball early, which seemed a gamble as it would allow India to score freely.

But Pant committed the same mistake as Shubman Gill did on the opening day. Like Gill, the intention couldn't be faulted. Debutant Keshara Nuwantha hadn't been at his best on his first day at office, but on Sunday he found the control with his length and speed. Watching Pant in a hurry, he was prepared to slow it down and by the time the left-hander charged down, he was nowhere close to the pitch of the ball. Yet, he committed himself to hoick, which was caught at mid-off for his maiden Test wicket.

That dismissal brought in KL Rahul, who had retired hurt on 77. Having done all the hard work against the spinners, he had an opportunity to wrap up



Dhruv Jurel scored 51 off 68 balls on Day 2. CREIMAS

his 13th Test century. But on a pitch that had been under covers, the Lankan attack found enough help.

Early on, Asitha Fernando managed to induce an edge, which went through the vacant third slip. Soon, Nishan Fernando came up with some exceptional reflex work at forward short-leg to give Nuwantha his second wicket. The turn and the bounce forced Rahul to play a shot he was in no control for the first time against the spinners. A score 82 off 175 was a commendable effort, but not a complete job. It was an innings synonymous with Rahul's career so far.

Different outfit

Once Sri Lanka found the early breakthroughs, they appeared a different outfit.

Dhruv Jurel, with Sarfaraz Khan breathing down his neck, didn't look in absolute control. Even to full deliveries, he preferred to defend or nudge here and there, seldom inducing assurance. But on the occasions he played with absolute clarity, he appeared a different batsman. Each of his four boundaries and a six was a message that he can be a specialist batsman in the long run. The dismissal, trying to nudge it around the leg-side only for the ball to find the edge and Dhananjaya de Silva coming up with an acrobatic catch, only showed his limitations.

Like Rahul on the opening day, he too received deliveries he could have swept. But it remained on the shelf.

Beyond Padikkal and Jurel, the rest came up with cameos. The two all-rounders Ravindra Jadeja and Manav Suthar tried to show their positive intent, but their innings were short-lived, on a 43-over day where India tried their best to take the game forward as quickly as they could. That they scored at

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA	
GALLE	
TOSS: India won, chose to bat	
INDIA (O/N 288-2)	
KL Rahul c Fernando b Nuwantha	39 (62b, 4x4, 1x6)
Devdutt Padikkal st Dickwella b Jayasuriya	82 (175b, 10x4, 1x6)
Dhruv Jurel c de Silva b Jayasuriya	167 (230b, 15x4, 1x6)
Ravindra Jadeja lbw b Nuwantha	51 (68b, 4x4, 1x6)
Manav Suthar c Udara b Jayasuriya	13 (25b, 1x4)
Mohammed Siraj c de Silva b Fernando	24 (43b, 2x4)
SRI LANKA	
Kuldeep Yadav not out	12 (13b, 2x4)
Prasidh Krishna not out	1 (4b)
EXTRAS (b 4, lb 3, w 1, nb 4)	12
TOTAL (116 Overs)	460-9
FOW: 307-3 (Rishabh Pant, 80.4 ov), 319-4 (KL Rahul, 84.1 ov), 357-5 (Devdutt Padikkal, 91.3 ov), 377-6 (Ravindra Jadeja, 98.1 ov), 432-7 (Dhruv Jurel, 109.1 ov), 447-8 (Mohammed Siraj, 112.6 ov), 447-9 (Manav Suthar, 113.1 ov)	
BOWLING: Asitha Fernando 17 1-61-1; Lahiru Kumara 13 1-76-0; Keshara Nuwantha 39 1-175-3; Prabath Jayasuriya 39 1-109-4; Dhananjaya de Silva 4 0-15-0; Sonal Dinusha 4 0-17-0	

four runs an over showed their intention. If not for some untimely wickets at the start, they would have probably ended up with a bigger score on the board.

On a pitch where turn and bounce are already manifesting, India would hope they would make most of the conditions. Once the groundstaff remove the covers, the overnight sweating could bring in seamers into the play. If they can make early inroads, they would be setting up an ideal platform for spinners to go full-throttle against an inexperienced batting unit.

Over the next three days, as much as the strip, India would be keeping their eyes firmly on the overhead conditions.

'There is no pressure', claims Jurel after scoring timely fifty

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 16

AHEAD OF the first Test of the two-match series against Sri Lanka, India had a selection puzzle to solve between the incumbent Dhruv Jurel and the returning Sarfaraz Khan for the middle-order position. The management went with the former, and the right-hander, who had scores of 19, 2, 0 and 13 leading into Galle, responded by making 51 on Day 2, before he fell to Prabath Jayasuriya.

Speaking after the day's play,

Jurel said he did not feel any pressure about his lack of runs coming into the game, and he looked at every chance as an opportunity to play for India.

"Not at all. Because, to be honest, I am very grateful that I have the opportunity to represent India. Whenever I go in, I think this is an opportunity to do something for India. So, there is no pressure. That's the only privilege that I play for," Jurel told reporters on Sunday.

The 25-year-old also revealed what India planned to do when play resumed in the afternoon.

"You can say that the plan was to make as many runs as possible. The plan was not that from ball one we are going bonkers. The plan was that we can make as many runs as possible by hitting on a sensible wicket. I, Rishabh bhai and whoever is batting down there can do that," he added.

With 9 sessions left in the Test match, India will need to bowl Sri Lanka out twice on a surface that is turning. Jurel admitted that India will have their task cut out for them to bowl Sri Lanka out twice.

LONG TIME COMING

Tanzid, Hasan and structural change behind an emerging force in Test cricket

Tanishq Vaddi
Hyderabad, August 16

"USKE SAATH mera relationship bahut purana hai..." (We go back a long way), said Hannan Sarkar, the delighted Bangladesh U-19 head coach, about Tanzid Hasan Tamim. The southpaw scored 101 in the first innings against Australia in Darwin, playing a pivotal part in Bangladesh's historic win on Sunday.

Tanzid's compact technique, coupled with playing the ball late, worked wonderfully well against the Aussies. One stand-out shot of his innings came when he was on 63 and square-drove Pat Cummins for a boundary. It was a shot from a batter who was in control and in sync

with the pace and bounce from the surface. His century was filled with such delightful strokes.

Sarkar has been watching Tanzid for the last 15 years and working on his game. "He has a strong technique for Test cricket," he told *The Indian Express*. It was only Tanzid's second Test, but Sarkar believes his success stems from five years of playing international white-ball cricket.

"When we travel to Australia, South Africa, New Zealand and Zimbabwe, we have to leave the ball well outside the off-stump, and that is Tanzid's strength; whenever he had the ball there for him to play his shots, he took it," Sarkar said.

Tanzid averages 40.06 in first-class cricket. Sarkar said Tanzid had taken to the red-ball format like duck to water and could bat for long periods to tire bowlers.

Domestic impact

Bangladesh has made structural changes in its domestic cricket in recent years, steadily improving the nation's red-ball ecosystem. "For the last 4-5 years, we have used the Dukes ball with the pace bowlers. The batsmen have faced tough times in first-class cricket...so, there has been improvement. That's the reason why we are playing well when we go to places like New Zealand and Australia.

"Earlier, the grass on our pitches was not compact, but



Tanzid Hasan scored 101 in the 1st innings against Australia. AP

now we are getting consistent grass on the wicket," Sarkar added. Bowling on bouncy pitches with the Dukes ball has helped them unearth new bow-

“ When we travel to Australia, South Africa, New Zealand and Zimbabwe, we have to leave the ball well outside the off-stump, and that is Tanzid's strength”

HANNAN SARKAR, BANGLADESH U-19 HEAD COACH

ling talent. Taskin Ahmed, Hasan Mahmud and Ebadot Hossain, who played at Darwin, kept the Australian batters in check with their precision

across different spells.

Hasan was the star, picking up nine wickets in the game. "When the pitches were not as good, we used a lot of spinners, but now with these wickets, faster bowlers are bowling 15-20 overs a day, and that was what the making of Hasan was," Sarkar observed. Travis Head chopped the ball onto the stumps, and it was that in-between length from Hasan that made the difference; the batter did not do either go forward or backwards.

"He is different from the others; he hits the pitch hard. He has also been a part of County Cricket recently, and that has boosted his confidence...He uses his wrist well, and that is

what makes him so threatening to face," Sarkar said.

Memory trip

Sarkar was the opener of the Bangladesh team which last toured Australia in 2003 and got whitewashed. "We were given Test status in 2000. So, it was a very early stage for our Test cricket. At that time, our thinking was that if we played with Australia for 3-4 days, that would be a big achievement," Sarkar laughed. "But now, we play to win against any team," he said.

"Even in domestic cricket in my time, we used to see players score a maximum of 3-4 centuries in an entire season. But now that number has gone up drastically, and you see cen-

turies and double centuries frequently," Sarkar said.

This decade has seen some historic results for Bangladesh. In 2022, they beat New Zealand for the first time in Mount Maunganui and in 2024 they whitewashed Pakistan in their backyard. Sarkar said wins like these could inspire the cricketing ecosystem in the country. "This is a good boost. When the top team achieves a good result, it boosts the rest of our system. It inspires them to do well, and targets also increase."

Despite Sunday's win, however, he concluded by sounding a note of caution, stating that the next challenge for the board and the players was to consistently deliver such results.



Anders Antonsen classified Delhi pollution as seasonal. EXPRESS

Don't mind \$5000 fine for skipping India Open: Antonsen

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

DANISH SHUTTTLER Anders Antonsen, who skipped the India Open Super 750 earlier this year due to pollution, expressed his satisfaction with the conditions at the BWF World Championships at the IG Indoor Stadium.

However, he mentioned that he won't come back if the India Open continues to be held in the month of January or February, because of the severe air pollution then.

"As far as the conditions go, the hall is pretty and practice facilities are good," Antosen told the media in a pre-tournament interaction. "I haven't been here for over three years. I pulled out of the India Open due to air pollution. I know there is a big difference in pollution season by season. Right now, it's fine," he added further.

Antonsen had paid a mandatory \$5000 fine for his India Open 2026 withdrawal. When asked if he will come back for the India Open next year, Antonsen said he won't mind paying the \$5000 fine if the tournament is held between January and March.

"Every year, when I see the calendar, I am like, okay, they are just instantly giving me a \$5,000 fine. I don't know if next year will be the same. I haven't really decided 100% yet," he said.

He added that it's not right to host the India Open in the heavy pollution season. "The pollution during that season is pretty insane. I don't think it is the right move for the BWF to host the tournament in January or February in Delhi. Hosting it around this time (August) seems much better from my perspective," Antonsen said.

Antonsen, who is World No. 4, is set to feature in the men's singles category and will be Denmark's medal prospect in the absence of former world champion Viktor Axelsen.

"No, I don't feel any additional pressure. The only pressure I feel is the one coming from within. I hold myself to high standards and I want to win and claim the biggest titles," Antonsen further said.

Deceptive calmness shrouds Delhi before storm unleashes

Reticent shuttlers are reluctant to do the talking, but over the coming week, their badminton will

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 16

AS BADMINTON'S biggest jamboree returns to India after 17 years, with the hosts anxious about pulling off a global event seamlessly, the top-tier athletes are offering their approval to an "improved arena," resembling humble invitees at the mercy of hosts.

They know about the monkeys and pigeons, but laud the efforts undertaken to negate all that went wrong in January. Perhaps, the venue mirrors their own tentative mindset in an injury-ravaged season with several top names neither completely fit, nor completely confident. Badminton, indeed, revels in its reserve.

At its grandest stage, it falls back on the opposite of boxing's trash-talk. It politely reveals wounds and weaknesses, lulling opponents. A day before the World Badminton Championship, World No 1 An Se-young had ice bags strapped to her left knee when she came to speak to the press. She insisted the lead-up has been solely about injury recovery and rediscovering rhythm. Her opponent Chen Yufei concedes compatriot Wang Zhi Yi is better prepared than her, and she's only just finding her way back into battle-mode. Zhi Yi, a potential PV Sindhu roadblock, stresses on how tough it is to play the Indian.

Neither Chinese will reveal their level of preparation in the bid to reclaim a title China has not won since 2011, because the murmurs over the elusive World title have turned into a clamour. Yufei claims her strategies have nothing to do with who the opponent is. Yet, at the mere mention of Akane Yamaguchi, her facial expression freezes in time. Clipped clichés about focusing on self, follow.

Men's singles No 2 and former champion, Kunlavut Vitidsarn almost concedes he is in a testing phase after an injury lull, and says the Delhi Worlds are not much more than a training pad for the Asian Games—a title he hasn't won. He acknowledges the new generation has increasingly made his life difficult, with the likes of Alex Lanier, Lin



Ayush Shetty's clash against World No 1 Shi Yuqi will headline Day 1 of the BWF Badminton World Championships. BAI

• Dark horses at Delhi Worlds



CHRISTO POPOV (MS), FRANCE

Ranked 5th in the world, Christo Popov is among the more improved men's singles shuttlers in the past few months. After comparatively easier opening rounds, he will potentially clash with Alex Lanier and Jonatan Christie. Riding on confidence from the Japan Open, there is a chance that Popov can medal.



PUTRI KUSUMA WARDANI (WS), INDONESIA

World No 6, Putri Kusuma Wardani can be the surprise package in an otherwise stacked women's singles. She defeated PV Sindhu in the quarter-finals of the last edition and went on to win the bronze medal. She is likely to face the home favourite in the third round on this occasion.



RAYMOND INDRA AND NIKO-LAUS JOAQUIN (MD), INDONESIA

The 12th-seeded upstarts from Indonesia can be a thorn in the flesh for any men's doubles pair. It has been a decent year for them, having reached the semis of All England and the final of the Indonesia Open. They might face the Indian pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy-Chirag Shetty in the third round.



LAUREN LAM AND ALLISON QUYNH LEE (WD), USA

The rapidly rising duo from the USA doesn't have a title to show, but has dished out consistent performances over the past season, with multiple semi-final appearances. They have a bye in the first round and could face the Indian pair of Tressa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand in the second.

Chun Yi and Ayush Shetty snapping at his heels. Kunlavut is from Lakshya Sen's batch and ought to have seen Viktor Axelsen's exit as an opportunity, but there's no dearth of Christo Popovs and Alwi Farhans waiting to dislodge him, already a seasoned senior. He is 25, and sport is seldom kind.

In men's doubles, there is hardly anything to separate the top 10. Former champions Aaron Chia and Soh Wooi Yik are reuniting in Delhi, having spent the last few months playing with different partners. "We are playing together for years, so tuning won't be a problem," Chia insists. Seo Seung-jae, arguably the most versatile player in Delhi and the only contemporary two-

gold winner at mixed and doubles, has his left shoulder in an iced plastic sling, and refuses to think beyond the Round of 32. He and Kim Won Ho lost next to nothing till April of 2026, but have tapered off at the last four tournaments. Even the boisterous Chinese, Liang Weikeng remains subdued, lacking clarity on expectations. These are serial medallists at the Olympics and Worlds, but it is not in badminton's DNA to talk up their own chances. They'd rather keep expectations low. In this sport, they hide the Jekyll.

The sweetest silence belongs to men's World No 1 Shi Yuqi, who has been handed the tall Ayush Shetty in Round 1. The Chinese declined to speak to the

media, even risking a hefty fine. In a rapid-fire, Ayush was asked who might win. "Ayush Shetty," he said with a straight face. He will need to walk and talk, because Yuqi won't. "Try to feel relaxed, and enjoy as much as possible," Ayush says of his pre-match mindset ahead of a World's debut.

The other Shetty, the older one with two Worlds medals already, is less emphatic. The Sat-Chi pair does think and analyse, but does not overthink and over-analyse. What do they, then, talk about before the opener? "If there are jitters, it's natural. It's better to voice it out," he says. Lakshya Sen guards against complacency. "We don't want to take it easy in the first round, so

we are more alert," he says. Sen tends to get better as tournaments progress. "Everybody has a chance, but I believe in myself."

PV Sindhu and Nozomi Okuhara are legends of World Championships. "2017 was my favourite because I was champion. But I have happy memories of 2019 (reaching the final) too," Okuhara says. Sindhu might have won at Basel, but as she chases her sixth, she is dialled into 2017's loss. "I was hard on myself after that loss. But it made me stronger," she recalls.

In badminton, regardless of the stature of the shuttler, one is likely to have a penchant for the lull. Delhi, hence, can only await the storm that follows. It almost always does.

Sindhu begins home Worlds with renewed vigour, confidence



PV Sindhu is gunning for her sixth World Championships medal. BAI

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, August 16

AS INDIA'S shuttlers gear up for the World Championships starting at the IG Indoor Stadium on Monday, the spotlight will once again fall on PV Sindhu and her quest to win another medal at the prestigious event.

The 31-year-old remains one of India's best medal prospects and will feature in a home World Championships for the first time and enters the competition with confidence, having won the Japan Open Super 750 title recently.

On the tournament's eve, Sindhu, who will face Sophia Noble of Ireland in the first round on Monday, spoke to reporters about expectations and the thrill of playing at home, her newfound confidence and evolution since her first medal.

Excerpts from conversation:

On playing at home:

I am very excited that it's happening in India after a long time. I haven't won for seven years; I hope I keep the confidence from the Japan Open and win here. The Indian crowd is going to support me, and playing on home ground is going to be great for me.

Evolution after first medal in 2013:

I have won five medals at the World Championships, and it has been an amazing journey. Every medal gave me a different kind of experience. The transition was such a way that it gave me a lot of confidence.

Confidence after Japan Open win:

Japan Open gave me a lot of boost and confidence.

Difference in women's singles:

Earlier, women's singles was more attacking and fast-paced, but now it's about staying on the court, staying patient and long rallies. When I look back at 2019, I'm much more experienced in terms of dealing with court conditions. I'm more adapted to situations when things are not

“When you get a new coach, it takes time to get to know each other. But now it is good, as we understand each other's requirements. It has started clicking for me, and we can see how the results have improved.”

PV SINDHU
ON WORKING WITH IRWANSYAH

going according to how I want.

Memories of 2009 Worlds:

I was a very small girl, and I used to come and watch matches from morning to evening. I used to watch top players, and it's great to see the journey when I experienced the best back then, and now I have been playing at that level.

On the new scoring system:

The new scoring system is going to be very challenging. In 21 points, you have time to come back, but in 15 points, you need to be on your feet from the word go. There is no scope for getting relaxed.

On using sports science:

As I mentioned, it was very important for me to have a sports science team. I have Wayne Lombard, Heera (physio) and Shreyashi (S&C). Sometimes the body is not 100 percent, but you still push. Injuries are unpredictable, but sports science helps in taking precautions to avoid them. The gadgets and the new metrics have helped me avoid injuries and see the changes in my movements.

On new coach Irwansyah:

My coach has been with me for the past 18 months. When you get a new coach, it takes time to get to know each other. But now it is good, as we understand each other's requirements. It has started clicking for me, and we can see how the results have improved.

{ HOCKEY WORLD CUP }

India make point against China in opener

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 16

ONE MOMENT, Navneet Kaur was holding off a defender inside the Chinese circle, turning sharply and finding the space to fire India into the lead. Minutes later, she was sprinting into her own half, winning possession and giving her defence a chance to reset.

That was India's afternoon in a nutshell. Nikki Pradhan sat in front of the back three like a sentry, reading danger before it fully developed and cutting off passing lanes as China pressed. Baljeet Kaur's explosive runs ensured the Chinese defence never had the luxury of settling into shape. Deepika Soreng attacked the baseline, slipping behind defenders and stretching the field.

And when China inevitably found openings, Savita Punia and Bichu Devi, who alternated the quarters, were there to keep India in the contest.

There were moments of individual brilliance throughout the match. But India's 2-2 draw against one of the World Cup favourites wasn't the result of one outstanding performance. It was built on contributions from every corner of the field.

India hadn't beaten China in their last four outings. Each defeat had been more damaging than the previous one. But this Indian team is different. The dressing room that once looked fractured has found some of its



Shilpi Dabas (C) surrounded by China players. HOCKEY INDIA

old rhythm; players seem clearer about their roles, and the defensive discipline that had been missing is now becoming a defining feature.

Sjoerd Marijne, back for a third stint with the team after his previous one ended with a fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics, has spent much of his time bringing that 'joy' back into the group. His four pillars have been role clarity, team unity, defensive discipline and precise finishing.

The FIH Nations Cup, which India won in June without losing a match, was an early glimpse of a programme beginning to yield results. The World Cup opener in Amsterdam on Sunday reinforced that belief.

Alyson Annan wanted her team to play fast hockey from the get-go. For much of the first half, though, it was China who were being forced to chase.

India took the lead in the eighth minute. India earned a foul at the edge of the semicircle on the right and Baljeet played the ball quickly towards Neha Goyal, who played it into the circle first time. Navneet received it under pressure, with a Chinese defender hovering over her. The forward from Shahbad didn't panic. Instead, with her back to the goal, she showed great positional awareness and pushed the ball hard and low to the far post, beating the defenders and goalkeeper to give India the lead.

They, however, couldn't hold on to it. In the 15th minute, Shilpi Dabas pushed Zhong Jiaqi inside the 'D', and the referee had no hesitation in awarding a penalty stroke. India challenged the call, but it was upheld, leaving them without their review and allowing China to equalise after Zhang Ying caught Savita.

The goal didn't swing momentum China's way. India deployed a half-court press to counter China's offensive push. They absorbed pressure and recoiled like a spring whenever a counterattacking opportunity presented itself. Deepika Soreng's goal came from one such move. India won possession and charged forward. Deepika made a penetrative run down the right flank, entered China's 'D', kissed the baseline and drew a foul to win a penalty corner. She then converted it, her drag-flick taking two big deflections before finding the back of the net.

China began the third quarter with a subtle tactical tweak. Their two forwards in the 4-4-2 formation pressed very high and operated in their zones, making India uncomfortable and smothering them for space. The tactic worked as China equalised again in the 39th minute, Ma Ning drilling a powerful drag-flick to Savita's right. But India held. They could even have won had La'rens miami found a touch to Navneet's cross that flew across the goalmouth.

India, however, seemed content with a point against an opponent who will be their biggest rival at next month's Asian Games. "It's better than losing," Navneet leamed after the game. "This was a learning for us. If we score early, we have to keep the lead. The match was a bit up and down but we are happy. The one point is a good result."

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 16

RIVALRIES in hockey usually come with labels attached. India versus Pakistan carries the weight of history and politics. Australia against the Netherlands is often sold as a clash between two modern powerhouses. Belgium taking on anyone from the sport's elite rarely disappoints.

Yet, the most underrated rivalry in world hockey might just be India versus England.

When they meet again at the World Cup on Monday, the fixture will arrive without the noise or narrative that accompanies the sport's bigger rivalries. But the recent history between the two teams suggests it deserves far more attention.

Start with the obvious point: these matches are almost always close.

The 2022 Commonwealth Games semifinal ended 4-4 before England prevailed in the shootout. Their meeting at the 2023 World Cup in Rourkela finished 0-0 after a fiercely contested battle. The Pro League encounters have repeatedly been decided by a single goal or a shootout. In fact, since the last time these two teams (either as England or Great Britain) met at a World Cup in the Netherlands back in June 2014, 11 out of the 24 games have been decided by a margin of one goal, while 10 have ended in a draw. There is



Both India, England have opened their WC campaigns with wins. H

rarely much daylight between these two teams.

Then, there was Paris. If there is one match that perfectly captures this rivalry, it is the Olympic quarterfinal in 2024. It also added needle to the duel.

India were reduced to 10 men after Amit Rohidas was sent off in the 17th minute. Against most elite teams, that should have been a death sentence. Against Great Britain, it became one of the finest performances in recent Indian hockey history. Harmanpreet Singh gave India the lead before Great Britain equalised. What followed was a defensive masterclass. India absorbed relentless pressure for more than three quarters of the contest, defended with extraordinary discipline and somehow dragged the game into a shootout.

England rivalry remains underrated

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 16

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• Number Plate

11

• Number of matches out of the last 24 between India and England since the 2014 WC that have been decided by a margin of one goal. 10 matches in the same period have ended in draws.

ophies almost guarantee an intriguing tactical battle.

There is also a broader shift that has transformed the fixture over the last decade. Until a couple of decades ago, this wasn't really a rivalry. England and Great Britain were the more established international sides. It was the 2-0 loss to Britain in 2008, in fact, that led to India missing out on the Olympics. That equation has changed. India's Olympic bronze medal in Tokyo and Paris, and the evolution under successive coaching regimes have brought them back into hockey's top tier.

If the last few years have taught us anything, it's that when these two teams meet, clear favourites are hard to find, comfortable victories are even harder to predict, and the chances of witnessing another classic are remarkably high.

INDIA VS ENGLAND, 6.30pm, live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar